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AI and
the Future
of Work

By Josh
Tyrangiel



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ILLUSTRATION BY
STEPHAN DYBUS

“With brilliant, original scholarship, Matthew Pinsker tells the sweeping epic of how Lincoln’s mastery of politics enabled him to quell an insurrection against democracy, liberate a people, and save the nation.”

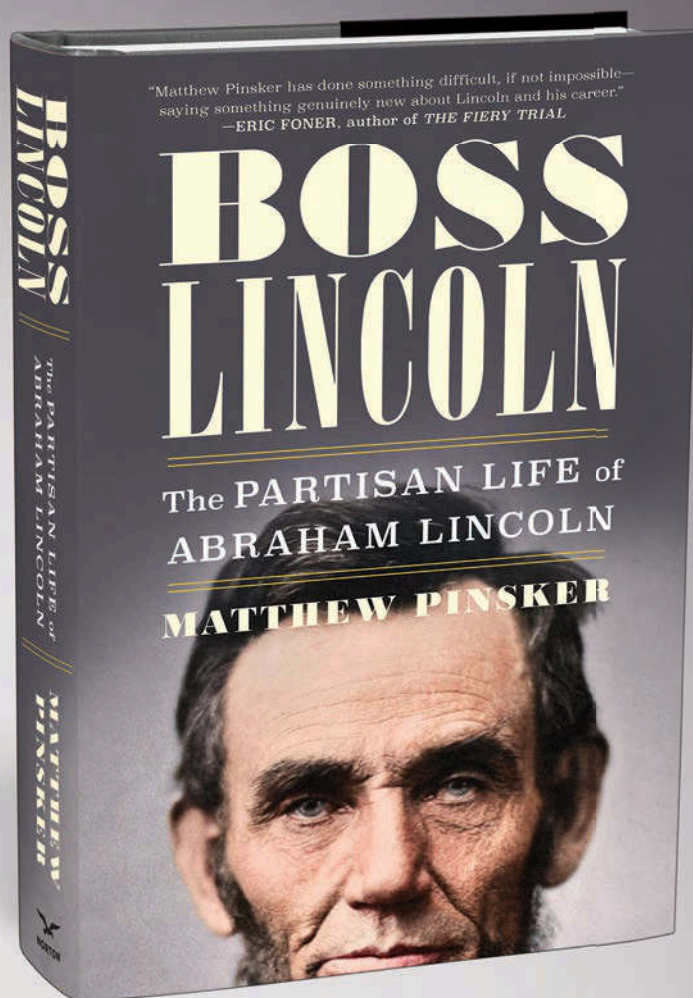
—SIDNEY BLUMENTHAL, author of *The Political Life of Abraham Lincoln*

“Pinsker reveals a pragmatic politician adept at building coalitions, doling out patronage, and, even, playing the dirty tricks of old-school politics. Vivid and persuasive.”

—ALAN TAYLOR,
author of *American Civil Wars*

“Pinsker gives us a ferociously partisan Lincoln for whom political parties are not driven by inflexible ideology but are flexible instruments for the pursuit of worthy ends. Readers who know Lincoln well will know him better thanks to this eye-opening book.”

—ANDREW DELBANCO,
author of *The War Before the War*



“Pinsker has done something difficult, if not impossible—saying something genuinely new about Lincoln and his career.”

—ERIC FONER, author of *The Fiery Trial*


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Behind the Cover: In this month's cover story, "What's the Worst That Could Happen?" (p. 18), Josh Tyrangiel reports on how artificial intelligence will change the American job market. The new technology has the potential not just to make workers more

efficient, Tyrangiel argues, but to render many of them obsolete. For our cover image, the artist Stephan Dybus evoked both the marvels of AI and a looming threat for which the American economy, and democracy, may not be prepared. — Paul Spella, *Senior Art Director*

THE

The Unfinished Revolution

*The November
issue examined the
founding of the United
States and brought
the nation's history to
bear on its present—
and its future.*

Letters

I look forward to the cover of each issue of *The Atlantic* as much for the artistry as for the bold message it conveys. "The Unfinished Revolution," however, struck me as, dare I say, revolutionary. I have the privilege of working with middle-school students, many of whom are learning about the American Revolution for the first time. Although we stress the importance of history's "forgotten" heroes—in this case, the women, African Americans, and Native Americans without whom the efforts of the great men of the era would

surely have failed—there are few, if any, images depicting them as equal to Washington or Jefferson. How inspiring for our young learners to see, in looking at Joe McKendry's exquisite tableau, faces that reflect their own. I typically treasure old issues of *The Atlantic*, but this cover I'll remove to display in a seventh-grade classroom.

Jenny Giessler
Fairport, N.Y.

Rick Atkinson's "The Myth of Mad King George" is a timely reminder that history is nuanced and rarely divides neatly between villain and victim. George III was not mad; he was methodical, conscientious, and tragically certain that duty and inflexibility were synonymous.

The American colonists' decision to frame their rebellion as a quarrel with a man rather than a system was brilliant from a

public-relations standpoint, if not exactly honest. By aiming their indictment at the King, the Founders converted constitutional disputes into a moral crusade. They could preserve their identity as Englishmen defending their rights even as they repudiated England itself. As Carl N. Degler wrote in *Out of Our Past: The Forces That Shaped Modern America*, the American Revolution was radical in its political outcome but socially moderate. It left intact many of the hierarchies it claimed to overthrow, because tyranny had been embodied in a single sovereign, not the structures that sustained him. Perhaps this helps explain why the Founders could prevent the radical promise of the Declaration from extending to African Americans and Native Americans.

Ethan S. Burger
Washington, D.C.

I've long considered myself a patriotic progressive, so I greatly appreciated George Packer's "America Needs Patriotism" and its lament over how many Americans have lost a love of their country. When I attended a recent "No Kings" march, I was surprised to see that by far the most ubiquitous symbol was the American flag. I saw big flags waving in the air, tiny lawn flags carried by moms and kids, flag bandannas, flags on T-shirts, and flags as capes, including one pinned with a sign that read THIS FLAG IS ANTI-FASCIST. Where was this constellation of red, white, and blue? San Francisco. This was quite a contrast to the 2003 peace marches against the U.S. invasion of Iraq, where an American flag among the protesters was as common as a necktie at a rock concert. Perhaps Donald Trump has had at least one salutary effect on American civic culture: He's convinced even the left to embrace the Stars and Stripes.

Jason Dove Mark
Bellingham, Wash.

George Packer implies that the left is as culpable as the Trumpian right for deep skepticism about expressions of patriotism. But he seems to conflate three different positions: (1) belief in core values such as liberty, equality, and democracy; (2) flag-waving support for, or loyalty to, one's own country; and (3) a belief in America's "essential decency."

It is perfectly reasonable to be skeptical of nationalism—to be, as Thoreau put it, citizens of the world first, "and Americans

COMMONS



DISCUSSION

&

DEBATE

only at a late and convenient hour.” You don’t have to believe America is decent; you can be critical of the disturbing and sometimes horrific qualities that America has represented over much of its history but still offer a full-throated defense of democracy, equality, and other values that should be aspirational for people everywhere.

Alfie Kohn
Belmont, Mass.

As the president and CEO of the Colonial Williamsburg Foundation at the time of the 1994 slave auction, I took particular interest in Clint Smith’s article, “What Is Colonial Williamsburg For?”

The idea of reenacting a slave auction originated with Colonial Williamsburg’s African American Interpretation Department, whose director, Christy Coleman, approached the foundation’s leadership and said that her team was not only ready to put on the reenactment, but wanted to do it. Knowing that it would be controversial, we agreed that the reenactment would be based on records of actual slave auctions conducted in Virginia during the period, and that we would make it part of our educational programming. I gave her team my blessing.

On the morning of the program, after *The New York Times* published a story about our plans, representatives from

the Virginia branches of the NAACP and the Southern Christian Leadership Conference, as well as local ministers and others who wanted the reenactment canceled, asked to meet with me. I listened carefully and told them that I appreciated that they had come. I explained that the reenactment was something that our African American—interpretive staff wanted to do, that we thought it was the right thing to do, and that we had committed to the staff and the public that we were going to do it. I reminded them that our mission was educational—we were doing this not to sell tickets, but to teach.

They listened but told me that they still planned to attend and protest. Several blocked the stage before the program began, but when the audience of 2,000 began to boo, all except one protester stepped down. Christy and her colleagues worked the program around him. The other protesters remained silent.

We did the slave auction only once; it was simply too emotional an experience for the staff. I fielded some complaints from donors, and lost a few, but never regretted the decision. It was the right thing to do.

Robert C. Wilburn
Pittsburgh, Pa.

I was particularly interested in John Swansburg’s article on “Rip Van Winkle” because Cornelius

S. Van Winkle—who originally published Washington Irving’s *The Sketch Book of Geoffrey Crayon, Gent.*—was the brother of my great-great-great-grandfather Peter Van Winkle.

Family lore has it that Irving got into some sort of heated disagreement with Cornelius, and got revenge by bestowing the Van Winkle name on his main character—a man unflatteringly described as having, among other things, an “insuperable aversion to all kinds of profitable labor.”

While I have no idea if there’s any truth to this hilarious tale, it’s worth noting that my Van Winkle ancestors were among the first Dutch settlers in this country, having arrived less than two decades after Henry Hudson sailed upriver in 1609. They came to live in present-day Albany, Rensselaer, and Hudson and Bergen Counties. I’ve always been proud to trace my roots directly back to the founding of our great

nation, regardless of my connection to its founding folklore. In his article, Swansburg writes that, by the end of the story, Rip has “become a link to the past, a living connection to the history that predates the Revolution.” I look forward to rereading “Rip Van Winkle” and once again hearing what he has to say.

Christopher Pollock
Brooktondale, N.Y.

Two days after we received the November issue, my wife, Cindy Whitman, a retired history teacher, completed a diorama version of Joe McKendry’s cover painting. She customizes Playmobil figures and found objects to make scenes to display in libraries and children’s museums.

Dave Whitman
Queensbury, N.Y.

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DISPATCHES

OPENING ARGUMENT

HOW AMERICA GOT SO SICK

*The health of a
nation reflects the health
of a democracy.*

BY VANN R. NEWKIRK II

In the winter of 168 C.E., the famed Greek physician Galen arrived in Aquileia, an Italian city on the northern edge of the Adriatic. The city had grown large since its founding as a Roman colony, but during the 200-year *Pax Romana*, its fortifications had been allowed to deteriorate. After an armed group of migrating Germanic peoples had crossed the Danube a year earlier, the Roman co-emperors, Marcus Aurelius and Lucius Verus, had rushed to the city, raising two legions and rebuilding its defenses; they planned to use it as a base of operations against the invaders.

Galen had been summoned, however, to help fight a different kind of invader. A plague, likely an early variant of smallpox,

had traveled to Aquileia with the troops, and held the city in its grip. The emperors fled, but Verus succumbed to the disease on the road to Rome. Galen tried to slow the wave of illness, but most of the people in Aquileia perished.

They represented just a sliver of the eventual victims of the Antonine Plague, also known as Galen's Plague, which killed at least 1 million people throughout the Roman empire. It was possibly the world's first true pandemic, and haunted the empire for the rest of the *Pax Romana*, which ended in 180 with Aurelius's death. The details of the pandemic—the exact pathogen, the true number of victims—are subjects of debate, and might never be fully settled. But some research has cited the Antonine Plague as part of a vicious cycle that hastened Rome's long fall. Food shortages, internal migrations, and overcrowding had already signaled a slippage in imperial power, and created a fertile environment for disease. The pandemic, in turn, spread panic and left behind mistrust, weakening faith in civic and religious authorities.

Men famously think about Rome every day, and political commentators have been nervously comparing Rome's fall to a potential American collapse since before America even had a Constitution. But Rome's example really does merit consideration in light of recent events. One of the better measures of a society's vitality is its ability to protect its citizens from disease, and the two often move in tandem; a decline in one may produce a reduction in the other.

Infectious disease is probably not an imminent threat to the United States' survival.

Still, after nearly a century of existence, the American public-health apparatus, which has driven some of the most remarkable advances in global longevity and quality of life in human history, is teetering. The country has lost much of its ability to keep microbes from invading its body politic, and progress in life expectancy and other metrics is slowing or even reversing.

It is tempting to lay these changes all at the feet of President Trump and his current health secretary, Robert F. Kennedy Jr., who together have shredded America's global-health organizations, drawn back public-health funding, fomented vaccine skepticism, and begun to dismantle child-vaccination programs. But the "Make America Healthy Again" moment is in some ways just another step in the long retreat of the civic trust and communitarian spirit that have enabled America's disease-fighting efforts. If this retreat continues, the public-health era—the century-long period of unprecedented epidemiological safety that has been the foundation for so many other breakthroughs—will come to an end. And that end will have dire consequences for this republic and its future.

IN JANUARY 2025, a hospital in West Texas began reporting that children were coming in sick with measles. The cases were initially clustered in a Mennonite community, where vaccination rates had been low in recent decades. But soon the outbreak spread around the state, and to others; the reported number of cases reached more than 1,800 by the year's end. As of this writing, the

outbreak is still ongoing, and America is in danger of having its measles-elimination status revoked by the World Health Organization.

On August 8, as the measles outbreak continued to make headlines, a man named Patrick Joseph White entered a CVS in northeast Atlanta and fired hundreds of rounds from a rifle into the CDC's headquarters across the street. According to Georgia investigators, White had been suicidal, and believed that COVID-19 vaccines were part of a conspiracy to sicken him and other Americans.

These were but two signs among many that something has broken within the systems that protect the population's health. Despite all of our advantages, the coronavirus pandemic caused more confirmed deaths per capita in the United States than in any other Western country, and our mortality rate's recovery has lagged behind others'. Life expectancy in the U.S. is lower than in other high-income nations, and the gulf is widening.

America is unique, and comparisons are difficult. The country easily outpaces the rest of the developed world in gun deaths and overdoses, both major mortality drivers here that have largely been accepted as the cost of being American. But even if you discount those peculiarities, plenty of other indicators are pointing the wrong way. Foodborne illnesses appear to be on the rise, including regular surges of norovirus. Deteriorating water-delivery and sewage systems have contributed to a growing number of outbreaks of legionella. Cases of tetanus, whooping cough, and

hepatitis A have also risen in recent years.

Many problems contribute to these shifts—insufficient investments in infrastructure, budget cuts in state and local health departments, the growing drug resistance of bacteria. Yet underlying all of the outbreaks, and even gun and opioid deaths, is a common theme: a declining sense of mutual responsibility among Americans. If the population could be analogized to a single human body, then its immune system would rely on a concert of action and purpose between each cell. When that concert stops, the body dies.

IN 1946, the year the U.S. Public Health Service founded its Communicable Disease Center, American life expectancy at birth was about 66 years. Malaria was rampant in the South, and fever diseases, tuberculosis, syphilis, and polio killed tens of thousands of Americans annually. Thirty-four out of every 1,000 children born in 1946 were expected to die before their first birthday, many from communicable diseases. America was moving toward modernity, but the risks people faced were of a different order than they are today.

The CDC (since renamed the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention) inherited much of its early mandate from a U.S. military campaign to control infectious diseases among soldiers fighting in World War II. The scale of the war effort had necessitated the creation of a health infrastructure on American soil—spraying for mosquitoes near the front lines in the Pacific wouldn't mean anything if soldiers caught malaria at home before deployment.

Responses to outbreaks near bases needed to be big and fast enough to account for car travel beyond military jurisdictions. When the CDC took over, it extended this paradigm—of coordination across long distances and disparate communities—to the civilian population.

The same year the CDC was created, the influenza vaccine reached the public, and international organizations, supported by the U.S., began a global push to eliminate tuberculosis. The agency worked to promote mass vaccination. It began a national disease-surveillance program, and shared intelligence with cash-strapped county health departments and state agencies. Wartime campaigns to coax and chide Americans into doing their part to conserve resources and volunteer for the war effort translated easily into pushes for vaccination and sanitation.

Before 1946, conquering disease would have seemed as much a subject of science fiction as putting a man on the moon. But since 1950, global life expectancy has risen by four years each decade. Smallpox has been eradicated, and polio and malaria cases have dramatically fallen. Within the past 80 years, there have perhaps been more significant advances in human health than there were in the previous 300,000.

On the home front, several generations have grown up on an American mainland without malaria, yellow fever, or typhoid fever; diseases like dysentery are medical rarities. Measles and polio, once routine scourges of childhood, were pushed back by millions of vaccinations. Life expectancy increased by more than a decade, to 78 in 2023. This

was a public-health revolution, on equal footing with any of the great agricultural, industrial, or information revolutions that have punctuated the past few centuries.

THOSE OTHER GREAT revolutions are often considered to be the result of technological advances—the plow, steam

widespread immunity. The real public-health revolution was first and foremost a change in the way people thought about themselves and their relationship to one another.

Epidemiology made a new kind of thinking necessary. Pathogens respect neither individuals nor borders. Vaccinations and other preventatives

public health nonetheless managed to carve out a large cooperative space. Before the 1940s, the United States was still reporting a relatively high number of smallpox cases compared with other similarly industrialized nations; it achieved total elimination in 1949. With the insistence of a growing public-health apparatus, it became common practice to wash our hands, to cover our mouths, to not smoke indoors, and to get tested—not just for our own benefit, but for the sake of the people around us. Parents waited in long lines to have their children inoculated, and enterprising physicians went to rural clinics to reach the last isolated clusters of unvaccinated people.

That is not to say America's particular system of public health was ever perfect. Owing partly to the legacy of segregation, the country never developed a universal health-insurance program, and maintains a fragmented health-care system in which both class and race still dictate much of a patient's access to care. Many people on the margins who have wanted to get screened for certain diseases or vaccinated against them have not been able to do so, because they cannot afford to or because no doctor will serve them.

And yet, sometimes through the insistence of those same people that America live up to the tenets of public health, the system has come closer to the ideal. As much as any other institution—schools, libraries, churches—the public-health system has helped propagate the idea of a commons, often working against historical inertia to curb the excesses of American individualism. That work



power, fertilizers, the internet. And certainly, the development of vaccines, antibiotics, and other medicines has played a tremendous role in the advance of human health. But vaccines for smallpox and some other diseases had been around for at least half a century before the 1940s, and had failed to create

against ever-evolving germs do not on their own guarantee personal safety—only eradication can do that. And eradication, it came to be understood, can be achieved only through local and global cooperation.

In America, where capitalist and individualist ethics have always predominated,

has always required energy and effort from the people. And so it has always been vulnerable, because that energy and effort could dissipate at any time.

There is ample evidence that this is exactly what is happening. According to the health-policy organization KFF, in the summer of 2025 just 83 percent of parents kept their children up to date on vaccines, down from 90 percent four years earlier. Cases are surging for several of the diseases covered by the national vaccine schedule. Tuberculosis cases are higher than they have been in a dozen years, and meningococcal disease is rising as well. Measles cases have trended upward for years too, even before 2025.

Over the past 50 years, American trust in the medical system has declined, as has trust in government, science, and expertise in general. The coronavirus pandemic exploded those trends, creating the world in which we now find ourselves. Public-health agencies did themselves no favors: They often gave out confusing and sometimes conflicting advice. Conspiracy theories grew quickly on social media, and measures such as masking became subject to partisan polarization. According to Gallup, a bare majority—just 51 percent—of Americans now favors government requirements for vaccines, down from 81 percent in 1991 and 62 percent in 2019. Most of the slippage has been among conservatives, and studies suggest that political ideology is perhaps the biggest predictor of vaccine rejection.

Medicine has kept moving forward, with some truly great results. Deaths in the U.S. from cardiovascular disease

are plummeting, and might see further declines with the advance of GLP-1 drugs. With the advent of better cancer-screening tools, survival rates are improving, and wonder-drug therapeutics for many conditions are now on the market. But personalized care of this sort is expensive, and does not keep us collectively safe from infectious disease.

Meanwhile, as viruses that once killed hundreds of thousands have receded from public memory, they have come to

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seem less fearsome. Owing to the near eradication of some diseases, there have been few real risks to the heretofore small portion of people who refuse vaccines. In this landscape, organizations such as the CDC, which once stood as unimpeachable examples of government competence, have become victims of their own success, appearing to skeptics to be inert or irrelevant.

This was the system as Trump and Kennedy found it last year, vulnerable and stripped of the halo of public

trust. Kennedy slashed agency budgets and stocked a key vaccine advisory committee with vaccine skeptics, then this past January announced a new set of childhood-vaccine recommendations that excluded coverage for rotavirus, influenza, and hepatitis A, which all now cannot be administered to most patients without a doctor's consultation.

Kennedy's biggest threat to public health comes from what he symbolizes. The MAHA movement derides expertise, overemphasizes personal commitment and liberty, and has embraced pseudoscience. This stance, mingled with Trump world's conspiratorial tendencies, has turned the CDC and other once-trusted institutions into targets. After the August shooting at CDC headquarters, hundreds of current and former Health and Human Services employees singled out Kennedy as a driver of the kind of rhetoric that had motivated Patrick Joseph White, referring to the secretary's previous insinuations that the CDC itself was hiding information about the risks of COVID vaccines.

MARCUS AURELIUS, the surviving Roman emperor, is mostly famous in our time because of his Stoicism. His philosophy encouraged the embrace of duty, not because of the expectation of praise or other material benefits but because duty is in itself fulfillment of the human condition. In his *Meditations*, he offered a maxim: "Do your duty—whether shivering or warm, never mind; heavy-eyed, or with your fill of sleep; in evil report or in good report; dying or with other work in hand."

It's hard to psychoanalyze a guy who lived two millennia

ago, but it's easy to believe that this particular admonishment may have come from his time as a plague fighter. In the face of Galen's "everlasting pestilence," Marcus had to rally the public and improvise, stocking depleted armies with convicts and ordering the digging of mass graves. He saw that the state was held up not just by the military or territory, but by invisible webs of shared sacrifice and obligation. In the end, the fortifications that mattered most were those that strengthened Rome against the invaders that could not be seen.

If the American state disintegrates, future postmortems are unlikely to focus much on measles, or on rotavirus vaccination rates. But the ability to beat back our more routine pathological menaces is a good indicator of the country's ability to take on bigger, more virulent threats. The thing about bacteria and viruses, our most ancient foes, is that they are always at the gates, waiting for lean times. Among them will be pathogens worse than the coronavirus.

In the main, the withering of public health might not anticipate a future apocalypse so much as it recalls a previous America, one where lives were cheaper and shorter, where good health was the province of a privileged few, and where epidemics regularly scoured the countryside and the city slums. What's spurring the slide now isn't a dearth of information or cutting-edge medicine. Rather, the precepts of a shared reality have been shattered, and with them the ability to act for a common cause. *A*

Vann R. Newkirk II is a senior editor at The Atlantic.

THE MYSTERY OF HENRY FORDHAM

How did my great-great-grandfather become a free man?

BY EUGENE ROBINSON

The librarian sat me in front of a microfilm reader and brought out roll after roll of film. I stayed there for hours, squinting to decipher the archaic handwriting in the *Free Negro Book*, which was published annually in South Carolina before the Civil War.

The names in each year's edition were alphabetized, but only roughly—all of the surnames starting with *A* came before all of the surnames starting with *B*, but Agee might come before Anderson, or it might come after.

I began with the 1848 edition, but there was no listing for a Henry Fordham. The same was true of the book for 1849. Same for 1850. But as I slowly made my way through the *F* section of the 1851 edition, I let out a shout that shattered the library's decorous hush: "Yesssss!" Then, quickly, to the startled patrons and librarians: "I'm so sorry, excuse me, I'm so sorry." And then, more softly: "Yes."

I had found him.

ON MARCH 27, 1829, a wealthy white planter and businessman named Richard Fordham purchased four enslaved African Americans from a woman named Isabella Perman. One of them was my

great-great-grandfather, a boy called Harry.

This transaction took place in Charleston, the port of entry for an estimated 40 percent of all enslaved Africans brought to toil in this country. A document recording the sale was filed with the South Carolina secretary of state several days later, on April 7. It does not say where in Charleston the sale took place—on the steps of the Old Exchange and Provost Dungeon, perhaps, or at the Cooper River docks, or in one of the thriving markets where people were bought and sold. The individuals bought by Fordham are listed as "a Negro boy named Harry and a Negro woman named Jenny and her two children named Hager and Margaret." For the lot, Fordham paid \$1,080.

Harry, whose proper name was Henry, spent 19 years as Fordham's chattel. The young man proved to be quick of mind and good with his hands: He mastered the art of blacksmithing at the Chalmers Street Forge, which Fordham co-owned. Henry's skills eventually made him Fordham's de facto right-hand man at the forge. On July 10, 1848, Fordham sold "a Negro man named Henry" to Otis Mills and Co., a grain-wholesaling business with multiple warehouses near the Cooper River docks. The

sale was recorded with the secretary of state seven days later. The company's eponymous founder, one of Charleston's richest men, went on to build the city's most luxurious hotel, the Mills House. The price he paid for my great-great-grandfather was \$2,000, a lot of money for a single Black man.

According to family lore, Henry had somehow circumvented the state's strict law against educating the enslaved and become literate. He had also become deeply religious. Not only had he learned to read the Gospel of Jesus Christ; he'd also heard the call to preach it.

A few years after being acquired by Mills, Henry Fordham was purchased one final time—by himself, when he bought his freedom.

I'VE ALWAYS KNOWN, through my family's rich oral history, that my extraordinary great-great-grandfather obtained his liberty at some point before the Civil War. For a long time, however, my attempts to find out exactly when and how he cast off his chains ran into dead ends.

When I was growing up, it never occurred to me to go looking for my family's history. It was already right there, all around me. My sister, Ellen, and I were born and raised in Orangeburg, 75

miles northwest of Charleston, in the house that Henry Fordham's son—a formidable man named John Hammond Fordham—built for his family in 1903. Anchoring the corner of Boulevard and Oak Streets, the house is a characteristically southern structure—one and a half stories, with white wooden siding, two graceful bay windows, four dormers poking through the roof, and a wide wraparound front porch that serves as an auxiliary living room during the hot months.

We knew that important family talismans lay in a big, black safe that John Hammond Fordham kept in the main bedroom. It looked like a cartoon safe, the kind that the Road Runner used to drop on Wile E. Coyote's head, and it was incredibly heavy, which is probably why it still sits there today.

When I was growing up, the safe was always closed but never locked. I was curious about everything, and so sometimes, while my grandmother was busy in the kitchen, I would peek inside. But the old, yellowed papers that I found didn't mean anything special to me.

Once I became a journalist, I realized that my family's house, documents, photographs, and oral history constituted an extremely rare gift. All of that material told an important story; I didn't know what it was, but I had the sense that I was destined to find and share it. Life and career had a way of intervening, however, and for decades I put off the exploration of my family's past.

I returned to those annals in earnest when I realized two things: First, that my family's history vividly traced the repeated cycles in which African Americans win a greater measure of opportunity, only

to have much or all of it taken away again. With the materials in my house and a bit of research—a lot of research, as it turned out—I could show this pattern in action, over two centuries. Second, I saw that our history is every African American’s history. Through slavery and emancipation, Jim Crow and civil rights, war and peace, all that Black Americans have ever wanted is a fair chance to pursue the American dream.

FAMILY LORE SAID that Henry may have arrived in Charleston from Barbados, one of the British islands in the Caribbean where Africans were “seasoned”—conditioned to the lash—in the sugarcane fields. When my wife, Avis, and I went on vacation to Barbados in 1996, I decided to look for traces of my family in the National Archives. We drove around for quite a while—on the wrong side of the road—until we found the place, which I remember as a graceful old building filled with natural light.

In a big reading room, we sat at a long table while helpful staff members, accustomed to visits from Americans seeking their roots, brought out materials they thought might help us with our search. A day of poring over records, however, gave up nothing more than hints and shadows. Discouraged, we went back to our hotel and I called Aunt Grace—actually one of my mother’s many first cousins—who was the family’s chief genealogist.

I had been looking for records of slave owners named Fordham, but she explained that the name hadn’t attached itself to our family until after Henry’s 1829 sale to Richard Fordham. Instead, she said, I

should look for a Black woman named Jenny—the “Negro woman” who was sold at the same time as Henry. Jenny’s previous owner, Isabella Perman, had the maiden name Fell. So I should look for a woman named Jenny who had some connection with those two surnames.

We returned to the archives, and a senior researcher named Shirley Archer helped us renew our quest, bringing out reels of microfilm and precious old ledger books recording births, baptisms, and deaths. We finally found a family named Fell that had lived in Barbados in the early 19th century, in St. Philip Parish. We also found a family in the same parish named Perreman—pretty close to Perman. And we found that on November 27, 1793, an enslaved adult named Kitty Fell was baptized at St. Philip’s Church. *She would have been the right age*, I thought, *to be Jenny’s mother*.

But we could find no record of Kitty having a daughter, and no record of Kitty being sold away to Charleston. We had bits and pieces that might fit together, but we couldn’t figure out how. English planters in the Caribbean kept meticulous records of the horses they bred and raced, but they couldn’t be bothered to keep even rudimentary family histories of the human beings they claimed to own.

IT WAS AUNT GRACE who learned that Henry Fordham had been sold to Otis Mills in 1848. And I knew Henry had been free before the Civil War and emancipation, because I found his name in the 1861 Charleston city census, appended with the notation *f.p.c.*—“free person of

color.” By then, I reasoned, he must have been a free man for some time, because the census showed that he already owned two wood-framed houses in the city. It must have taken him at least a few years to accumulate such assets.

But exactly when, in that 13-year gap between his last sale and his first appearance in the census, had he become free? I examined real-estate records, scoured the family Bible, searched archives in reading rooms and digital databases, looked everywhere I could think of—and didn’t find a clue. By the 19th century, manumission was essentially illegal in South Carolina, which did not entirely end the practice, but it meant there would be no official document recording the moment of Henry Fordham’s freedom in the secretary of state’s archives.

The South Carolina Historical Society, a private institution founded in 1855, is the first stop for researchers seeking information about the antebellum period. I visited its grand neoclassical headquarters on Charleston’s main thoroughfare, Meeting Street, several times over the years to look for anything about my great-great-grandfather that might pin down the date of his freedom. No luck.

In 2014, the society’s collection was moved across town to the College of Charleston so that the archives’ original home—a landmark 1826 structure known as the Fireproof Building—could be turned into a museum. Slowly, more records were digitized, or at least preserved on microfilm. In February 2023, I visited the collection at its present location, a hushed sanctum on the second floor of the college’s Addlestone

Library, in the hopes that more of the hit-or-miss manumission records from Henry Fordham’s time might have been cataloged and made accessible.

I was overjoyed when the librarians found a folder labeled with Henry Fordham’s name—but then immediately deflated when they brought it out, because I saw that it contained only a long, speculative, and largely inaccurate account of Henry’s life, compiled by a distant relative whom I’d never met. I was already familiar with that document, and I knew it said nothing about when Henry had liberated himself.

Finally, one of the librarians suggested that I look through editions of Charleston’s *Free Negro Book*. I’d had no idea that such a thing existed: a yearly list of free African Americans residing in the city who had paid the state’s poll tax. It was an exercise in data collection born of paranoia. The fact that Black people outnumbered white people in South Carolina during the decades before the Civil War meant that white officials lived in constant fear of a Haiti-style Black uprising. Free African Americans were a tiny minority—more than 95 percent of Black people in the state were enslaved—but it seemed to make sense that any rebellion would be led by conspirators with independent resources and the liberty of unsupervised movement. White southerners took great pains to keep track of men and women like Henry Fordham.

And there he was.

I doubt I will ever be able to find out the month and the day my great-great-grandfather became free. But I can be quite sure that he was still enslaved when free African Americans were counted in 1850—and

that he had become a proud, free Black man by the time the *Free Negro Book* was compiled in 1851.

EVEN AFTER SOLVING this mystery, I never stopped wondering about my deeper history, before the time of Henry Fordham. Who was my first African ancestor to set shackled foot on this continent? He or she had a name. He or she had a clan, a language, a culture, a faith. All of this history is forever gone.

There was nothing at all inadvertent about its disappearance. It was stolen.

Slave owners in the English colonies of the New World went to great lengths to sever any ties that their captives had with the past and with one another. Enslavers' fortunes and lives depended on being able to control the able-bodied Black men and women who outnumbered them—20, 40, 60 Black bodies crammed into slave shacks, versus

maybe a dozen white family members in the big house. Our captors could not allow us to feel confident in the strength of our numbers. They wanted us to feel powerless, ungrounded, disconnected, and thus easier to dominate.

I feel the absence of my deep, pre-American history. I feel it the way an amputee suffers phantom pain in a missing limb. I keep looking for what was stolen from me. And occasionally I glimpse what might be fragments of it.

When I was little, among the out-of-town visitors who

would occasionally drop by to visit my grandmother and great-aunt were two women from Charleston. I don't remember their names. What got my attention was that they spoke to each other in an incomprehensible, rapid-fire patois that definitely wasn't English. I learned they had been speaking Gullah (also called Geechee), a creole language based on English but laden with a hodgepodge of West African vocabulary, grammar, and syntax.

Gullah is possibly a corruption of *Angola*, a region from

Island, where Richard Fordham had his plantation and my great-great-grandfather grew into manhood—Gullah evolved as a lingua franca that allowed enslaved Africans from different cultures and language groups to communicate. Henry almost surely would have understood every word those women who visited were saying.

Somewhere in Africa there is a city, town, or village where Henry Fordham's progenitors lived and died for hundreds or thousands of years, where

and it doesn't narrow things down meaningfully.

The remaining 20 percent of my DNA comes mostly from Germany, with a small contribution from the British Isles—again, no surprise. The fact that part of my genetic inheritance comes from Europe makes me like most Black Americans: According to a 2010 study, “an African American individual in the United States has, on average, about 75–80 percent West African ancestry and about 20–25 percent European ancestry.”

Someday, perhaps, the collective human genome will be sufficiently mapped to trace my DNA to a specific Nigerian village or English hamlet. But the truth is that race has never been a biological fact. It has always been a social construct, which allowed the powerful to justify exploitation of the powerless. The elaborate fiction of race gave Richard Fordham the



A painting by the author's wife, Avis Collins Robinson, of the house that John Hammond Fordham built in 1903

my distant relatives walk the streets today. That place exists, and I know I will never find it. Still, I can get closer than was possible even a few years ago, thanks to DNA testing.

In 2022, I mailed away a saliva sample and waited, with no real expectation of an aha moment. When the results came back, I learned that 34 percent of my DNA comes from Nigeria, 20 percent from Mali, and another 26 percent from other places up and down the west coast of Africa. That doesn't depart from what I'd have predicted,

“right” to purchase my great-great-grandfather, and required Henry Fordham to purchase his own freedom. And it is race and racism that have kept me from knowing the names, let alone the hopes and dreams, of Henry's predecessors in my American history. So I begin with him. *A*

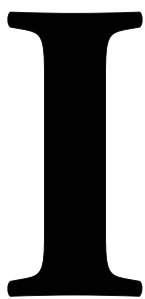
Eugene Robinson is a contributing writer at The Atlantic. This article was adapted from his new book, Freedom Lost, Freedom Won: A Personal History of America.



What's the Worst That Could Happen?

AI and the future of work

By Josh Tyrangiel



I**N 1869**, a group of Massachusetts reformers persuaded the state to try a simple idea: counting.

The Second Industrial Revolution was belching its way through New England, teaching mill and factory owners a lesson most M.B.A. students now learn in their first semester: that efficiency gains tend to come from somewhere, and that somewhere is usually somebody else. The new machines weren't just spinning cotton or shaping steel. They were operating at speeds that the human body—an elegant piece

of engineering designed over millions of years for entirely different purposes—simply wasn't built to match. The owners knew this, just as they knew that there's a limit to how much misery people are willing to tolerate before they start setting fire to things.

Still, the machines pressed on.

So Massachusetts created the nation's first Bureau of Statistics of Labor, hoping that data might accomplish what conscience could not. By measuring work hours, conditions, wages, and what economists now call “negative externalities” but were then called “children's arms torn off,” policy makers figured they might be able to produce reasonably fair outcomes for everyone. Or, if you're a bit more cynical, a sustainable level of exploitation. A few years later, with federal troops shooting at striking railroad workers and wealthy citizens funding private armories—leading indicators that things in your society aren't going great—Congress decided that this idea might be worth trying at scale and created the Bureau of Labor Statistics.

Measurement doesn't abolish injustice; it rarely even settles arguments. But the act of counting—of trying to see clearly, of committing the government to a shared set of facts—signals an intention to be fair, or at least to be caught trying. Over time, that intention matters. It's one way a republic earns the right to be believed in.

The BLS remains a small miracle of civilization. It sends out detailed surveys to about 60,000 households and 120,000 businesses and government agencies every month, supplemented by qualitative research it uses to check and occasionally correct its findings. It deserves at least some credit for the scoreboard. America: 250 years without violent class warfare. And you have to appreciate the entertainment value of its minutiae. The BLS is how we know that, in 2024, 44,119 people worked in mobile food services (a.k.a. food trucks), up 907 percent since 2000; that nonveterinary pet care (grooming, training) employed 190,984 people, up 513 percent; and that the United States had almost 100,000 massage therapists, with five times the national concentration in Napa, California.

These and thousands of other BLS statistics describe a society that has grown more prosperous, and a workforce endlessly adaptive to change. But like all statistical bodies, the BLS has its limits. It's excellent at revealing what has happened and only moderately useful at telling us what's about to. The data can't foresee recessions or pandemics—or the arrival of a

technology that might do to the workforce what an asteroid did to the dinosaurs.

I am referring, of course, to artificial intelligence. After a roll-out that could have been orchestrated by H. P. Lovecraft—“We are summoning the demon,” Elon Musk warned in a typical early pronouncement—the AI industry has pivoted from the language of nightmares to the stuff of comas. *Driving innovation. Accelerating transformation. Reimagining workflows.* It's the first time in history that humans have invented something genuinely miraculous and then rushed to dress it in a fleece vest.

There are gobs of money to be made selling enterprise software, but dulling the impact of AI is also a useful feint. This is a technology that can digest a hundred reports before you've finished your coffee, draft and analyze documents faster than teams of paralegals, compose music indistinguishable from the genius of a pop star or a Juilliard grad, code—really code, not just copy-paste from Stack Overflow—with the precision of a top engineer. Tasks that once required skill, judgment, and years of training are now being executed, relentlessly and indifferently, by software that learns as it goes.

AI is already so ubiquitous that any resourceful knowledge worker can delegate some of their job's drudgery to machines. Many companies—Microsoft and PricewaterhouseCoopers among them—have instructed their employees to increase productivity by doing just that. But anyone subcontracting tasks to AI is clever enough to imagine what might come next—a day when augmentation crosses into automation, and cognitive obsolescence compels them to seek work at a food truck, pet spa, or massage table. At least until the humanoid robots arrive.

Many economists insist that this will all be fine. Capitalism is resilient. The arrival of the ATM famously led to the employment of more bank tellers, just as the introduction of Excel swelled the ranks of accountants and Photoshop spiked demand for graphic designers. In each case, new tech automated old tasks, increased productivity, and created jobs with higher wages than anyone could have conceived of before. The BLS projects that employment will grow 3.1 percent over the next 10 years. That's down from 13 percent in the previous decade, but 5 million new jobs in a country with a stable population is hardly catastrophic.

And yet: There are things that economists struggle to measure. Americans tend to derive meaning and identity from what they do. Most don't want to do something else, even if they had any confidence—which they don't—that they could find something else to do. Seventy-one percent of respondents to an August Reuters/Ipsos poll said they're worried that artificial intelligence will “put too many people out of work permanently.”

This data point might be easier to dismiss if the modern mill and factory owners hadn't already declared that AI will put people out of work permanently.

In May 2025, Dario Amodei, the CEO of the AI company Anthropic, said that AI could drive unemployment up 10 to 20 percent in the next one to five years and “wipe out half of all entry-level white-collar jobs.” Jim Farley, the CEO of Ford, estimated that it would eliminate “literally half of all white-collar workers” in a decade. Sam Altman, the CEO of OpenAI, revealed

that “my little group chat with my tech-CEO friends” has a bet about the inevitable date when a billion-dollar company is staffed by just one person. (The business side of this magazine, like some other publishers, has a corporate partnership with OpenAI.) Other companies, including Meta, Amazon, UnitedHealth, Walmart, JPMorgan Chase, and UPS, which have recently announced layoffs, have framed them more euphemistically in sunny reports to investors about the rise of “automation” and “head count trending down.” Taken together, these statements are extraordinary: the owners of capital warning workers that the ice beneath them is about to crack—while continuing to stomp on it.

It’s as if we’re watching two versions of the same scene. In one, the ice holds, because it always has. In the other, a lot of people go under. The difference becomes clear only when the surface finally gives way—at which point the range of available options will have considerably narrowed.

AI is already transforming work, one delegated task at a time. If the transformation unfolds slowly enough and the economy adjusts quickly enough, the economists may be right: We’ll be fine. Or better. But if AI instead triggers a rapid reorganization of work—compressing years of change into months, affecting roughly 40 percent of jobs worldwide, as the International Monetary Fund projects—the consequences will not stop at the economy. They will test political institutions that have already shown how brittle they can be.

The question, then, is whether we’re approaching the kind of disruption that can be managed with statistics—or the kind that creates statistics no one can bear to count.

AUSTAN GOOLSBEE IS the president of the Federal Reserve Bank of Chicago, the Robert P. Gwinn Professor of Economics at the University of Chicago’s Booth School of Business, and a former chair of the Council of Economic Advisers under Barack Obama. He’s also one of the few economists you would not immediately regret bringing to a party. When I asked Goolsbee if any conclusive data indicated that AI had begun to eat into the labor market, he delivered an answer that was both obvious and unhelpful, smiling as he did it. The nonanswer was the point.

I’ve known Goolsbee long enough to enjoy these moments, when he makes fun of our shared uselessness. Economists are rarely equipped to give straight answers about the present. Journalists hate when the future won’t reveal itself on deadline.

We spoke in September, shortly after the release of what’s come to be known as “The Canaries Paper,” written by three academics from the Stanford Digital Economy Lab. By crunching data from millions of monthly payroll records for workers in jobs with exposure to generative AI, the authors concluded that workers ages 22 to 25—the canaries—have seen about a 13 percent decline in employment since late 2022.

For several days, the paper was all anyone in the field wanted to talk about, and by talk about I mostly mean punch holes in. The report overemphasized the effect of ChatGPT. Youth employment is cyclical. The same period saw a sharp interest-rate spike—a far more likely source of turbulence. “Canaries” also contradicted a study released a few weeks earlier by the Economic Innovation Group, which argued that AI is unlikely to cause mass unemployment in the near term, even as it reshapes jobs and wages. That paper was knowingly titled “AI and Jobs: The Final Word (Until the Next One).”

This was the point Goolsbee wanted to emphasize: Economists are constrained by numbers. And numerically speaking, nothing indicates that AI has had an impact on people’s jobs. “It’s just too early,” he said.

The question is whether we’re approaching the kind of disruption that can be managed with statistics—or the kind that creates statistics no one can bear to count.

A lack of certainty should not be mistaken for a lack of concern. The Fed’s mandate is to promote maximum employment, so the corporate pronouncements about imminent job loss have Goolsbee’s attention. But the numbers don’t add up. It’s possible that the labor market is softer than it looks, but that the softness is being absorbed within firms rather than showing up in the unemployment rate. If companies are sitting on more workers than they need, however—a phenomenon known as labor hoarding—you’d expect that to reveal itself as weak productivity growth. It’s as predictable as a hangover: too many workers, not enough work, sagging productivity. “But it’s been totally the opposite,” Goolsbee said. “Productivity growth has been really high. So I don’t know how to reconcile that.”

Productivity is the cheat code for a more prosperous society. If each worker can produce more in the same hour—more goods, better services, faster results—then the total economic pie grows, even if the number of workers doesn’t. It’s the rare efficiency gain that expands the pie rather than merely redistributing slices.

America has been on a productivity tear for the past few years. It might be temporary, the result of a onetime boost, such as the COVID-era boom in new small businesses. But with the special joy of someone paid to complicate everything, Goolsbee pointed out that general-purpose technologies such as electricity and computing can create lasting productivity gains, the kind that make whole societies wealthier.

Whether AI is one of those technologies will only become clear over time. How long before we'll know? "Years," Goolsbee said.

In the meantime, there's another complication. The immediate risk to employment may not be AI itself, but the way companies, seduced by its promise, overinvest before they understand what it can actually do. Goolsbee reached back to the internet bubble, when companies spent wildly on laying fiber cables and building capacity. "In 2001, when we found out that the growth rate of the internet is not going to be 25 percent a year, but merely 10 percent—which is still a pretty great growth rate—it meant we had way too much fiber, and there was a collapse of business investment," Goolsbee said. "And a bunch of people were thrown out of work the old-fashioned way."

A similar crash in AI investment, if it comes, would likely look familiar: painful, destabilizing, and accompanied by surges of CNBC rants and recriminations. But it would amount to a financial reset, not a technological reversal—the kind of outcome economists are especially good at recognizing, because it resembles a thing that's happened before.

This is the paradox of economics. To understand how fast the present is hurtling us into the future, you need a fixed point, and the fixed points are all in the past. It's like driving while looking only at the rearview mirror—plenty dangerous if the road stays straight, catastrophic if it doesn't.

David Autor and Daron Acemoglu are among the most accomplished rearview drivers. Both are at MIT, and both excel at understanding previous economic disruptions. Acemoglu, who won the Nobel Prize in Economics in 2024, studies inequality; Autor focuses on labor. But both insist that the story of AI and its consequences will depend mostly on speed—not because they assume lost jobs will automatically be replaced, but because a slower rate of change leaves societies time to adapt, even if some of those jobs never come back.

Labor markets have a natural rate of adjustment. If, over the course of 30 years, 3 percent of employees in a profession retire or have their jobs eliminated annually, you'd barely notice. Yet a decade later, a third of the jobs in those professions would be gone. Elevator operators and tollbooth attendants went through this slow fade to obsolescence with no damage to the economy. "When it happens more rapidly," Autor told me, "things become problematic."

Autor is most famous for his work on the China shock. In 2001, China joined the World Trade Organization; six years later, 13 percent of U.S. manufacturing jobs—about 2 million—had disappeared. The China shock took a disproportionate toll on small-scale manufacturing—textiles, toys, furniture—concentrated primarily in the South. "Many of the workers in those places still haven't recovered," Autor said, "and we're obviously living with the political consequences."

But AI isn't a trade policy. It's software. Even if it hits some professions and places first—a lawyer in a large urban firm, say, may feel the impact years before a worker in a less digitized industry—the technology won't be constrained by geography. Eventually, everyone will be affected.

All of this sounds foreboding, until you remember the most important thing about software: People hate it, almost as much as they hate change.

This is what gives many economists confidence that the AI asteroid is still at least a decade away. "These tech CEOs want us to believe that the market for automation is preordained, and that it will all happen smoothly and profitably," Acemoglu said. He then

STEPHAN DYBUS



made a disdainful noise from his Nobel Prize–winning bullshit detector. “History tells us it’s actually going to happen much slower.”

The argument goes like this: Before AI can transform a company, it has to access the company’s data and be woven into existing systems—which sounds easy, provided you’re not a chief technology officer. A trade secret of most *Fortune* 500 companies is that they still run many critical functions on lumbering, industrial-strength



mainframe computers that almost never break down and therefore can never be replaced. Mainframes are like Christopher Walken: They’ve been going nonstop since the 1960s, they’re fantastic at performing peculiar roles (processing payments, safeguarding data), and nobody alive really understands how they work.

Integrating legacy tech with modern AI means navigating hardware, vendors, contracts, ancient coding languages, and humans—every one of whom has a strong opinion about the “right” way to make changes. Months pass, then years; another company holiday party comes and goes; and the CEO still can’t understand why the miracle of AI isn’t solving all of their problems.

Every new general-purpose technology is, for a time, held hostage by the mess of what already exists. The first electric-power stations opened in the 1880s, and no one debated whether they were superior to steam engines. But factories had been built with steam engines in their basements, powering overhead shafts that ran the length of the buildings, with belts and pulleys carrying power to individual machines. To adopt electricity, factory owners didn’t just need to buy motors—they needed to demolish and rebuild their entire operations. Some did. Most just waited for their infrastructure to wear out, which explains why the major economic gains from electrification didn’t show up for 40 years.

NONE OF THIS IS REASSURING enough for the economist Anton Korinek. He’s “super worried,” he told me. He thinks that America will see major job losses—“a very noticeable labor-market effect”—as soon as this year.

“And then those economists you’ve been talking to, they’re going to say, ‘I see that in the data!’” Korinek paused. “Let’s not joke about it, because it’s too serious.”

Korinek is a professor and the faculty director of the Economics of Transformative AI Initiative at the University of Virginia. Last year, *Time* magazine put him on its list of the most influential people in AI. But he did not set out to become an economist. He grew up in an Austrian mountain village, writing machine code in 0s and 1s—the least glamorous form of programming, and the most unforgiving. It teaches you where instructions bottleneck, where systems jam, and what breaks first when pushed too hard.

He’d kept a close watch on developments in AI since the deep-learning breakthroughs of the early 2010s, even as his doctoral work focused on the prevention of financial crises. When he got his first demo of a large language model, in September 2022, it took “about five seconds” before he considered its consequences for the future of work, starting with his own.

We met for breakfast in Charlottesville in the fall. Korinek is youthful and slender, with delicate wire-frame glasses and a faintly red beard. My overall impression was of someone who’d rather be customizing Excel tabs than prophesizing doom. Still, here he was, saying the five words economists disdain the most: *This time may be different.*

The crux of Korinek’s argument is simple: His colleagues aren’t misreading the data—they’re misreading the technology. “We can’t quite conceptualize having very smart machines,” Korinek said. “Machines have always been dumb, and that’s why we don’t trust

them and it's always taken time to roll them out. But if they're smarter than us, in many ways they can roll themselves out."

This is already happening. Many of the least comprehensible ads during sporting events are for AI tools that promise to speed the integration of other AI tools into the workflows of large companies. Because many of these systems don't require massive new hardware or human-engineered system rewrites, the rollout time shrinks by as much as 50 percent.

This is where Korinek parts company with the rearview economists. If AI moves as fast as he expects, for many workers the damage will arrive before institutions can adapt—and each successful use will only intensify the pressure for more.

Consider consulting firms, which have always charged high fees for having junior associates do research and draft reports—fees clients tolerated because there was no alternative. But if one firm can use AI to deliver the same work faster and cheaper, its competitors face a stark choice: adopt the technology, or explain why they are still charging a premium for human hours. Once a firm plugs in and undercuts its rivals, the rest must either race to follow or be left behind. Competition doesn't just reward adoption; it makes delay indefensible.

Korinek concedes the two standard objections: The numbers don't show anything definitive yet, and new technologies have historically created more jobs than they've destroyed. But he thinks that his peers need to start driving with their eyes looking ahead. "Whenever I speak to people at the labs on the West Coast"—Korinek is an unpaid member of Anthropic's economic advisory council—"it does not strike me that they are trying to artificially hype what they're producing. I usually have the sense that they are just as terrified as I am. We should at least consider the possibility that what they are telling us may come true."

Korinek is not sure that the technology itself can be steered by policy, but he wants more economists doing scenario planning so that policy makers aren't caught flat-footed—because mass job loss doesn't just mean unemployment; it means missed loan payments, cascading defaults, shrinking consumer demand, and the kind of self-reinforcing downturn that can transform a shock into a crisis, and a crisis into the decline of an empire.

AFTER THE BRIEF period in early 2025 when CEOs were openly volunteering "thought leadership" about AI and its impact on their workforces and profit margins, the pronouncements stopped, eerily, at roughly the same time. Anyone who has seen a shark fin break the water and then disappear knows this is not reassuring.

The simple explanation comes courtesy of the Bureau of Labor Statistics. America employs about 280,590 public-relations specialists, an increase of 69 percent over the past two decades. (They outnumber journalists almost 7 to 1.) It's not hard to imagine their expert syllogism: AI is unpopular. CEOs who talk about job cuts are even less popular. So maybe shut up about AI and jobs?

In October, the day after *The New York Times* revealed Amazon executives' plan to potentially automate more than 600,000 jobs by 2033, the PR chief at a large multinational firm told me, "We are so done speaking about this." It was at least a small piece

of history—the first time I'd been asked to grant anonymity to someone so they could explain, on the record, that they would no longer be speaking at all.

All of which is to say that the chief executives of Walmart, Amazon, Ford, and other *Fortune* 100 companies, as well as executives from rising AI-driven firms including Anthropic, Stripe, and Waymo—people who had been remarkably chatty about AI and jobs a few months earlier—declined or ignored multiple interview requests for this story. Even the Business Roundtable, an association of 200 CEOs from America's most powerful companies that exists to speak for its members on exactly these kinds of issues, told me that its CEO, former George W. Bush White House Chief of Staff Joshua Bolten, had nothing to say.

Of course, telling a reporter you won't speak on the record isn't the same as not speaking. The CEOs are talking to at least one person: Reid Hoffman, the co-founder of LinkedIn and a Microsoft board member. Hoffman is a technologist by pedigree and an optimist by temperament. He knows everyone in corporate America, and everyone knows he knows everyone, which makes him Silicon Valley's favorite mensch—a reasonable, neutral sounding board whom CEOs can go to when they want to think out loud. He told me that AI has sorted the CEOs into three groups.

The first are the dabblers: latecomers finally spending some quality time with their chief technology officers. The second rushed to declare themselves AI leaders out of vanity or a desire to have their traditional businesses taken more seriously by tech snobs. "They're like, *Look at me! I'm important! I'm central here.* But they're not actually doing anything yet," Hoffman said. "They're just like, *Put me at the AI table too.*" The third group is different: executives who are quietly making transformational plans. "These are the ones who see it coming. And to their credit, I think a lot of them want to figure out how to help their whole workforce transition with this through education, reskilling, or training."

But what all three groups share is a belief that investors—after years of hearing about AI's promise—have lost patience with dreaming. This year, they expect results. And the fastest way for a CEO to produce results is to cut head count. Layoffs, Hoffman said, are inevitable. "A lot of them have convinced themselves this only ends one way. Which I think is a failure of the imagination."

Hoffman doesn't waste time urging CEOs not to make cuts; he knows they will. "What I tell them is that you need to be presenting paths and ideas for how to get benefits from AI that aren't just cutting costs. How do you get more revenue? How do you help your people transition to being more effective using AI?"

"It's a fever," Gina Raimondo, the former governor of Rhode Island and commerce secretary under Joe Biden, told me, referring to the rush to cut jobs. "Every CEO and every board feels like they need to go faster. 'We have 40,000 people doing customer service? Take it down to 10,000. AI can handle the rest.' If the whole thing is about moving fast with your eye strictly on efficiency, then an awful lot of people are going to get really hurt. And I don't think this country can handle that, given where we already are."

Like Hoffman, Raimondo occupies an unusual niche: a Democrat who can walk into a boardroom without setting off the

cultural metal detectors. She co-founded a venture-capital firm, and AI executives, who see her as pragmatic and fluent in tech, are willing to talk to her. “This is a technology that will make us more productive, healthier, more sustainable,” Raimondo said. “But only if we get very serious about managing the transition.”

Last summer, Raimondo made the trip to Sun Valley, Idaho, for the four-day Allen & Co. conference known as “summer camp for billionaires.” She asked people the same two questions: How are you using AI? And what happens to your workers when you do? A number of CEOs admitted that they felt trapped. Wall Street expects them to replace human labor with AI; if they don’t do it, they’ll be the ones out of a job. But if they all order mass job eliminations, they know the consequences will be enormous—for their workforces, for the country, and for their own humanity.

Raimondo’s response was that “it’s the responsibility of the country’s most powerful CEOs to help figure this out.” She sees the possibility of “new public-private partnerships at scale. Imagine if we could get companies to take ownership over the retraining and redeployment of people they lay off.”

She knows how this sounds. “A lot of people say, ‘Oh, Gina, you’re naive. Never going to happen.’ Okay. But I’m telling you it’s the end of America as we know it if we don’t use this moment to do things differently.”

If executives’ concern is as genuine as Raimondo thinks, then perhaps they can be moved to action. Liz Shuler, the president of the AFL-CIO, is trying—and mostly failing—to do just that. CEOs and tech leaders are so focused on winning the AI race that “working people are an afterthought,” she told me.

Shuler’s aware that this is a predictable take from a union leader, so she volunteered a concession: “Most working people, and especially union leaders, start out with a panic, right? Like, *Wow, this is going to basically obliterate all jobs and everyone’s going to be left without a safety net and we have to put a stop to it*—which we know is not going to happen.” Instead of panicking, Shuler said, she talked with the leaders of the AFL-CIO’s unions, representing about 15 million people, and pushed them to use the brief moment before AI is imposed on them to figure out what they want from the technology—and what they might be prepared to trade for that.

So far the olive branch has been grabbed by precisely one company. Microsoft has agreed to bring workers into conversations about developing AI and guardrails around it. Most remarkably, the deal includes a neutrality agreement that allows workers to freely form unions without retaliation—something that’s never been done before in tech. “We think it’s a model,” Shuler said. “We would love to see others acknowledge that working people are central to this debate and to our future.”

Squint and you might convince yourself that the Microsoft deal is indeed proof of concept. More likely, it’s an anomaly.

Because all the coaxing, reasonableness, and appeals to patriotism and shared humanity are battling a truth as old as wage labor: American capitalism rushes toward efficiency the way water flows downhill—inevitably, indifferently, and with predictable consequences for whoever happens to be standing at the bottom. And with AI, for the first time, capital has a tool that promises the kind of near-limitless productivity the factory and mill owners could never have imagined: maximum efficiency with a minimum number of employees to demand a share of the gains.

Mass job loss doesn’t just mean unemployment; it means cascading defaults, shrinking consumer demand, and the kind of self-reinforcing downturn that can transform a shock into a crisis, and a crisis into the decline of an empire.

In that context, the silence of the CEOs takes on a different resonance. It could be a cold acknowledgment that the decisions have already been made—or a muffled plea for the government to save them from themselves.

AND SO TO WASHINGTON.

You’re probably aware that our politics are unbearable at the moment. And yet the only way to make them bearable—to recover the glimmer of promise at their core—is more politics. That’s the joke at the heart of Washington: The very struggle that’s hollowed the place out is also the only way it can be renewed.

If there were ever an issue capable of relieving the national migraine—something large enough and urgent enough—you might assume the future of American jobs would be it. “At least from my interactions here in the Senate, not many people are talking about it,” Gary Peters, the senior senator from Michigan, told me. “There’s a general attitude among my colleagues”—Peters, a Democrat, singles out Republicans, though he says there’s blame to go around—“like, *We don’t need to do anything. It’s going to be fine. In fact, the government should just stay out of it. Let industry move forward and continue to innovate.*”

It’s hard to slow AI without abdicating America’s tech supremacy to China—a point the tech lobby makes with religious fervor. It’s hard to force AI labs to give advance notice of the consequences of their deployments when they often don’t know themselves. You could regulate the use of job-displacing AI, but enforcement would require a regulatory apparatus that doesn’t exist and technical expertise the government doesn’t have.

That said, the government has a decades-old playbook on how to get workers through economic shocks. And Peters has been banging his head on his desk trying to get Congress to use it.

Since 1974, when the United States began opening its economy more aggressively to global trade, the Trade Adjustment Assistance program has helped more than 5 million people with retraining, wage insurance, and relocation grants, at a cost in recent years of roughly half a billion dollars annually. In 2018, Peters co-sponsored the TAA for Automation Act, which would have extended the same benefits to workers squeezed by AI and robotics. It died quietly, as many things in Congress do. In 2022, authorization for the TAA expired, and in a Congress allergic to trade votes and new spending, Peters's efforts to revive it have gone nowhere.

This is very stupid. The United States has about 700,000 unfilled factory and construction jobs. (Ironically, one of the few things slowing AI is a shortage of HVAC technicians qualified to install cooling systems in data centers.) Jim Farley, the Ford CEO who predicted that half of white-collar jobs could disappear in a decade, has been saying that the auto industry is short hundreds of thousands of technicians to work in dealerships—jobs that sit in a long-term sweet spot: technical enough to earn six figures, and dependent on precise manual dexterity that makes them hard to roboticize. But someone has to pay for the months of training the jobs require. “These are really good jobs,” Peters said. But “we spend a lot more money from the federal government for four-year higher-education institutions than we do for skilled-training programs.”

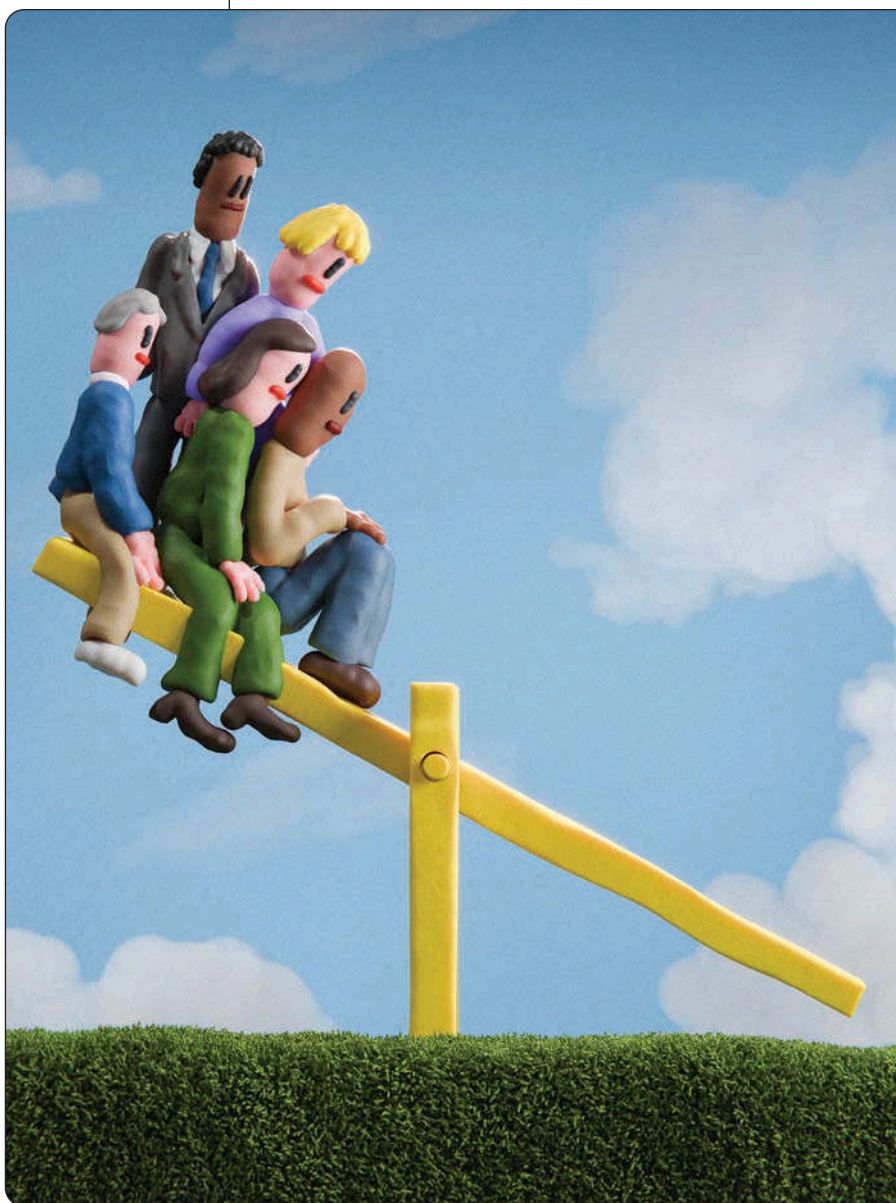
There's no shortage of ideas about what to do if AI hollows out large swaths of work: universal basic income, benefits that don't depend on employers, lifelong retraining, a shorter workweek. They tend to surface whenever technological anxiety spikes—and to recede just as reliably, undone by cost, politics, or the simple fact that they would require a level of coordination the United States has not managed in decades.

The 119th Congress is a ghost ship, steered by ennui and the desire to evade hard choices. And the AI industry is paying millions of dollars to make sure no one grabs the wheel. To cite just one example, a super PAC called Leading the Future—which has reportedly secured \$50 million in commitments from the Silicon Valley venture-capital firm Andreessen Horowitz and \$50 million more from the OpenAI co-founder Greg Brockman and his wife, Anna—plans to “aggressively oppose”

candidates from both parties who threaten the industry's priorities, which boil down to: Go fast. No, faster.

Shuler told me that the AFL-CIO will keep pressing national elected officials for a worker-focused AI agenda, but that “this game is not gonna be played at the federal level as much as it will be at the state level.” More than 1,000 AI bills are bubbling up in statehouses. Of course, the AI money will be there, too; Leading the Future has already announced plans to focus its efforts on New York, California, Illinois, and Ohio.

The executive branch has delegated almost all of its AI oversight to David Sacks—nominally a co-chair of the President's Council of Advisors on Science and Technology, but functionally a government LARPer who maintains his role as a venture capitalist and podcast host. Sacks, who is also the White House crypto czar, co-wrote the Trump administration's “America's AI Action Plan.” A *New York Times* investigation found that Sacks has at least 449 investments



STEPHAN DYBUS

in companies with ties to artificial intelligence. The fox isn't just guarding the henhouse; he's livestreaming the feast.

AI IS JUST a newborn. It may grow up to transform our lives in unimaginably good ways. But it has also introduced profound questions about safety, inequality, and the viability of a wage-labor system that, despite its flaws, spawned the most prosperous society in human history. And there's no sign—none—that our political system is equipped to deal with what's coming.

Which means the deepest challenge AI poses may not be to jobs at all.

"Gosh, the textbook ideal of democracy," says Nick Clegg, "is the peaceful articulation and resolution of differences that otherwise might take a more disruptive or violent form. So you'd like to think that a strong democracy could digest these kinds of changes."

Clegg is a former deputy prime minister of the United Kingdom and leader of the Liberal Democrats. When he lost his seat in Parliament after Brexit, he moved to California, where he spent seven years running global affairs at Facebook/Meta, becoming a kind of Tocqueville with vested options, before returning to London in 2025. Many governments "just don't have the levers" to deal with AI, Clegg told me.

He suspects that the societies best positioned to navigate the next few years are small homogenous ones like the Scandinavians, who are capable of having mature conversations—they'll put together "some commission led by some very wise former finance minister who will come up with a perfect blueprint which everybody consensually will then do, and they will remain in a hundred years the happiest societies"—or large authoritarian ones that refuse to have conversations at all. China, America's primary AI rival, has repeatedly demonstrated a capacity to impose rapid, society-wide change (the one-child policy, the forced relocation of more than 1 million people for the Three Gorges Dam) without consent or delay.

"If democratic governments drift into this period, which may require much more rapid change than they currently appear to be capable of delivering," Clegg warned, "then democracy is not going to pass this test with flying colors."

He then delivered, over Zoom, a fantastically British pep talk, combining Churchillian resolve with a faintly patronizing nod to America's centuries-long streak of pulling four-leaf clovers out of its ass. "You are extraordinarily dynamic," he began. "It's remarkable the number of times people have written off America."

If politics is to be part of the solution, Gary Peters will not be around to participate; he's retiring next year. Marjorie Taylor Greene, Congress's most articulate Republican advocate (really) for safeguarding the workforce from AI, has already resigned. Gina Raimondo is being considered as a potential presidential contender for 2028, and she's a centrist with the chops to balance the reasons for speeding forward on AI with the need to do so warily. But the issue is unlikely to wait that long. "We're going into a world that seems to be getting more unstable with each and every day," Peters said. "And that uncertainty creates anxiety, and anxiety leads to sometimes dramatic shifts in how people act and how they vote."

Which brings us to Bernie Sanders, who has been wrestling with an AI-shaped future since it was still theoretical. "Are AI and robotics inherently evil or terrible? No," Sanders told me in his familiar staccato. "We are already seeing positive developments in terms of health care, the manufacturing of drugs, diagnoses of diseases, etc. But here is the simple question: Who is going to benefit from this transformation?"

At the Davenport, Iowa, stop on his 2025 Fighting Oligarchy tour, audience members booed when he mentioned AI. And Sanders, the ultimate vibes politician, can feel decades of anger—over trade, inequality, affordability, systematic unfairness, government fealty to corporations—coalescing around AI.

In October, he issued a 95 theses-style report on AI and employment. It included all of the dire CEO and consulting-firm quotes about the looming job apocalypse and proposed a shorter workweek; worker protections; profit sharing; and an unspecified "robot tax on large corporations," whose revenue would be used "to benefit workers harmed by AI." It's a furious document, as though Sanders typed it with his fists.

At least one populist politician thinks Sanders didn't go far enough.

Steve Bannon's D.C. townhouse is so close to the Supreme Court that you can read *JUSTICE THE GUARDIAN OF LIBERTY* from the top step. He greeted me in his signature look: camouflage cargo pants, a black shirt, also a brown shirt, also a black button-down shirt. He hadn't shaved in days. It would not have surprised me if he suggested that we get hoagies, or form a militia.

Bannon has, shall we say, some scoundrel-like tendencies. But he's not an AI tourist. In the early 2000s, while still a film producer, he tried to buy the rights to Ray Kurzweil's *The Singularity Is Near*, a sacred text of the AI movement that imagines the day when machines surpass human intelligence. Bannon thought it would make a good documentary. He hired an AI correspondent for his *War Room* podcast a few years ago, and he tracks every corporate-layoff announcement, searching for omens.

He's concerned about rogue AI creating viruses and seizing weapons—fears that are shared more soberly by national-security officials, biosecurity researchers, and some notable AI scientists—but he believes the American worker is in such imminent danger that he's prepared to toss away parts of his ideology. "I'm for the deconstruction of the administrative state, but I'm not an anarchist," Bannon told me. "You do have to have a regulatory apparatus. If you don't have a regulatory apparatus for this, then fucking take the whole thing down, right? Because this is what the thing was built for."

What Bannon wants goes beyond regulation. It's a callback to an old idea: that when the government deems a technology strategically vital, it should own part of it—much as it once did with railroads and, briefly, banks during the 2008 financial crisis. He pointed to what he called Donald Trump's "brilliant" decision to have the federal government take a 9.9 percent stake in Intel in August. But the stake in AI would need to be much greater, he believes—something commensurate with the scale of federal support flowing to AI companies.

"I don't know—50 percent as a starter," Bannon said. "I realize the right's going to go nuts." But the government needs to put people with good judgment on these companies' boards, he said. "And you have to drill down on this *now, now, now*."

Instead, he warned, we have "the worst elements of our system—greed and avarice, coupled with people that just want to grasp raw power—all converging."

I pointed out that the person overseeing this convergence is the same man Bannon helped get elected, and recently suggested should stick around for a third term.

"President Trump's a great business guy," Bannon said. But he's getting "selective information" from Elon Musk, David Sacks, and others who Bannon thinks hopped aboard the Trump bandwagon only to maximize their profit and control of AI. "If you noticed, these guys are not jumping around when I say 'Trump '28.' I don't get an 'atta-boy.'" He said that "they've used Trump," and that he sees a major schism coming within the Republican Party.

Bannon's politics don't naturally lend themselves to cross-party coalition building, but AI has scrambled even his sense of the boundaries. He and Glenn Beck signed a letter demanding a ban on the development of superintelligent AI, out of fear that systems smarter than humans cannot be reliably contained; they were joined by eminent academics and former Obama-administration officials—"lefties that would rather spit on the floor than say Steve Bannon is with them on anything." And he's been sketching out a theory of the coalition needed to confront what's coming. "These ethicists and moral philosophers—you have to combine that together with, quite frankly, some street fighters."

Horseshoe issues—where the far right and far left touch—are rare in American politics. They tend to surface when something highly technical (the gold standard in 1896, or the subprime crisis of 2008) alchemizes into something emotional (William Jennings Bryan's "cross of gold," the Tea Party). That's populism. And the threat of pitchforks has occasionally made American capitalism more humane: The eight-hour workday, weekends, and the minimum wage all emerged from the space between reform and revolution.

No one understands or exploits that shaggy zone quite like Bannon. His anger about AI can sound reasonable in one breath and menacing in the next. We were discussing some of the men who run the most powerful AI labs when he said, "Let's just be blunt": "We're in a situation where people on the spectrum that are not, quite frankly, total adults—you can see by their behavior that they're not—are making decisions for the species. Not for the country. For the species. Once we hit this inflection point, there's no coming back. That's why it's got to be stopped, and we may have to take extreme measures."

The trouble with pitchforks is that once you encourage everyone to grab them, there's no end to the damage that might be

done. And unlike in earlier eras, we're now a society defined by two objects: phones that let everyone see exactly how much better other people have it, and guns should they decide to do something about it.

America would be better off if its elites could act responsibly without being terrified. If CEOs remembered that citizens are a kind of shareholder, too. If economists tried to model the future before it arrives in their rearview mirror. If politicians chose their constituents' jobs over their own. None of this requires revolution. It requires everyone to do the jobs they already have, just better.

There's an easy place for all of them to start—a bar so low, it amounts to a basic cognitive exam for the republic.

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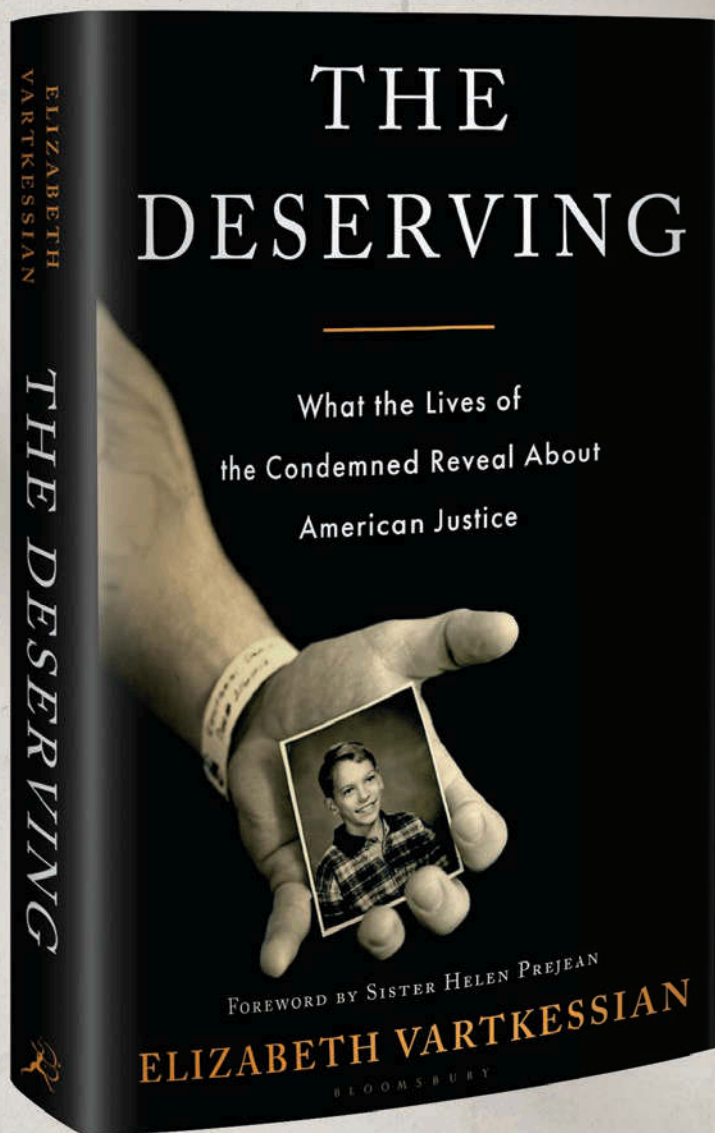
Erika McEntarfer was the commissioner of labor statistics until August, when Trump fired her after the release of a weak jobs report. McEntarfer has seen no evidence of political interference at the Bureau of Labor Statistics, but "independence is not the only threat facing economic data," she told me. "Inadequate funding and staffing are also a danger."

Most of the economic papers trying to figure out the impact of AI on labor demand use the BLS's Current Population Survey. "It's the best available source," McEntarfer said. "But the sample is pretty small. It's only 60,000 households and hasn't increased for 20 years. Response rates have declined." An obvious first step toward figuring out what's going on in our economy would be to expand the survey's sample size and add a supplement on AI usage at work. That would involve some extra economists and a few million dollars—a tiny investment. But the BLS budget has been shrinking for decades.

The United States created the BLS because it believed the first duty of a democracy was to know what was happening to its people. If we've misplaced that belief—if we can't bring ourselves to measure reality; if we can't be bothered to count—then good luck with the machines. *A*

Josh Tyrangiel is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

A groundbreaking new take on the American justice system from one of its unknown revolutionaries



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Mitigation specialist **Elizabeth Vartkessian** has been investigating the life histories of those facing the most severe penalties possible in the United States since 2004. She is the founder and director of Advancing Real Change Inc., a national nonprofit dedicated to conducting life history investigations in criminal cases.



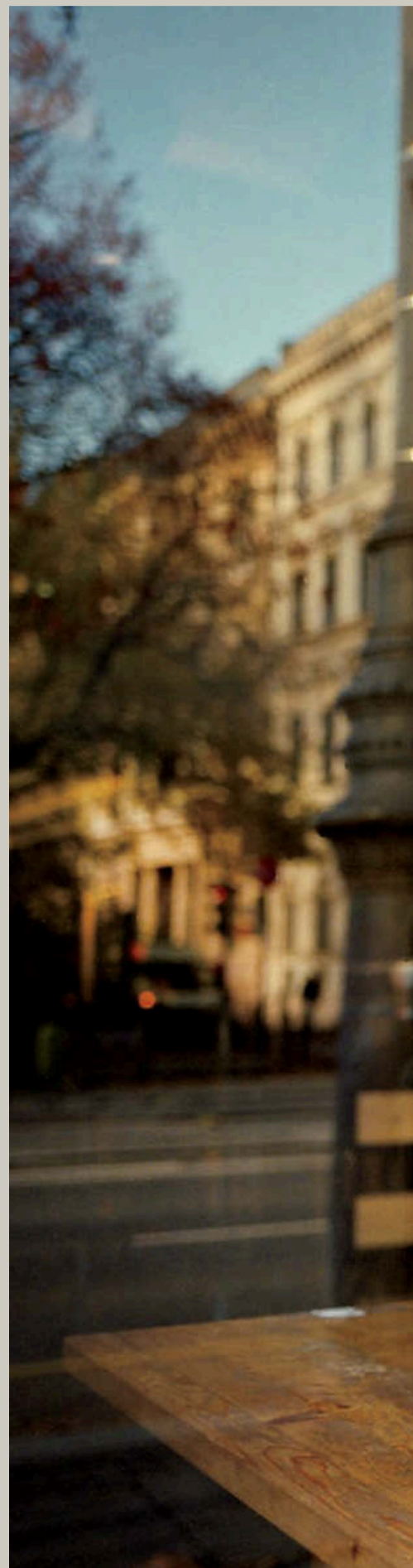
ROD DREHER'S DEMONS

HE DERIDES THE ENLIGHTENMENT, SECULARISM, AND THE MODERN WORLD. CONSERVATIVES—including the VICE PRESIDENT—are JOINING HIM ON A MARCH BACK TO THE MIDDLE AGES.

BY ROBERT F. WORTH



PHOTOGRAPHS BY ERIKA NINA SUÁREZ





On an April evening last year, Rod Dreher sat in the front row of an auditorium at the Heritage Foundation, in Washington, D.C., giddy with pride and happiness. He was there for the screening of a new documentary series based on one of his books, *Live Not by Lies*, about Christian dissidents from the former Soviet bloc—but first, a special guest was making his way toward the stage. J. D. Vance arrived at the podium to a roar of applause and told the crowd that he would not be the vice president of the United States if not for his friend Rod.

It was Dreher, Vance said, who latched on to his memoir, *Hillbilly Elegy*, a decade ago and promoted it on his blog for *The American Conservative*, helping to vault the book to the best-seller list. Dreher then became a friend and adviser to Vance as he launched his political career. After praising Dreher for 10 minutes, Vance invited him onstage. The two men hugged, each of them saying, “I love you, man.”

Unlike many in the crowd, Dreher, then 58, was not a staunch Donald Trump supporter; he had long criticized the president and came around only at the beginning of his second term, after concluding that Trump’s crude energy was needed to defeat progressive ideas. But Dreher has been giving voice to the yearnings and frustrations of religious conservatives for many years—as a magazine blogger with more than 1 million pageviews a month, an author of best-selling books, and a deliriously verbose writer on Substack. In January he joined *The Free Press* as a regular contributor. More than anyone else I know of, Dreher offers a full-fledged portrait of the cultural despair that haunts our era, a despair that has helped pave a road toward tyranny.

Dreher emerged from the conservative blogosphere in the 2000s and won fans with his daily stream of testy opinions and unguarded anecdotal writing. He seems almost allergic to ideological consistency, has long had readers on the left as well as the right, and sometimes changes his mind over the course of a single paragraph. He can be mean-spirited at times, but is quick with a heartfelt apology when he thinks

he has made a mistake. His columns are often a collage of quotes from the day’s news and from an eclectic cast of literary and philosophical idols: Dante, perhaps, or Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn, or the philosopher Alasdair MacIntyre.

When Dreher became a prominent figure a decade ago, he seemed resigned to the idea that religious conservatives like him had lost the political battle. In *The Benedict Option*—the 2017 book that put him on the map—he counseled a patiently monastic approach to Christians who felt that their faith was endangered in a relentlessly secularizing era. Drawing inspiration from Saint Benedict of Nursia, who founded thriving monasteries in the sixth century as Rome decayed, he wrote of a future in which committed Christians “will have to be somewhat cut off from mainstream society for the sake of holding on to the truth.”

But over the past decade, the rightward shift of politics has made clear that Dreher’s intuitions are more widely shared than he once thought. Take his interest in the supernatural and the demonic, the theme of his latest book, *Living in Wonder*. “The world is not what we think it is,” Dreher writes. “It is so much weirder.” We must disavow our scientific materialism and learn “to open our

eyes to the reality of the world of spirit and how it interacts with matter.”

Such ideas appear to have fueled some of the more apocalyptic currents on the Trumpist right, such as Peter Thiel’s musings on the anti-Christ and the ravings of Dan Bongino, the former deputy director of the FBI, who has said that demons are real. Before Tucker Carlson went public in 2024 with his story about being attacked in bed by a demon, he confided in Dreher.

I first began reading Dreher’s Substack a couple of years ago and felt as if I’d stepped into another world. Dreher spends much of his time with monks, back-to-the-land theologians, and exorcists. He believes that a great spiritual battle is under way: “As faith has receded, and interest in the occult and pornography has grown, so has demonic activity.” He continues, “Priests must understand that they are dealing with discarnate beings—fallen angels—who are vastly more intelligent than mortals.” Dreher often speaks of AI as a portal to the demonic, and he feels similarly about the trans-rights movement, which he sees as a symptom of a progressive dystopia in which there are no “structures of truth outside the choosing self.”

To a secular ear, all of this supernatural talk can sound like useful idiocy that serves only the autocrats Dreher sometimes praises—people such as Viktor Orbán, Hungary’s authoritarian leader, who are always in need of a crisis, spiritual or otherwise, to justify their most extreme measures. Dreher moved to Budapest in 2022 and is on familiar terms with Orbán and other European conservatives.

But if Dreher is any sort of courtier—a suggestion he would angrily reject—he is entirely sincere in his beliefs, and his deepest concerns are more religious than political. He seems tempted by the idea that Trump’s wrecking ball could clear the ground for a cultural rebirth. “I had never been enthusiastic about Trump,” Dreher told me, “but I was enthusiastic about him this time because it seemed like only somebody like him could put a stop” to “wokeness and the madness of transgenderism.”

Dreher’s writing is a useful indication of just how angry and pessimistic even the most thoughtful conservatives have

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become in recent years. He seems to see America as a hellscape, drained of religion and hope, drugged and distracted by the false gods of the internet. The renewal he imagines is not the sunlit, future-oriented conservatism of the Reagan era, and he doesn't look to the Founding Fathers for inspiration. If anything, Dreher's compass points in the opposite direction. He wants his country to turn back toward Europe—not the homogenized, secular continent of today but premodern Christian Europe, before the Enlightenment and the disenchantment set in.

evokes his Louisiana origins. His joy was partly a measure of his long-running preoccupation with the future of Europe, where the broader culture has been steadily marching away from Christianity. Fewer than a quarter of French people ages 18 to 23 identify as Catholic. The continent's eroding religious traditions and cultural loyalties, and its surging population of Muslim migrants, are a constant and gloomy obsession in Dreher's posts. But here, surrounded on this morning by Christian pilgrims, he felt sparks of hope.



Dreher (right) with Vice President J. D. Vance and Hungarian Prime Minister Viktor Orbán in Washington, D.C., November 2025

I met up with Dreher in early June outside the Church of Saint-Sulpice, in Paris. We were surrounded by thousands of excited young Catholics preparing for the start of an annual pilgrimage from Paris to Chartres, organized by devotees of the traditional Latin Mass. The pilgrimage is a rallying point for conservative Christians from across Europe and beyond; Catholic political figures sometimes join the pilgrims for a stretch.

"This is my world but not my world," Dreher told me as we ambled through the crowd. He meant that he is Christian and conservative, but no longer Catholic. He left the faith 20 years ago, disgusted by the Church's handling of the sex-abuse scandal, and became an Eastern Orthodox Christian. But he still feels an affinity with Catholics, especially the theological conservatives who adhere to the Latin liturgy that was universal in the Church until the Vatican II reforms of the 1960s.

"I can't think of the last time I felt so happy," Dreher said, in a drawl that

A Mass began inside the church, and loudspeakers broadcast the sounds of a choir to the overflow audience outside. All talk ceased, and thousands of people crossed themselves and knelt on the pavement. It was a very different Paris from the one most tourists or even Parisians see.

Dreher's excitement about the pilgrims turned out to be mutual. A number of them rushed up to greet him as the journey began. His work has gained a following in France, especially among young people who grew up in a thoroughly secularized Europe and are hungry for a more traditional or mystical experience. "Rod allowed the French to pose the question of faith in a new way," Yrieix Denis, a 34-year-old Catholic writer and consultant who helped get *The Benedict Option* published in French, told me. Dreher's perspective was refreshing, Denis said, because he had no stake in the political arguments that consumed and divided older French Catholics; he just wanted to help people sustain their faith in a hostile climate. And his warnings about demons

lurking in our cellphones and laptops seem to resonate with the younger generation.

Dreher's ideas about the decline of Christianity in Europe—once seen as a little conspiratorial—are now becoming something like the official view of the Trump administration. When Vance attended the annual Munich Security Conference as a first-term senator, in 2024, he got fed up with the European Union bureaucrats and took off early to reconnect with Dreher, who had come from Budapest, over beer and sausages. A year later, Vance returned to Munich as vice president and vented his feelings about the arrogance of Europe's ruling elite and the dangers of mass immigration in a speech that could almost have been written by Dreher, accusing the European leaders seated before him of betraying their own civilization. Those themes were echoed in December, when the Trump administration released a new National Security Strategy warning that Europe was in danger of "civilizational erasure."

The pilgrims marched westward out of the city, carrying crucifixes and flags bearing the names of local saints. They would be camping outdoors for two nights on their way to Chartres, but Dreher would not be joining them. "I'm a crotchety old bastard who won't camp," he'd told me.

Dreher's phone lit up often as we strolled through the newly empty streets toward the Latin Quarter. He presents a peculiar blend of gregariousness and inner solitude—connected to many people around the world yet profoundly lonely. His marriage broke up years ago, and he is now mostly estranged from his former wife and two of his three children. He lives alone in Budapest.

His daily routine, Dreher told me, is a trip to a local café followed by hours of reading and writing. Later he will walk around the city, his only form of exercise, and perhaps meet friends for drinks or dinner. During the five days I spent with him in France, he wrote and published four online columns, each several thousand words long. When I expressed surprise at his output, he said: "It's all I do."

Dreher didn't shy away from questions about his belief in the supernatural. He told me that he had once seen a woman possessed by demons while he was visiting her and her husband at their Upper East Side apartment, a story he recounts in *Living in Wonder*. The demons weren't themselves visible: One of them shouted obscenities through the woman's mouth, the way a demon possessed Linda Blair's character in *The Exorcist*, until her husband managed to silence it with a "relic of the True Cross" hidden in his pocket. The woman apologized for the demon's outburst, saying, "That wasn't me."

Dreher rattled off other encounters he's had with poltergeists and various nameless spirits. At the same time, he made clear that he wasn't sure how real these experiences were or what they meant, and noted that this was precisely the point: We

to promise infinite autonomy but is in fact a "vast disenchantment machine."

To Dreher, these changes are not just the queasy side effects of a world that is shedding outworn rules and becoming freer. They represent the fraying of a social and cultural order built on Christianity, and are responsible for a litany of troubling symptoms: loneliness, rising rates of anxiety, political polarization. "If you wanted to create a society and a culture that's guaranteed to make people miserable," Dreher told me, citing the psychiatrist Iain McGilchrist, "you couldn't do better than what we're living in now." Dreher often invokes the experience of fourth-century Romans, who could not see that the ageless pagan world they'd inherited was at an end, and that they were on the verge of a radically new and less stable era.

to understand the need to have some sort of divine structure to things.") Perhaps Dreher's most surprising ally is the evolutionary biologist Richard Dawkins, the author of *The God Delusion* and other atheistic broadsides, who has declared that he is now a "cultural Christian."

But lately Dreher's insights have come with an ominous political corollary. He believes our institutions are so rotten that they need a good slap from people like Trump and Orbán, even if it means losing some of them. "Maybe what's being born now will be worse, I dunno," he wrote as Trump and Elon Musk were using DOGE to dismantle the federal bureaucracy in early 2025. "We'll see. But bring it on. I've had it."

Dreher didn't always talk this way. In early 2017, he told an audience at the National Press Club that Trump's election suggested a weakness in the faith of the many Christians who had voted for him. Trump was another symptom of a "consumerist, individualistic, post-Christian society that worships the self." The writer Andrew Sullivan, who has been a friend and occasional sparring partner of Dreher's for decades, told me he believes Dreher hasn't really changed. "The politics came to him more than the other way around," Sullivan said, suggesting that Dreher was radicalized by his opposition to the trans-rights movement, Black Lives Matter, and other progressive causes.

The past decade may have been a very successful one for Dreher—he published three books and gained a much wider following—but it has also been a time of deep suffering, as anyone who reads his posts knows. His family broke apart in multiple ways, culminating in a divorce that took a terrible toll and left him almost entirely alone. When I first met Dreher, over dinner at a Sichuan restaurant in New York in April, he looked careworn, with signs of fatigue around the eyes. I couldn't help wondering whether Dreher's diagnosis of a "civilizational crisis," demons and all, was partly a measure of his own emotional turmoil.

The story of Dreher's personal Calvary begins with his father, who seems



Pilgrims traveling from the Church of Saint-Sulpice, in Paris, to Chartres, June 2025

should not remain "locked in an iron cage of scientism and rationality."

I got the sense that, for Dreher, the demonic is partly a metaphor, a way of talking about the psychic disturbances of our age. At his best, he is capable of shedding light on these disturbances, and not in narrowly religious terms. Dreher has a gift for articulating the unease that many people, including thinkers on the left, feel about the rapid erosion of borders and traditions of all kinds and the birth of an online landscape that seems

In recent years, Dreher's premonitions have caught on with a number of secular-minded people who have concluded that the West needs Christianity to protect it from an array of perceived threats, including the spread of Islam. Some, such as the Somali-born author and former atheist Ayaan Hirsi Ali and the British comedian Russell Brand, have converted to Christianity. Others, such as Jordan Peterson and Joe Rogan, seem ambivalent or opportunistic. (Rogan said in 2024 that, "as time rolls on, people are going

to be the key to his lifelong struggle to get closer to God. Ray Dreher was a rural public-health officer and a stubborn authoritarian who expected his children to spend their life in the Louisiana town of St. Francisville (population 1,557), where they grew up. Rod, his only son, loved books and dreamed from an early age of getting away to Europe. As an adolescent, he scorned the narrowness of his parents' lives, their views (Ray appears to have been a member of the Ku Klux Klan), and their bland Methodism—"Christianity as psychological and social wallpaper," as Dreher put it to me. He got out as soon as he could, going to college at Louisiana State University and then moving to the East Coast. His father never really forgave him for it.

Dreher traveled far from St. Francisville over the following decades, as an inner restlessness led from one religious incarnation to another. He started off as a secular liberal, but in his mid-20s he felt drawn back to faith, thanks in part to a one-night stand that led to a brief pregnancy scare. He converted to Catholicism at the age of 26 in St. Matthew's Cathedral in Washington, D.C. In 2006, he found a new home in Eastern Orthodoxy, an even more tradition-bound branch of Christianity.

In 2011, as Dreher was building a national reputation as a columnist, he decided to move back to St. Francisville with his wife and children. He had gained a new appreciation for his hometown after his younger sister, Ruthie, was diagnosed with Stage 4 lung cancer. Dreher was living in Philadelphia at the time, and during visits back home, he discovered that she had become a kind of local saint, revered for her charity and love of God. Ruthie's funeral—which he described in a long post for *The American Conservative* and later in a book, *The Little Way of Ruthie Leming*—brought out a deep sense of community. The love he saw there, he wrote, was "a thing of such intense beauty it's hard to look upon it and hold yourself together." Dreher wanted to be part of it, and to reconcile with his father.

The return was a spectacular failure. His father refused to relinquish his grudge, as Dreher saw it, and his mother always went along with her husband.

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Dreher told me the rift wounded him so badly that, for four years, he was mostly bedridden with chronic mononucleosis, sleeping four to six hours in the middle of the day. "The thing that I wanted more than anything else in the world," Dreher wrote years later, "and have wanted from the time I was a little boy, is to feel at Home in this world, with a father who approves of me. That was not to be mine, except, by God's grace, in heaven."

He stayed in Louisiana for more than a decade, struggling to maintain a marriage that was failing for reasons that Dreher has never fully spelled out (he says he needs to respect his family's privacy). Dreher says that only his faith in God sustained him. His writing about all of this is some of his best and most vulnerable. "It feels like that sometimes, that God has forgotten me, has forgotten us men who wanted to be good husbands and good fathers," he wrote in 2023. "Flannery O'Connor has a character who says she thinks she might be able to be a martyr if they kill her quick. Yeah, me too. But the very slow

martyrdom of the woman who bled out for twelve years, and for men and women who suffer the pains of marriages gone bad, and divorce—that's harder, I think."

IN PARIS, we skirted the edge of the Luxembourg Gardens, and the stony gray dome of the Panthéon became visible ahead. "I hate the Panthéon," Dreher said. For a moment, I was baffled, but Dreher explained: The building where France inters its greatest patriots and public figures is an emblem of the secular faith that spread after the French Revolution, a reminder that the rot in contemporary Europe, as he sees it, goes back to the ideals of the Enlightenment—liberty, scientific inquiry, individualism.

He began talking about the revolutionary mobs of 1793 as if they had swept through yesterday. "Genevieve had always been the city's local saint," he said. "But the mob came and took her relics and burned them." Dreher led me to the Church of Saint-Étienne-du-Mont, not far away, which contains what is left of her tomb. As we entered the dim sanctuary, he crossed himself and knelt to touch the floor in deference, an Orthodox tradition. We made our way to the chapel devoted to Saint Genevieve, where Dreher lit a candle for her, knelt, and prayed.

Dreher can give the impression that it has all been downhill for humanity since the 14th century. In his writing, he offers a potted history of how we fell away from a luminous medieval wholeness, when sacred and secular were as one; when, as he has written, "the entire universe was woven into God's own Being." Dreher is well aware that this reactionary outlook strikes many people as ludicrous. He often refers to himself in his columns as "Your Working Boy," a winking allusion to the half-mad protagonist of John Kennedy Toole's 1980 comic novel, *A Confederacy of Dunces*. That character, Ignatius J. Reilly, is a grotesque, obese shut-in who reveres the sixth-century Roman philosopher Boethius and claims to be writing a "lengthy indictment against our century."

I hear an echo of Ignatius Reilly when Dreher inveighs, as he often does, against progressive orthodoxy, writing incendiary posts with titles such as "Another Day,

Another Killer Tranny.” When he champions “normie” values and sensibilities against the “soft totalitarianism” of wokeness, he seems closest to the aggrieved ethos of the MAGA base.

But I saw little evidence of Ignatius Reilly during my time with Dreher. He did not seem motivated by hatred or bitterness but instead came off as kind and humble, with an endearing habit of telling humiliating stories about himself. He seemed almost eager to have his own views challenged, and genuinely saddened by the loss of some of his friendships with liberals in recent years.

it’s hard to avoid the sense that he *wants* a civilizational crack-up, a cleansing storm that would chase away evil forces and allow for Christian renewal.

This kind of talk has political consequences. How far is he willing to go? Dreher told me firmly that he could never condone a religious belief being forced on anyone, and he has regularly said in his columns that he opposes a totalitarianism of the right as much as one of the left. He told me that authentic Christianity “can’t exist if liberal democracy goes away.” Dreher has written some scathing things in recent months about Trump’s tariffs and his overall

“The System is collapsing? Good. It’s about time.” He hopes for a similarly bold assault on the liberal governments of Western Europe; he would like to see its white, native-born population rise up and fight against the dilution of its Christian heritage. In July, he wrote a melancholy post asking why the British are “acquiescing in their own demise as a people.”

And then there is Dreher’s decision to move to Budapest. I asked him about the price of Orbán’s rule—the shameless undermining of democratic institutions, the rampant corruption, the weak economy, the kowtowing to Vladimir Putin. Dreher told me he doesn’t support everything Orbán has done, but he was full of praise for the Hungarian leader, whom he credits with having rescued his country’s social and cultural integrity by limiting immigration. “The man is a real visionary,” Dreher told me. The two have met only three or four times, he said, but Dreher has been affiliated since 2021 with the Danube Institute, a state-backed think tank that has been a vehicle for disseminating Orbán’s political ideas.

Dreher used his ties with Orbán to help Carlson get an interview, which aired in August 2021. After Carlson gushed about Orbán’s avowedly illiberal approach to governance, American conservatives began making regular visits to Budapest, and references to “the Hungarian model” became a standard feature of Trumpian politics. Dreher bears a share of responsibility for all of this.



Dreher inside St. Stephen’s Basilica, Budapest

When Dreher wrote *The Benedict Option*, during the Obama presidency, his primary concern was how to keep faith alive at a time when Christianity seemed to be fading away. After it was published, his ideas took a darker turn: The portal to the demonic was getting larger, and Western civilization itself was at risk. Dreher told me he often meets ordinary Europeans who believe that civil conflict is just around the corner. There are certainly people who feel that way, but reading Dreher,

fecklessness, and has lost Substack subscribers as a result, he said.

Dreher has also spoken out forcefully against the rise of anti-Semitism and the white-nationalist trolls in the MAGA base known as “Groypers.” In November, he warned Vance about the trend during a visit to Washington. After Dreher criticized Tucker Carlson for hosting the Hitler-loving commentator Nick Fuentes on his podcast, Dreher revealed that Carlson had written to him privately to attack him and that their friendship appeared to be over.

But Dreher has also given plenty of rhetorical support to Trump’s demolition agenda. In February 2025, he wrote:

After two days of hiking, the pilgrims arrived in Chartres looking sweaty and exultant. Dreher was there to greet them, after an hour-long train ride from Paris. We entered the sanctuary, with its cool scent of ancient stone. Dreher led me to a spot at the center of the nave and gazed down. This, he told me, was the exact stone on which he’d been standing when he had his first true religious experience, at the age of 17. His mother had won a round-trip ticket to Paris at a church raffle back in Louisiana, and she passed it on to him. Young Rod went off to France by himself, and on a visit to Chartres, standing in the nave of the cathedral,

he was overcome by a vague but powerful sense that God was real.

Dreher has always sought solace in places that are rooted in tradition and far removed from modern life: hermetic religious communities, island monasteries, European cathedrals. His greatest admiration is reserved for people who commit themselves to “a fixed place and way of life,” as he wrote about Saint Benedict.

Yet Dreher seems resigned to living as a rootless exile, shorn of his family and condemned to wander a landscape of what the philosopher Zygmunt Bauman—one of Dreher’s favorite thinkers—called “liquid modernity.” I sometimes got the sense that all of his pilgrimages amounted to failed efforts to recapture the Edenic solidity of St. Francisville.

I accompanied him on another of these journeys after the Chartres pilgrimage. This one brought us to Rocamadour, a magnificent medieval town in Occitania, set on a cliffside above a tributary of the Dordogne River. Dreher had wanted to see the medieval chapel of Notre-Dame de Rocamadour for years, and for a curious reason: It is the site of a crucial scene in Michel Houellebecq’s controversial 2015 novel, *Submission*, in which the protagonist makes a failed attempt at religious conversion. The novel portrays France as a place so spiritually exhausted that it gives in to Islamic rule without much of a fight. Houellebecq is a famously cynical figure, and an odd bed-fellow for Dreher. But the story made a deep impression on him.

We climbed the old stone steps toward the chapel. Above one entryway, a sword is lodged in the stone, said to have found its place there in the eighth century after being thrown more than 100 miles by Roland, the hero of the medieval chanson that bears his name. (This sword was actually a replica. A year earlier, the original had been stolen.)

The sanctuary was dark and silent. On the far wall, framed by a red-and-gold Gothic arch, was the Black Virgin, a doll-like wooden figure that pilgrims come to see. It is here that Houellebecq’s antihero, François, feels the stirrings of something divine. But the feeling fades, and he dismisses it as an effect of hypoglycemia and

goes home. Dreher knelt in one of the pews and prayed.

He told me later that he’d been drawn to Houellebecq’s novel because of “what it says about the disposition one needs toward mystical experiences.” Many people, he said, lack the courage to act on their spiritual intuitions. Dreher himself may still be poised between belief and unbelief, struggling to break through the boundaries of the secular world he lives in. “Sometimes I ask, *Am I fooling myself?*” he told me at one point. But when he sees something like the Chartres pilgrimage, “I know I’m onto something.”



St. Stephen's Basilica, Budapest

Late that afternoon, we got in the car and drove away. The route took us along rural roads with views of sun-gilded fields and hillsides. Dreher fell into a pensive mood. I asked him what lessons these holy places might hold for America. He said he wasn’t sure. But the question led us back to his friendship with Vance, and he recounted a strange dream he’d had the night before: “I was supposed to marry Arianna Huffington,” he said, “and J.D. was supposed to marry the girl I had a crush on in high school, but couldn’t have. I arranged things so that we switched brides. But then I was exposed and felt humiliated.”

To me, the dream suggested that Dreher sees Vance as a kind of secret sharer, as well as a possible vehicle for the mysteries he was chasing among the monks and pilgrims. Vance is the kind of figure who might help create the conditions for a reenchantment of American life, or so Dreher hopes. “That man is the future of America,” Dreher wrote in April. If Trump represents Armageddon, Vance for Dreher may be something like the Rapture.

After the 2024 election, a number of people urged Dreher to move to Washington, saying he could capitalize on his friendship with Vance and double his readership.

I sensed that Dreher had considered the idea, however briefly. Were Vance to become president, the temptation to return would be even stronger. Dreher might be offered honors, or unique access to the administration as a writer. Would he seize the chance?

He told me he would not. He is more useful to Vance at a distance, he said. In any case, he is not looking for a political messiah. He wants the real thing. *A*

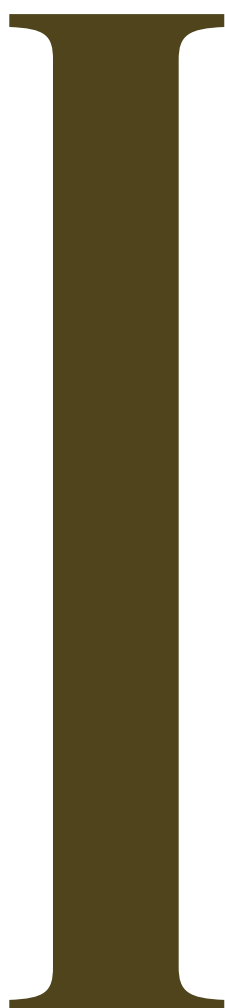
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THE PLOT AGAINST THE HUMANITIES

What is the Andrew W. Mellon
Foundation doing to higher education?

BY TYLER AUSTIN HARPER



In 1964, an influential report identified a disquieting trend in academia. “Increasingly during the past few years,” it began, “concern has been expressed about the condition, in this country, of those fields of intellectual activity generally called the humanities.” The 200-plus-page document was a publication of the National Commission on the Humanities, which had been established the previous year.

Reading the commission’s findings six decades later, one could reasonably conclude that what today gets called the “crisis of the humanities” is not so much a discrete 21st-century emergency as the latest expression of an educational catastrophe long in the making. The challenges outlined in 1964 are familiar: meager funding, insufficient support for graduate students, too few faculty jobs, an education system that glamorizes science and math, dense writing that alienates the public, and on and on. “The state of the humanities today creates a crisis,” the report concluded. “There is genuine doubt today whether the universities and colleges can insure that the purposes for which

they were established and sometimes endowed will be fulfilled.”

This doubt has not much diminished in the intervening decades, nor have the problems the report identified. Yet what is most notable in the report is not these similarities, but the commission’s prescient fear that the solutions to what ailed the humanities—namely, more cash and large-scale institutional support—also carried risks. “For the very reason that the humanities are concerned with quality, with values, with emotions, and with the goals of living, *they must remain free*,” the report proclaimed. “To control them is to dictate opinion and to subject all men to the tyranny of a controlling authority in the most intimate and sacred concerns of our existence as human beings.”

The commission’s boldest recommendation was that a new, publicly funded national foundation be established to disperse money to the humanities. But it also cautioned that this path was fraught. The report argued that, although building a taxpayer-financed agency to support American arts and letters was necessary, no federal body should have a monopoly on this grant-making, lest the humanities become unduly influenced by politics. “We must unquestionably increase the prestige of the humanities and the flow of funds to them,” the commission wrote. “At the same time, however grave the need, we must

safeguard the independence, the originality, and the freedom of expression of all who are concerned with liberal learning.”

The report recommended that federal funding for the humanities be supplemented by ideologically diverse, nongovernmental donors. “The day must never come when scholars and artists can look only to the federal government for the help they need,” it said. “The notion of any one ‘chosen instrument’ of government in this area must be abhorrent to anyone who cherishes the humanities and realizes that if they are not free they perish.”

For a while, things seemed to go more or less according to the commission’s plan. President Lyndon B. Johnson established the National Endowment for the Humanities in 1965 in direct response to the report. A few years later, the Andrew W. Mellon Foundation was created to finance American arts and letters. It would become part of a broader network that included the Ford Foundation, which began funding the humanities in the 1950s, and the John Templeton Foundation, which began funding research in religion and philosophy in the 1980s. The benefaction of these private nonprofits eventually came to exceed, by a substantial margin, the money dispensed by the government, which has declined over time.

In recent decades, though, the priorities of many of these nonprofits have shifted. The Atlantic Philanthropies, a onetime stalwart, reduced its funding for the humanities in the 1990s. The Rockefeller Foundation began moving away from humanities funding in the 2000s. In 2022, the Ford Foundation announced plans to drastically reduce its higher-education funding in order to focus on racial-justice-movement building. With the broader ecosystem of humanities-focused philanthropies all but dried up, only one major private grant-maker is left standing.

Today, no single entity, including the federal government, has a more profound influence on the fiscal health and cultural output of the humanities than the Mellon Foundation. The National Endowment for the Humanities’ grant budget was \$78 million in 2024 (its overall budget was less than half of what it was in 1980, when adjusted for inflation). Mellon awarded \$540 million in grants that same year; its endowment sits at roughly \$8 billion.

Mellon’s largesse is badly needed, especially as the Trump administration has threatened further cuts to the NEH. But the foundation’s virtual monopoly on humanities funding means that it has the power to remake entire fields according to its desires. And in recent years, under the leadership of Elizabeth Alexander, who became the organization’s president in 2018, Mellon has embraced an understanding of the humanities that is much more utilitarian, and far more political, than the one put forward by the 1964 commission. In June 2020, Mellon announced that it would be “prioritizing social justice in all of its grantmaking”—“a major strategic evolution” for the organization. This new paradigm seems to find value in arts and letters only insofar as they advance approved, left-leaning causes.

Over the past decade or so, conservative critics of higher education have tended to offer a rather simple explanation for the humanities’ decline. Their argument amounts to a version of “go woke, go broke.” According to this theory, ultraprogressive faculty coalesced around an unpopular liberal orthodoxy, turning

off undergraduates (and the public) and accelerating the humanities' collapse. In short, Shakespeare was replaced by jargon-laden prattle about "settler colonialism," and students took their tuition dollars to more sane, less shrill corners of universities.

But this tale places too much of the blame on humanities professors, overestimating their actual power within institutions. More important, the went-woke-went-broke hypothesis does not account for the ways that economic transformations within higher education have accelerated the trends that conservatives lament. Specifically, the right-wing theory of the case gets the causal arrow wrong. The humanities aren't broke because they went woke. The humanities went woke in large part *because* they were broke. As other donors, the government, and universities themselves all but abandoned these fields, Mellon became a lifeline. But the foundation has proved to be—as Jacques Derrida might have said—a kind of *pharmakon*: a Greek word that the philosopher noted could be translated as either "remedy" or "poison," depending on your perspective.

The 1964 report failed to anticipate that, in the 21st century, one of the most substantial challenges to the intellectual and political autonomy of the humanities would come not from a government agency, but from a private organization. American humanists now find themselves in a position that the report's authors would have considered a nightmare: A multibillion-dollar politicized grant-making entity has a stranglehold over humanities research and teaching, and is using that power to push them in a direction that blurs the boundaries between scholarship and activism, pedagogy and politics.

Under Alexander's leadership, even as it has cut back on funding for less political projects, Mellon has disbursed enormous sums of money to hyper-liberal academic initiatives at institutions both public and private. These have included grants to Portland State University to help its Women, Gender, and Sexuality Studies Department become more "ungovernable," creating "spaces where activism is encouraged" and "queer and feminist resistance" takes place; to Texas A&M at San Antonio for the Borderlands Shakespeare Colectiva (a group of academics and activists who "use Shakespeare to reimagine colonial histories and to envision socially just futures in La Frontera"); to Northwestern University for a project that explores how "Black dance practices" work to "instantiate Black freedom"; to Northeastern University for its Digital Transgender Archive to establish a new "lab" on the West Coast; and to UC Davis's Department of Gender, Sexuality and Women's Studies to create a working group on "Trans Liberation in an Age of Fascism."

One may feel a variety of ways about the worldview that Mellon has chosen to promote through its grant-making. But the salient question is not whether its politics are laudable or lamentable, or even whether the projects it funds are beneficial. The real questions are: What are the consequences when eye-watering sums of money are put behind the idea that the purpose of American arts and letters is not wisdom but advocacy? What happens when the humanities are seen not as having intrinsic worth, but as valuable only insofar as they can be of service to a cause? And what happens when the "choice" of whether to accede

to this vision of the humanities becomes—when there is only one real funding game in town—a matter of survival versus collapse?

THE ANDREW W. MELLON FOUNDATION was established in 1969, when two siblings—Ailsa Mellon Bruce, a socialite and an art collector, and Paul Mellon, an art collector and a racehorse breeder—decided to combine their personal charitable outfits in honor of their late industrialist father. Their new organization would fund American arts and letters, eventually including foreign-language programs, university special collections, tenure-track positions for new humanities professors, graduate fellowships for Ph.D. students, archival research, and more.

Even before its recent pivot, Mellon tended to tilt to the left, perhaps as a kind of compensation for, or a distraction from, the unseemly reality that it is a multibillion-dollar foundation created by the patrician offspring of a robber baron. But although some of its endeavors through the years were expressly social-justice-oriented (such as a 2016 grant for Columbia's "Facing Whiteness" project, an interdisciplinary study of how white Americans think about their racial identity), others were more traditional (a long-standing relationship with the Folger Shakespeare Library, for example).

In many ways, the role that liberal politics and social justice should play in higher education has been a preoccupation of the country's colleges and universities since the mid-20th century. Like cicadas, controversies tend to pop up every decade or so. There was William F. Buckley Jr.'s panic about "collectivism" in the Ivy League, documented in his 1951 book, *God and Man at Yale*. There were the campus free-speech and civil-rights movements of the 1960s, many of which led to the establishment of identity-focused humanities departments. Then came the fights over political correctness, multiculturalism, and the literary canon in the '80s and '90s associated with conservative intellectuals such as Allan Bloom and Roger Kimball. Christopher Rufo's "critical race theory" dissension kicked off the 2020s, giving way to disputes over wokeness and anti-wokeness. Lately, American campuses have been dominated by the debates around decolonial theory and free speech that emerged from the Gaza crisis.

The cumulative effect of these skirmishes has been to weaken the humanities' already vulnerable stock with the public. American culture treats the arts, ideas, and literature as luxury goods that can be cast aside during moments of belt-tightening, and post-2008 austerity measures have hit the humanities hard, resulting in budget cuts, vanished tenure lines, dwindling research funds, and diminished federal dollars. In a 2024 article for an academic journal, the literary scholar Christopher Newfield showed how few resources are allocated to basic humanities research in the United States. "Of the \$54 billion or so in research that the federal government funds in U.S. higher education, \$69 million goes to the humanities," he wrote. "That is, the humanities receive 0.13% of the federal total."

These economic woes have been exacerbated by the fact that, especially after the Great Recession, students and parents have placed even more emphasis on "practical" college majors that offered a strong "return on investment." Unable to compete with

STEM or business-adjacent fields in the hallowed category of “Making a Ton of Money After Graduation,” the humanities gradually settled into a sales pitch to justify the expense of a degree: The English or history or philosophy department will help turn you into A Good Person. The ROI of a humanities degree was not economic, the thinking went, but political and moral. This was the context in which Elizabeth Alexander became Mellon’s president, in 2018.

Alexander’s pedigree made her a natural choice to lead the foundation. Born to Clifford L. Alexander Jr.—a Kennedy-administration official and the first Black secretary of the Army—and Adele Logan Alexander, a noted historian, she has spent a lifetime in elite institutions: Sidwell Friends. Yale. Boston University to study poetry with Derek Walcott. A Ph.D. in English from the University of Pennsylvania. A stint as an assistant professor at the University of Chicago. Followed by Smith. Followed by Yale (again). Followed by reciting her own poetry at Barack Obama’s first inauguration (“In today’s sharp sparkle, this winter air, / any thing can be made, any sentence begun. / On the brink, on the brim, on the cusp”). A stint as the Ford Foundation’s director of creativity and (ironically) free expression after that. Then Mellon.

Alexander reportedly said in her interviews for the role that she planned to pivot the foundation’s attention to social-justice work, and she has kept her word. “There won’t be a penny that is going out the door that is not contributing to a more fair, more just, more beautiful society,” she declared in 2020.

TO BETTER UNDERSTAND the impact of Mellon’s agenda, I spoke with about 20 people who have had close dealings with the foundation. Some are professors; others are senior administrators who act as middlemen between their institution and donors and grant-makers. Several have been interacting with Mellon for a decade or more. They are employed at a variety of institutions, some public and some private, some generously endowed and others more threadbare. Most agreed to speak with me on the condition of anonymity. “I don’t think I want to go on the record,” a historian told me, “because Mellon is very powerful.”

One scholar described a relationship with Mellon that was as personal as it was professional. Decades ago, a Mellon fellowship paid for her to pursue a Ph.D. in 19th-century literature. “It changed my life,” she said. Later, when she was a new faculty member, a second Mellon grant enabled her to conduct research for her first book. The sort of work she did was traditional, historically minded, and apolitical, and she noted that she benefited from Mellon’s old approach to funding, in which “classic subjects were the norm.”

When I asked her how she felt about the organization’s turn toward social-justice work, she seemed ambivalent. She was open to Mellon’s new direction, but she also worried that the focus on progressive issues in academia had become “all-encompassing” and made the humanities a target of political criticism. I heard similar concerns from others.

A director responsible for grant administration at a small college said that humanities professors at her institution were

distraught by Mellon’s new focus, which they saw as coming at the expense of areas of inquiry without obvious social-justice relevance. She characterized some of the reactions she’s heard: “Are you saying that it’s no longer valuable that I’m doing research on these texts from this time to see what I can learn about them? Is that not valuable anymore to anyone?”

This director described a difficult conversation with a religious-studies professor who was excited about a new project. She told him that it had little chance of getting funding from Mellon, because, as the director put it, “it was purely research. It had nothing to do with community partners or racial justice.” She tried to let him down gently, but said it was like watching the air go out of a balloon.

I became a tenure-track humanities professor in 2020, and I remember Mellon’s shift being greeted with some quiet concern that funding in more traditional research areas would lapse. I saw an example of this several years ago, when a senior academic I know well was seeking research funding for a book project that had nothing to do with social justice. Forced to choose between forgoing an opportunity to win a badly needed grant and twisting his research into a social-justice pretzel, he opted for the pretzel, amending the project to focus on race in an unsuccessful bid to win the foundation’s favor. Another humanities academic I spoke with confessed that, like my acquaintance, he had reimagined his work to focus more squarely on race; he did win a grant. I suspect that this may not be a rare occurrence.

One professor told me that, after he and his colleagues were turned down for various Mellon grants, a representative from the foundation began helping them draft a new proposal that would more likely be approved. “We were pretty tightly coached,” he said. “It certainly felt like we were being told, ‘Do this, this, and this in order for it to work on our end.’” Ultimately, he said, a fair amount of social-justice jargon was tacked on to the proposal, “in consultation with, or perhaps at the insistence of, the representative from Mellon.” His team won the grant. (Asked to comment on this, Mellon responded in a statement to *The Atlantic*, “We firmly support intellectual and academic freedom.” The foundation also said that, “as a private charitable organization, we exercise our freedom to support projects in alignment with our mission.”)

It is hard to see how an incentive structure that pushes scholars to fake or fudge an interest in social justice helps produce a more just academy. If anything, this seems likely to further entrench higher education’s tendency to confuse performative preening with real societal improvement. It also effaces the difference between serious scholarship on race, colonialism, or gender and gaseous buzzword-mongering.

When I was pursuing a Ph.D. in comparative literature in the 2010s, Mellon’s Dissertation Completion Fellowship program provided essential financial support to graduate students finishing their studies. There were no substantive constraints on the subject areas that could be covered; awardees worked on topics as diverse as 15th-century women’s devotional literature, Descartes’ conception of infinity, temporal clauses in linguistics, and hacking culture in contemporary Mexico. In 2022, however, that program was eliminated.

Mellon's newer Dissertation Innovation Fellowship focuses on "supporting scholars who can build a more diverse, inclusive, and equitable academy." The guidelines list "thoughtful engagement with communities that are historically underrepresented in higher education" as one of the primary criteria used to evaluate the strength of an application; by my count, all 45 of the 2025 awardees work on issues of identity or social or environmental justice. The fellowship is explicitly "designed to intervene" before a student's research direction is finalized, which means, in practice, that Mellon can steer students who are just beginning to settle on a dissertation topic toward its preferred areas of inquiry.

In an alternate universe, with ample humanities funding for less politically salient work, one might see the fellowship program as an unalloyed good, providing support to projects that have not historically enjoyed sufficient resources. But in the funding landscape that actually exists, the reality is zero-sum. Every dollar that Mellon spends on this work is a dollar that it cannot spend on "non-applied" humanities research—in other words, scholarship for scholarship's sake that has no aim except to expand knowledge.

Some may argue that this trade-off is prudent. From my perspective, however, the gift of the humanities is that they liberate us from the tyranny of present opinion and the views of those in power—including those who sit atop multibillion-dollar philanthropies. A version of the humanities that sees its chief mandate as finding solutions to pragmatic problems doesn't ultimately seem all that different from the accounting department or business school.

I ASKED MULTIPLE times over the course of several months for an interview with Elizabeth Alexander, but through a spokesperson she refused to talk with me, a decision that highlights a broader set of problems within elite academic culture: a disinclination to be accountable to laypeople. A sense that private institutions, regardless of how much they influence the public, are entitled to push whatever ideologies they want. And a belief that it is perfectly natural for higher education to have a liberal slant because everything good and decent has a liberal slant. (Alexander sent along a handful of comments through a spokesperson shortly before this issue went to press. "At Mellon, grantmaking is guided not by ideology," she wrote, "but by the powerful ideal that the rich fabric of America's cultural and intellectual contributions must be broadened to convey the full scale of our nation's histories, surface new ideas, and challenge long-held assumptions.")

Alexander's appointment to Mellon also speaks to another trend I've observed within wealthy liberal institutions, in which people of color from unusually privileged backgrounds are anointed as standard-bearers for a radical cultural worldview that many working-class minorities do not share—even as the former are ostensibly intended to "represent" the latter. Of course, it is not Alexander's fault that she is the daughter of illustrious parents. Or that she is a descendant of the Logan family, a famous lineage of highly educated Black elites whose influence stretches back to the 19th century. Or that she is a longtime personal friend of the Obamas, or that her brother

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served on Barack Obama's transition team ahead of his first inauguration, where she read her poem "Praise Song for the Day."

But these facts are also not irrelevant to her elevation at Mellon, by whom she was paid \$1.53 million in direct compensation and \$672,785 in other compensation in 2024. I have no objection to poets making rookie-NFL-player money—though her 2024 salary is the equivalent of about 16 average tenure-track professors' annual pay—but it does make all of the social-justice posturing a little more comical.

Various people I spoke with said that Alexander has remade Mellon according to her values, pushing the foundation to become ever more devoted to a narrow conception of progress. A senior official in charge of grant administration at a small private college noted that Alexander has brought a new style of leadership to the foundation, wielding more top-down bureaucratic control and pushing more sweeping changes than past presidents have. Others agreed with this characterization.

This is a significant departure from the nonprofit's past approach to managing relationships with the institutions it funds, in which Mellon officials would try to balance a college's or university's particular—often less political—needs against its own ideological priorities. In 2023, the foundation allotted \$1 million to "deepen the ongoing conversation in Transgender Studies" at the University of Kansas—specifically, to "establish a cohort model for scholar-activists" and "create a more trans-liberatory local and regional landscape." Another \$1 million went to classics professors at Princeton and Brown for a project called Racing



the Classics, devoted to encouraging early-career scholars to implement “critical race approaches and curricular experimentation.” In 2024, Loyola Marymount University won a three-year, \$431,000 grant to “bridge AI practitioners and disability justice scholars and activists.” And MIT received \$500,000 for something called Engaging With Music and Musicking Through Engagement, aimed at correcting its curriculum’s “Western European biases.”

Whether or not these programs and projects are serious, significant contributions to humanities scholarship and teaching is somewhat beside the point. Even assuming that the undertakings are all worthwhile, the volume of financial support directed at the “scholar activism” model, at a moment when other, more time-honored varieties of humanities education are withering away, is cause for concern. Majors such as English, philosophy, and theater belong to an ever-shrinking number of fields that are not squarely devoted to job-market preparation or “skill building,” fields that aspire to do something loftier than clearing the brush from students’ career pathways. The merging of humanistic work and activism represents a surrender to the utilitarian logic that measures the worth of knowledge by its direct impact on “the real world.”

Mellon itself disputes this notion. A spokesperson connected me with Phillip Brian Harper, the foundation’s program director for higher learning, who said, “*Social justice* is a fuzzy term that people invest with a range of different meanings that don’t necessarily apply to the way we do grant-making.” He argued that Mellon’s focus is on emerging fields that have not received grant money in the past, regardless of their particular political bent. “Now, it does so happen that a lot of historically underfunded

fields entail scholarly work that itself has social-justice objectives in mind,” he conceded. “But that’s a separate thing.”

This is quite obviously nonsense. Harper himself published an opinion article in 2022 titled “Studying Humanities Can Prepare the Next Generation of Social Justice Leaders.” “The country’s next generation of leaders is pushing for racial equity, economic equality, disability justice and gender and sexual liberation,” he wrote. “To succeed they will need the observational and analytical skills that can be developed by studying ideas, historical events, aesthetic works and cultural practices”—in other words, by studying the humanities. In this context, it seems clear that “social justice work” does indeed mean “activism.”

Some of Mellon’s recent grants have the potential to remake liberal-arts education entirely. The foundation’s Humanities for All Times project, launched in 2021, is premised on the notion that “today’s humanities undergrads are tomorrow’s social justice leaders.” Over the past several years, the foundation

has regularly invited small cohorts of liberal-arts colleges to apply for grants—up to \$1.5 million each—that support social-justice-aligned curricular development. The application guidelines note that “submissions oriented toward revising an institution’s entire general education program are especially welcome.” That is to say, college administrators and academics are encouraged to submit proposals for projects that would overhaul their core requirements for *all students*, in every major, in the service of a progressive political program.

A 2021 Humanities for All Times grant proposal from Colorado College reads like conservative satire: “We recognize the myriad ways in which white supremacy has shaped our institution and have been taking steps to work our way out of its grip,” it confesses near the beginning. The application promises the introduction of “at least 50 new and relevant courses” to “empower students to be changemakers.” Mellon gave the college \$1 million to carry out this work.

In the summer of 2023, Colorado College hosted a conference based on this prompt: “How do the humanities contribute to anti-oppressive work, and how can humanities methods—from inquiry and critique to creative production and performance—dismantle systems of oppression, create and sustain community and solidarity, and advance liberation?” It does not seem to occur to those asking such questions that the humanities may not be especially well equipped to “dismantle systems of oppression.” Nor do they seem to consider that what might in fact be most valuable about fields like English, history, and philosophy is that they aspire to stand above the flotsam and jetsam of our immediate circumstances, and instead set their sights on what the classicist Leo Strauss called the “permanent problems” that have troubled human beings from time immemorial.

AS EASY AS it is to point to cartoonishly progressive things that Mellon has funded, it is also true that, under Alexander, the foundation deserves credit for working to create a more economically just landscape within higher education. Before Alexander's arrival, Mellon tended to disburse lavish funding to institutions that were already rich. Now, as part of Mellon's commitment to equity, it is making a conscious effort to provide funding to public and less selective institutions. It has also increased funding for university-led prison education programs.

In 2024, Mellon spent \$25 million to fund paid internships for undergraduate humanities students at five public colleges and universities. These internships can be in any field, with no particular ideological or social-justice strings attached. Renata Miller, a dean at the City College of New York, was effusive about the \$5 million internship grant it received. She told me that the money helps provide support for child care, commuting costs, and other obstacles that can prevent working-class students from taking internships.

Elizabeth Spiller, the arts-and-sciences dean at the University of South Florida, wrote in a press release that she was stunned her school was even asked to apply for a similar program. USF ultimately received a \$4.8 million grant, which can fund up to 900 students a year to take otherwise-unpaid internships.

Ironically, programs like this illustrate the bind in which both Mellon and the humanities writ large find themselves. It is hard to argue that the tens of millions of dollars that Mellon is putting toward internships for working-class kids at public colleges and universities would be better spent financing dusty archival research on 16th-century France. But this calculus also says something about the deeper structural problems of a model that pits various social goods—programs for humanities undergrads, resources for Ph.D. students, traditional humanities research, support for emerging fields and endowment-poor universities—against one another.

When I asked Harper how he feels about Mellon's role as the country's preeminent humanities funder, and the difficult choices that necessitates, he took issue with my characterization. "Serving in this way, that is not Mellon's *role*," he said. "Given the situation that we're in, Mellon is accidentally in the *position* of being the primary large funder." His point was that safeguarding the health of the humanities was not the foundation's *raison d'être*, even if the decisions it makes affect that health directly.

This distinction helps shed light on the implicit question that underlies the entire debate about Mellon's new focus. Namely, should the foundation be blamed for damaging the humanities by directing nearly half a billion dollars a year toward a social-justice-ified vision of American arts and letters, or should universities, the federal government, and other donors instead be blamed for not providing a healthier funding ecosystem to begin with, to say nothing of the anti-woke conservative billionaires who complain endlessly about the humanities and champion "the classics" without ever spending a single penny to support them?

"The sector needs to be taken by the collar and shaken very hard until resources that are adequate to the support of humanities doctoral students are jarred loose from higher-ed institutions themselves," Harper said, growing animated. "The role of the Mellon Foundation is to catalyze that sort of change. It's not to serve

in perpetuity as the piggy bank for research." Mellon, he said, was never supposed to be a panacea for the humanities.

But with the academic humanities in their death throes, Harper's distinction between *role* and *position* may be largely beside the point. No, it is not Mellon's job to be the humanities' piggy bank. Yes, Mellon is the humanities' piggy bank. The resulting situation is dismal, and the Trump administration's funding cuts will only make things worse.

Yet the president's attacks on the National Endowment for the Humanities and the canceling of federal humanities grants might not have the effect that conservatives hope for. Howard Husock, a fellow at the American Enterprise Institute, recently warned that gutting the NEH would simply expand the power vacuum for Mellon, and is likely to give the progressive organization even more sway over American arts and letters.

SOME WILL NO DOUBT feel that it is irresponsible to criticize Mellon at a moment when higher education is under assault from the federal government. That point of view is fair enough, I suppose, though I think it's also misguided. The humanities' problems began well before Donald Trump ever ran for office. The fantasy that we can put off these uncomfortable discussions—about Mellon, about the humanities, about the relationship between scholarship and activism—until some imagined time when higher education is in a healthier place strikes me as just that: a fantasy.

The humanities are in the mess they're in because of federal budget cuts, and because of administrators who care more about the football team than about William Faulkner, and because of the toxic pragmatism of an American culture that has a hard time valuing anything that is not immediately, aggressively useful. But the humanities are also in this mess because those of us who care about them have often preferred hunkering down in a defensive crouch, rattling our donation jars and begging for scraps, to serious soul-searching about the real purpose of American arts and letters. We have been too reluctant, or perhaps too ashamed, to consider whether we have betrayed the humanities' very spirit in our mad, ever more futile quest to keep them financially solvent.

I often wonder what, exactly, we think we're saving. Are the humanities as they are currently instantiated in the American university system actually worth the Faustian bargains we are forced to make to keep them? At their best, the humanities remind us that our problems are petty not because they are small, but because they are born of the same questions that have plagued all humans since our species lowered itself down from the trees and traded monkey chatter for wisdom-seeking: How to live virtuously? How to exist together peaceably? How to die with grace?

The humanities predate the modern university by millennia, and they will surely outlast it. But a higher-education system that can no longer keep them safe from the vulgarities of the market, the siren song of cultural warfare, or the decidedly sublunary work of furnishing political propaganda is one that has not just failed the humanities, but failed entirely. *A*

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Even before competing in his first
Olympics, 21-year-old Ilia Malinin has
transformed the sport of figure skating.

THE MAN WHO BROKE PHYSICS

By Sally Jenkins Photographs by OK McCausland



One of the pleasures of watching Ilia Malinin, apart from his indifference to gravity, is to witness him becoming. Becoming a world champion, as opposed to a juvenile with a skate-park mentality and a face like a Disney prince. Becoming a master of quadruple jumps that no one else can land, rising with all the ease of a young Michael Jordan—before landing on a pair of butcher knives, on ice.

Sometimes there are evolutionary leaps in sport, the arrival of athletes so physically dynamic, they widen the eyes with incredulity: the gymnast Simone Biles thundering in the air, the swimmer Michael Phelps coursing through the water with a wake like an attack boat's. Malinin is one of these. In December, while refining his routine for his first Olympic Games, in Milan, the 21-year-old figure skater landed seven quadruple jumps in competition, spinning like a weather vane in a windstorm. No other competitor landed more than three.

In a sport in which medals can be determined by fractions of a point, Malinin wins by 30, 40, sometimes even 70 points, and he does so with style, sliding on his knees and cartwheeling on one hand to medleys of classical cello mixed with Gen Z electronic power bass. His signature is a quadruple axel—a jump that only he has ever successfully completed in competition, earning him his self-styled nickname, the “Quad God.” Late in his routines, he likes to toss off one more maneuver, just to commence the crowd-roar: He high-kicks his skates over his head into a backflip, and lands on one foot.

Malinin's confidence would be insolent if his acrobatics weren't so astonishing. “I broke physics,” he told me recently, only half-kidding during a conversation in the back hall of a practice rink in Leesburg, Virginia. “Now I think physics doesn't apply to me.” He stood 5 foot 8 and 140 pounds in shapeless sweats and Nikes, his pale triangle of a face topped by flaxen hair. He did not yet have his own car. He was waiting for his dad to pick him up.

The first quadruple jump of any kind was landed in 1988 by a Canadian champion named Kurt Browning, but it was

a one-off. Quads wouldn't be performed consistently until about 15 years later, after an American named Timothy Goebel became the first man to hit three in a single program, in 1999, and did so again to win a bronze in the 2002 Winter Games, earning the nickname “Quad King.” By the mid-2000s, doing one or more quads was practically a necessity, because they were scored almost twice as high as triples. Quads became part of everyone's repertoire, with five different varieties and degrees of difficulty: the toe loop (worth up to 9.5 points), salchow (9.7), loop (10.5), flip (11), and lutz (11.5).

But one particular quad jump was so demanding that even the most elite champions could not perform it: the axel, valued at 12.5 points. To the casual viewer, most jumps are indistinguishable from one another, but anyone can detect an axel, because it's the sole jump that requires the skater to take off facing forward, then execute a blind backward landing, on the opposite foot. The skater actually rotates four and a half times, in less than a second. As of 2021, only one man had even tried a quad axel in competition: The 27-year-old Olympic champion Yuzuru Hanyu of Japan went for it in his country's national championships that year, but he under-rotated and two-footed his landing.

Malinin landed it smoothly in 2022, when he was 17.

He was a skinny-chested boy who had just begun competing in major international events, and he knew that the entire skating world considered it nearly impossible. The word provokes him. “It just screams ‘I'm possible,’” he said, as he walked through the hall of the practice rink and grabbed a snack of Auntie Anne's pretzel bites.

Malinin has a typical 21-year-old's crush on profundity; his long program, titled “A Voice,” opens with his own voice narrating a series of pontifical maxims, such as “Begin where light no longer reaches, where no path has yet been made.” If he can sound sophomoric, well, he is a sophomore, enrolled at George Mason University. But a mature, obsessive work ethic turns his big ideas into

big jumps and one-of-a-kind routines. “If I find a passion for something, I will really get down to just hammering away at it, until I get it,” he said.

Once Malinin gets it, the next boundary comes into view. One quad axel? Well then, how about two in a row?

TO FULLY APPRECIATE how revolutionary Malinin is, consider some fundamental physics and biomechanics. The gold-medal-determining long program, also known as the “free skate,” lasts for four and a half minutes. Roughly 30 seconds in, Malinin's heart rate rises to 90 percent of its capacity, about 180 beats a minute, and stays there for the duration. The effort is comparable to that sustained by the world's fastest milers.

Wearing carbon-composite skates that weigh about two pounds each, Malinin reaches a vertical leap of approximately 30 inches on his quad axel—one kinematic study captured it at 33 inches, similar to the standing vertical leaps of NBA players such as Stephen Curry, Devin Booker, and Kevin Durant. He lands on a blade that is just 3/16 of an inch wide.

Malinin enters the jump skating at about 15 miles an hour. As he snaps into his shoulder turn, he draws his arms and legs inward, creating a spin. At this stage, he experiences at least 180 pounds of centripetal force. By way of comparison, a NASCAR driver rounding a corner will experience about 400 pounds of centripetal force, while wearing a seat belt. As he reaches his apex, Malinin is spinning at 350 revolutions per minute. This is about the same as a kitchen stand mixer or the marine engine of an oil tanker.

A human being turning at such a rate experiences serious disorientation. Somehow, Malinin must find a way of “undizzying” himself, as Goebel told me. Skaters do this by spotting certain visual markers in the rink, but they don't always succeed in reorienting. Once, after completing one routine, Goebel nearly skated into the Zamboni tunnel by mistake.

As Malinin comes out of his spin, his backward boot strikes the ice with a landing force between five and eight times his body weight, or upwards of 700 pounds. In other sports, athletes distribute shocks



Ilia Malinin does a backflip in practice before the U.S. Figure Skating Championships in January.

to both feet, in soft shoes or on forgiving surfaces. “He’s going to land on one foot,” on a sheet of ice atop concrete, Deborah King, a biomechanics professor at Ithaca College, told me. Adding to the stress on his leg, she said, is the

rotational energy he’ll need to stop so he can glide out of his landing.

Still, none of this captures the totality of Malinin’s performances. There are spins, jumps into spins, jumps out of spins, fast steps, crossovers, rapid changes from inside to outside edge. Even a single misstep or break in a leg line will be marked down by the judges. “You know, when you kick a soccer ball, you don’t have to look perfect,”

Malinin said. “You don’t have to point your toe.”

Malinin spends up to six hours a day on the ice, in morning and afternoon sessions, rehearsing his footwork and doing as many as 50 jumps, six days a week. “Your whole body dies at the end of the day,” he said.

Malinin was merely on the threshold of public awareness late last year, as the Olympics approached, but seemed ripe for a “holy shit” audience moment. Only in the past few months has he begun to get endorsement deals with big companies—Xfinity, Coca-Cola, Google, Honda. “At first it was like, *Who?*” Sheryl Shade, Malinin’s co-agent, told me as she described her initial meetings with potential sponsors, a year and a half ago. But then “he started winning everything. It was like, *Oh! You mean the Quad God.*”

The Honda deal will finally get Malinin his own wheels and liberate him from the family car. The day I met him in November, he was at the Leesburg rink to film a commercial for the company. That morning, his father had dropped him off with the understanding that he wouldn’t take any unnecessary risks.

But as the camera crew darkened the arena, Malinin was isolated in a spotlight. Unable to resist, he performed a quadruple jump, and then a second one. Then he ordered the camera crew to take up a different angle, blazed across the ice, and arched into a backflip, his skates lightly touching down with a *tech* sound.

Afterward, he sat with damp hair on a sofa in a back room of the arena. When I

asked if what he'd just done felt particularly hard, he shrugged and said no.

Then he glanced up and said, "Don't tell my dad."

MALININ IS THE SON of two former Olympic skaters, Tatiana Malinina and Roman Skorniakov, Russian emigrants who competed for Uzbekistan but came to Virginia in 1998. Skating is a "family tradition, family business, family ritual, whatever you can name it," Malinin said. Without the coaching and influence of his parents, "I'd be nowhere."

Malinina and Skorniakov seldom comment on their son or their methods for coaching him, wary of creating any more pressure for him. They declined to be interviewed for this story. Malinina does not attend most of her son's events, because she gets too anxious. "We have a strong connection, and as soon as I get nervous, he can feel that," she said in a rare 2024 joint interview with her husband for the International Skating Union. Skorniakov, too, gets nervous—the first time he watched his son perform a double lutz, he said, "I remember I almost passed out." But he is better at concealing it, with a stoic rink-side presence that his son describes as "chill."

If figure skating is one of the most demanding sports in the world, then the hardest version of it is Russian. Malinin has never been to Russia, but its traditional skating commandments, heavily influenced by ballet, are stamped on him. His maternal grandfather, Valeri Malinin, coaches at a small rink in Novosibirsk, and during visits to the States, he had an early hand in teaching his grandson. "It is clear that there is only one correct technique"—the Russian one, Valeri told the state-owned news channel Russia 24 in a 2023 interview.

Malinina and Skorniakov were born in Siberia and raised in the old Soviet sports system. Skaters trained as much off the ice as they did on it, and form was everything: Even an incorrect jaw bite could lead to a slight bend in the backbone, affecting a jump. A preeminent coach of that era once made a skater change his bangs, believing that hair below the eyebrows caused a wilting of the spine.

Skorniakov and Malinina, out in distant Ural mining country, could never

quite crack the inner circle of the major training center in Moscow. For years there was just one rink in Sverdlovsk, where they trained, and it had to be shared by all, including hockey players. Practice time was precious, and bureaucrats carefully allocated the hours. After the collapse of the Soviet Union, Skorniakov and Malinina's coach, Igor Ksenofontov, became the national coach for Uzbekistan in 1993, and they followed him to Tashkent seeking better resources and opportunities.

At roughly the same time, small enclaves of Russian-émigré skaters began forming in out-of-the-way places in the United States, near excellent local ice rinks. In 1998, Skorniakov and Malinina moved to Dale City, Virginia, for their training. The availability of good ice and the cost of living were a relief.

They found work teaching skating for hourly fees at the Mount Vernon Rec Center to support themselves while they trained. In her few spare hours, Malinina studied English—she read *Gone With the Wind*. According to her father, she adapted so quickly that when she went back to Novosibirsk to visit him, she looked around his apartment and said, "Oh, Dad, is this how you live?" Valeri shot back, "Well, how do we live? You used to live like this too."

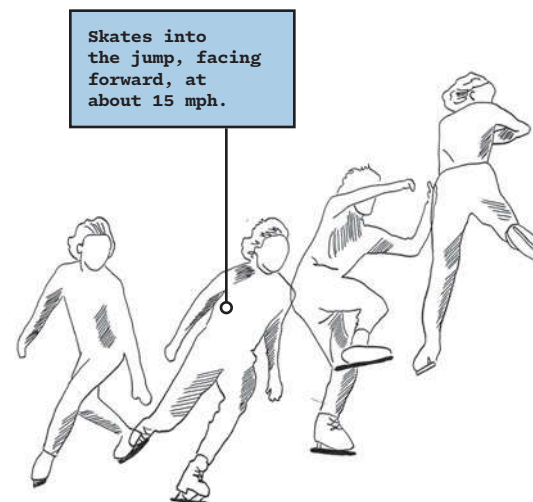
The move to America seemed to boost their careers. Malinina, renowned for her technically perfect triple lutz, placed eighth in the 1998 Nagano Olympics and fourth at the 1999 World Championships, her career best at 26 years old. Skorniakov finished 19th in the Salt Lake City Games in 2002. They were both known as "very big jumpers," Goebel recalled. The two married in 2000, and both retired after Salt Lake to become full-time coaches and start a family. When Malinin was born in 2004, they gave him his mother's last name because it was easier for Americans to pronounce, and they decided he would be anything but a skater. To have even a chance of being elite "takes so much time, dedication, lots of sacrifice, so much hard work," his mother told the International Skating Union. "And we thought maybe we want him to experience a different life than we did."

But they worked 12 hours a day, giving lessons from 6 a.m. to 6 p.m. at the SkateQuest ice arena in Reston, Virginia. The baby had to be there too. As Malinin grew into a toddler, he would watch through the rink glass as the other children glided around. When he was about 6, he began pestering his parents. "Can I go on the ice?" he'd ask. "Can I go on the ice?"

They finally decided to teach him to skate—never with the thought that he

Malinin's Quad Axel

Ilia Malinin is best known for landing the first quad axel. Here's a visual break down explaining it step-by-step.



would compete. But almost immediately, he began making up his own routines, mimicking the older skaters. His parents thought it was cute. It was also portentous. "I definitely do like performing," Malinin said. "It's something I realized when I grew up, when I started skating even just for fun. It was part of me."

Still, his parents doubted that he would be a skater. They enrolled him in gymnastics and soccer. He took violin lessons. On the ice, he loved to jump—his grandfather taught him all the variations during a single three-month visit when he was about 7—but he'd rebel when they tried to work on the details of his posture and

arm position. “Hold your back,” Malinina would tell him, and explain that a skater’s performance couldn’t just be about jumps. “I’ll do that later,” he’d say.

WHEN MALININ WAS 12, his father drove him to the University of Delaware to participate in a project measuring the jumping ability of young skaters, led by Jim Richards, a kinesiology professor. Though his parents had refused to push

“What we found from the measurements is that through pretty simple changes with his arm position, he could land a triple axel without a problem,” Richards told me. He shared something more with Malinin and his father: With a few further adjustments, he would be able to achieve the spin rates he needed for quads.

The possibilities persuaded Malinin to apply himself more seriously. He also became more appreciative of his unique

change everything up, to make it easier, or make things harder,” Malinin said.

Malinin landed his first triple axel at 13. He was practicing at a competition when he felt a surge of confidence and went for it. He landed it easily. “I was like, *Okay, I didn’t expect that*,” he said. Skorniakov was over at the rail, and his eyes popped in surprise. It was the moment that persuaded Malinin to pursue skating professionally.

Turns shoulder and draws in arms and legs, achieving a maximum spin rate of about 350 rpm, or roughly that of a kitchen stand mixer.

Touches down facing backwards, on opposite foot, with a landing force upwards of 700 pounds.

Jump as a whole involves 4.5 revolutions and takes less than one second.

Vertical leap reaches 30 to 33 inches, comparable to the standing jump of a typical NBA player.

him, he had shown what he could do with even a little effort: The previous year he had won the 2016 U.S. juvenile boys’ title by landing two double axels, despite practicing just two hours a day. Malinin was fitted with 10 reflective markers from his head to his skates and filmed by 10 cameras that captured his rotations and time in the air in a series of jumps. The data were then fed into a 3-D computer program that created two models, one of Malinin’s jumps and another of conceptual improvements to the jumps.

Some of the young skaters weren’t going to be elite under any circumstances. But Malinin clearly had that potential.

access to two former Olympians. They’d never shown him videos of their own performances or boasted about their medals, but their accounts of how they’d had to scrap for enough ice time to practice impressed him. The family would rise at 4:30 a.m. for an hour-long commute to SkateQuest, where he’d practice with his parents for two hours before school. Skorniakov worked with him on axels using a harness and a pole, bracing and lifting as his son spun in the straps. Malinina was relentlessly precise—and more blunt than Skorniakov—in her assessment of his technique. She taught that it took “just a very small fraction to

They moved to Vienna, Virginia, to be closer to SkateQuest and Malinin’s high school. He went to class until 12:45 p.m. and then spent the rest of the day on the ice, now training for four or five hours. On Sundays, his parents insisted that he do anything but figure skate. He got hooked on skateboarding and the video game *Fortnite*. On TikTok, he followed Wisdom Kaye, an irreverent fashion influencer who modeled eclectic clothing and staged challenges such as “style every character in the movie *Dune*.”

Malinin’s side interest in performance art began to show up in his skating. He seeded his programs with unorthodox

elements, like the “raspberry twist,” a sideways scissoring move. It wasn’t a traditional jump, or a spin, either. It was just his.

At 16, he created the Instagram handle *ilia_quadg0d_malinin*. It seemed presumptuous, given that he’d only landed the easiest one, a toe loop, in competition—and only once, at that. But it inspired him to keep working toward a quad repertoire, he told U.S. Figure Skating sometime later. “I can’t be ‘Quad God’ without any quads,” he remembered thinking.

He was aided, oddly enough, by the coronavirus. In 2020, when all of the rinks had shut down for almost four months and he was unable to skate or go to school, his parents had designed an off-ice program imitative of the old Russian physical training, including three hours a day of explosive-jump training, runs, skipping rope, stretching. They asked a nearby homeowners’ association for permission to use a tennis court as their training area. The off-ice work strengthened Malinin so much that when he got back in the rink, jumps felt easier. The final piece of his development came the following year, when he began tutorials with the technical-jumping coach Rafael Arutyunyan. Arutyunyan knew instantly he had a student capable of the quad axel. He tinkered just slightly with Malinin’s entry, and the next month, the boy was landing it.

Starting in 2021, Malinin posted Instagrams of himself doing quad axels in practice. Anticipation began to mount in the skating world. Then Malinin signaled his intention to try one in competition. “I was sort of aghast,” Goebel, the Quad King, said. He noted that the axel is not just technically difficult, but dangerous. “I never thought I would see one in my lifetime.”

Goebel decided to fly out to the U.S. Figure Skating Championships, where Malinin would be making his debut as a senior skater. “I wanted to see Ilia jump in real life,” he said. Could he possibly be that good? Malinin, just 17, landed four quads. “And the effortlessness with which he completed these really, really difficult things, as a teen, was kind of shocking.”

Malinin withheld the quad axel that day because his parents were worried that he would hurt himself. But as the season



Malinin in January at the U.S. Figure Skating Championships, which he won by nearly 60 points

wound down, they gave him their blessing. On September 14, 2022, at the U.S. International Figure Skating Classic in Lake Placid, New York, on his very first

jump, Malinin rose and spun four and a half times, as clean and straight as a flagpole, and lightly touched down, to pure tumult.

He won the World Championships in 2024 and again, easily, in 2025, when the International Skating Union also named his parents coaches of the

year. Colleagues continually write or call Malinina and Skorniakov to ask what they did to create such a performer. “There are no secrets,” Valeri Malinin told *Russia 24*. It’s been a simple matter of the Russian method colliding with American possibility—in the person of a creative young athlete determined to explore the limits of his sport.

THE SKATEQUEST RINK in Reston is a giant box with a metal roof that’s meant to hold one thing: ice. It’s a no-frills space with small stands of benches and a room with a window where mothers and fathers may watch from a distance. Here, skaters can fall without anyone but their parents seeing. Which, on this Monday, two days after his Honda shoot and 75 days before the Olympics opening ceremony, Malinin did. A lot.

Malinin took the ice to rehearse the opening combination of his Olympic short program, called “The Lost Crown.” The program (which lasts two minutes and 40 seconds and counts for about a third of a skater’s overall score) began with a leg-burning spread-eagle arc, into a quad axel followed by a triple toe loop. The jump combo would be yet another first, never landed in competition. On his initial try, Malinin was slightly off axis and skidded out of the axel sideways. There was a brief clatter as he went down, gathering frost on his pants.

For the next hour, the scene repeated itself. Music, a jump, and a trip or stumble out. At one point, Malinin slammed his fists on his thighs in frustration. After another skid and lurch, he stamped a skate on the ice so hard that chips flew up, enough to fill a martini glass. His father trailed him on the ice, murmuring. Finally, Malinin managed to hit the combination.

A little over a week later, two days after his 21st birthday, Malinin skated onto the ice for the International Skating Union Grand Prix, in Nagoya, Japan. Just seconds into his short program, he stumbled out of the quad axel–toe loop combination, as he had in practice. The miss left him in a surprising third place. A reporter asked if it would affect his confidence. He replied evenly, “Not really.”

By the time a skater performs a

Ilia Malinin
at the Junior
Grand Prix in
Lake Placid, New
York, in 2019,
at the age of 14



Roman
Skorniakov
and Tatiana
Malinina
at the 2002
Olympic
Games in
Salt Lake
City



jump in front of judges, “they’ve landed hundreds of them—and missed thousands,” the NBC commentator and former Olympian Johnny Weir told me. Shade, Malinin’s co-agent, said she has seen Malinin hit nine quads in practice,

without missing. But landing big jumps in competition, when adrenaline duels with cortisol, is more difficult. And Malinin has compounded this difficulty by continually trying to do the unprecedented.

On the afternoon we spoke, I asked how he felt about the pressure. Malinin straightened and leaned forward on the sofa. “Okay, there’s different ways to word it,” he said. “*Pressure* is—it’s not a good way. It feels like a negative, and I’m not really good with dealing with pressure. I think it’s more like *status*. That’s what I call it, which makes me, like, feel more confident.”

Status: That’s what Malinin projected when he returned to the ice during the Grand Prix for his long program, with his chin uptilted. He wore a new costume by the renowned Japanese designer Satomi Ito. On his black shirtfront, golden vines moved up his torso like a map of his veins. As Malinin landed one after another of his seven fluttering quads, he gathered the audience’s attention. Something happened, a recognition in those watching him. You know greatness when you see it, because it stops the breath in your throat and triggers a great involuntary rush of an “Ohhhhhh!” As Malinin finished, he stamped his skate, as if to establish his imperium over all ice, everywhere. He won the event by almost 30 points.

Malinin contended that his performance was only about “85 percent” of what he was capable of bringing to the Olympics. He wasn’t just flexing. The flex came later, on Instagram, when he posted a video of himself in a practice rink successfully performing an unheard-of quad axel–quad axel combination, to a crashing Babymetal soundtrack. Malinin’s Instagram feed tends to be a good preview of what to expect from him next. Lately, he has also begun teasing a quintuple jump.

Malinin started quietly working toward the quint about two years ago. Lounging on the practice rink’s sofa, he casually acknowledged that he had already successfully landed one. “In front of people?” I asked.

“My parents,” he said. *A*

Sally Jenkins is a staff writer at The Atlantic.



Every Nation for Itself

President Trump wants to return to the 19th century's international order. He will leave America less prosperous—and the whole world less secure.

The Trump administration's National Security Strategy made it official: The American-dominated liberal world order is over. This is not because the United States proved materially incapable of sustaining it. Rather, the American order is over because the United States has decided that it no longer wishes to play its historically unprecedented role of providing global security. The American might that upheld the world order of the past 80 years will now be used instead to destroy it.

Americans are entering the most dangerous world they have known since World War II, one that will make the Cold War look like child's play and the post-Cold War world like paradise. In fact, this new world will look a lot like the world prior to 1945, with multiple great powers and metastasizing competition and conflict. The U.S. will have no reliable friends or allies and will have to depend entirely on its own strength to survive and prosper. This will require more military spending, not less, because the open access to overseas resources, markets, and strategic bases that Americans have enjoyed will no longer come as a benefit of the country's alliances. Instead, they will have to be contested and defended against other great powers.

Americans are neither materially nor psychologically ready for this future. For

eight decades, they have inhabited a liberal international order shaped by America's predominant strength. They have grown accustomed to the world operating in a certain way: Largely agreeable and militarily passive European and Asian allies cooperate with the United States on economic and security issues. Challengers to the order, such as Russia and China, are constrained by the combined wealth and might of the U.S. and its allies. Global trade is generally free and unhampered by geopolitical rivalry, oceans are safe for travel, and nuclear weapons are limited by agreements on their production and use. Americans are so accustomed to this basically peaceful, prosperous, and open world that they tend to think it is the normal state of international affairs, likely to continue indefinitely. They can't imagine it unraveling, much less what that unraveling will mean for them.

And who can blame them? According to Francis Fukuyama, history "ended" in 1989 with the triumph of liberalism—even the primal human instinct toward violence was "fundamentally transformed." Who needed a powerful America to defend what was destined to prevail anyway? Since the end of the Cold War, influential critics have been telling us that American dominance is superfluous and costly at best, destructive and dangerous at worst.

By Robert Kagan

Some pundits who welcome a post-American world and the return of multipolarity suggest that most of the benefits of the American order for the U.S. can be retained. America just needs to learn to restrain itself, give up utopian efforts to shape the world, and accommodate “the reality” that other countries “seek to establish their own international orders governed by their own rules,” as Harvard’s Graham Allison put it. Indeed, Allison and others argue, Americans’ insistence on predominance had caused most conflicts with Russia and China. Americans should embrace multipolarity as more peaceful and less burdensome. Recently, Trump’s boosters among the foreign-policy elite have even started pointing to the early-19th-century Concert of Europe as a model for the future, suggesting that skillful diplomacy among the great powers can preserve peace more effectively than the U.S.-led system did in the unipolar world.

As a purely historical matter, this is delusional. Even the most well-managed multipolar orders were significantly more brutal and prone to war than the world that Americans have known these past 80 years. To take one example, during what some call the “long peace” in Europe, from 1815 to 1914, the great powers (including Russia and the Ottoman empire) fought dozens of wars with one another and with smaller states to defend or acquire strategic advantage, resources, and spheres of interest. These were not skirmishes but full-scale conflicts, usually costing tens—sometimes hundreds—of thousands of lives. Roughly half a million people died in the Crimean War (1853–56); the Franco-Prussian War (1870–71) resulted in about 180,000 military and up to 250,000 civilian deaths in less than a year of fighting. Almost every decade from 1815 to 1914

included at least one war involving two or more great powers.

Today’s equivalent of 19th-century multipolarity would be a world in which China, Russia, the United States, Germany, Japan, and other large states fought a major war in some combination at least once a decade—redrawing national boundaries, displacing populations, disrupting international commerce, and risking global conflict on a devastating scale. That was the world as it existed for centuries prior to 1945. To believe that such a world can never return would seem to be the height of utopianism.

PRECISELY TO ESCAPE this cycle of conflict, the generations of Americans who lived through two world wars laid the foundations of the American-led liberal world order. They were the true realists, because they had no illusions about multipolarity. They had lived their entire lives with its horrific consequences.

After 1945, instead of reestablishing a multipolar system, they transformed the United States into a global force, with responsibility for preserving not just its own security but the world’s. Doing so meant checking the rise of regional hegemons, especially in Europe and East Asia. They did this not because they wanted to

re-create the world in America’s image, but because they had learned that the modern world was interconnected in ways that would ultimately draw the United States into the great-power conflicts of Eurasia anyway.

No country had ever before played the role that the traditionally aloof United States took on after 1945. That is partly because no other power had enjoyed America’s unique circumstances—largely invulnerable to foreign invasion, because of its strength and its distance from the other great powers, and thus able to deploy force thousands of miles from home without leaving itself at risk. This combination of geography and reach allowed the United States after World War II to bring peace and security to Europe and East Asia. Nations scarred by war poured their energies into becoming economic powerhouses. That made global prosperity and international cooperation possible.

Perhaps more extraordinary than America’s ability and willingness to play the dominant role was the readiness of most other great powers to embrace and legitimize its dominance—even at the expense of their own potency. In the decades after 1945, almost all of the countries that had fought in the world wars gave up their territorial ambitions, their spheres of interest, and even, to some extent, power itself. Britain, France, Germany, and Japan not only relinquished centuries of great-power thinking and conduct but placed their security and the well-being of their people in the hands of the distant American superpower.

This was truly aberrant behavior and defied all theories of international relations as well as historical precedent. The normal response to the rise of a newly predominant power was for others to balance against it. Coalitions had formed to check Louis XIV, Napoleon, both imperial and Nazi Germany, and imperial Japan. Yet far from regarding the United States as a danger to be contained, most of the world’s powers saw it as a partner to be enlisted. America’s allies made two remarkable wagers: that the United States could be trusted to defend them whenever needed, and that it would not exploit its disproportionate might to enrich or strengthen itself at their expense.

The American order established harmony among the great powers within it, and left those outside it relatively isolated and insecure. All of that is now ending.

To the contrary, it would promote and benefit from its allies' economic prosperity.

This was the grand bargain of the American order after 1945. And it was what allowed for the extraordinary peace and stability of the subsequent decades, even during the Cold War. The American order established harmony among the great powers within it, and left those outside it, Russia and China, relatively isolated and insecure—unhappy with the global arrangement but limited in their ability to change it.

All of that is now ending. Trump has openly celebrated the end of the grand bargain. His administration has told Europeans to be ready to take over their own defense by 2027 and suggested that allies and strategic partners, including Japan, Taiwan, and South Korea, should pay the United States for protection. Trump has launched aggressive tariff wars against virtually all of America's allies. He has waged ideological and political warfare against European governments and explicitly threatened territorial aggression against two NATO allies, Canada and Denmark.

Meanwhile, the administration's National Security Strategy regards Russia and China not as adversaries or even competitors but as partners in carving up the world. With its significant emphasis on restoring "American pre-eminence" in the Western Hemisphere, Trump's strategy embraces a multipolar world in which Russia, China, and the United States exercise total dominance in their respective spheres of interest.

TRUMP AND HIS supporters seem to believe that the rest of the world will simply accommodate this new American approach, and that allies, in particular, will continue to tag along, subservient to a United States that cuts them loose strategically, exacts steep economic tribute from them, and seeks to establish a "concert" with the powers that directly threaten them. But the radical shift in U.S. strategy must force equally radical shifts among erstwhile friends and allies.

What does Europe do, for instance, now that it faces hostile and aggressive

great powers on both its eastern and western flanks? Not only Russia, but now the United States, too, threaten the security and territorial integrity of European states and work to undermine their liberal governments. A passive Europe could become a collection of fiefdoms—some under Russian influence, some under American influence, some perhaps under Chinese influence—its states' sovereignty curtailed and its economies plundered by one or more of the three empires. Will the once-great European nations surrender to this fate?

If history is any guide, they will choose rearmament instead. The task will be monumental. To mount a plausible defense against further Russian territorial aggression while also deterring American aggression will require not just marginal increases in defense spending but a full-scale strategic and economic reorientation toward self-reliance—a restructuring of European industries, economies, and societies. But if Germany, Britain, France, and Poland all armed themselves to the full extent of their capacity, including with nuclear weapons, and decided to forcefully defend their economic independence, they would collectively wield sufficient power to both deter Russia and cause an American president to think twice before bullying them. If the alternative is subjugation, Europeans could well rise to such a challenge.

Asian partners of the United States will face a similar choice. Japanese leaders have been questioning American reliability for some time, but Trump's posture forces the issue. He has imposed tariffs on America's Asian allies and repeatedly suggested that they should pay the United States for their protection ("no different than an insurance company"). Trump's National Security Strategy focuses intensely on the Western Hemisphere, at the expense of Asia, and the administration ardently desires a trade deal and strategic coordination with Beijing. Japan may need to choose between accepting subservience to China and building up the military capacity necessary for independent deterrence.

The recent election of a right-wing-nationalist prime minister, Sanae Takaichi, suggests which of these courses the Japanese intend to take. Trump and his advisers

may imagine that they see fellow travelers seeking to "Make Japan Great Again," but the upsurge of Japanese nationalism is a direct response to legitimate fears that Japan can no longer rely on the United States for its defense. South Korea and Australia, too, are reconsidering their defense and economic policies as they wake up to challenges from both East and West.

The consequence of a newly unreliable and even hostile United States, therefore, will likely be significant military build-ups by former allies. This will not mean sharing the burden of collective security, because these rearmed nations will no longer be American allies. They will be independent great powers pursuing their own strategic interests in a multipolar world. They will owe nothing to the United States; on the contrary, they will view it with the same antagonism and fear that they direct toward Russia and China. Indeed, having been strategically abandoned by the U.S. while suffering from American economic predation and possibly territorial aggression, they are likely to become hotbeds of anti-Americanism. At the very least, they will not be the same countries Americans know today.

Consider Germany. The democratic and peace-loving Germany of today grew up in the U.S.-dominated liberal international order. That order helped make possible West Germany's export-driven economic miracle of the 1950s, which in turn made the country an engine of global economic growth and an anchor of prosperity and democratic stability in Europe. Temptations to pursue a normal, independent great-power foreign policy were blunted both by economic interest and by the relatively benign environment in which Germans could live their lives, so different from what they had known in the past. How long Germany would be willing to remain an abnormal nation—denying itself geopolitical ambitions, selfish interests, and nationalist pride—was a question even before the present liberal world order began to unravel. Now, thanks to the American strategic shift, Germany has no choice but to become normal again, and quickly.

And just as American strategy forces the Germans to rearm, it is ensuring that

they do so in an ever more nationalistic, divided Europe. The founders of the American order worked in the postwar years to dampen European nationalism, in part by supporting pan-European institutions. The Cold War—era American diplomat George Kennan believed that European unification was the “only conceivable solution” for the German problem. Yet today those institutions are under pressure, and if the Trump administration has its way, they will disappear altogether. At the same time, the administration is trying to inflame European nationalism, especially in Germany, where it may well succeed. The right-wing nationalist Alternative for Germany is the second-largest party in Germany’s Parliament, just as the Nazi Party was in 1930.

Whether or not it succumbs to the far right, a rearmed Germany without an American security guarantee will necessarily take a more nationalist view of its interests. All of its neighbors will, too. Poland, squeezed between a powerful Germany on one border and a powerful Russia on the other, has over the centuries been repeatedly partitioned, occupied, and at times eliminated as a sovereign entity. With no distant superpower to protect them, the Poles are likely to decide to build up their own military capability, including nuclear weapons. Meanwhile, France is but one election away from a nationalist victory that will hit Europe like an earthquake. French leaders have already told the country to prepare for war against Russia. But imagine a rearming, nationalist France facing a rearmed, nationalist Germany. The two nations might find common ground against mounting threats from the United States and Russia, but they also have a complex history, having fought three major wars against each other in the 70 years before the United States helped establish a durable peace between them.

Japanese rearmament will have similar ramifications. It will heighten the nervousness among Japan’s neighbors, including South Korea, another ally now unsure of Washington’s commitment to its defense. How long before the Koreans decide that they, too, need to rearm, including with nuclear weapons, as they face a hostile and nuclear-armed North

Korea and a rearmed, possibly nuclear Japan, which has invaded and occupied Korea three times in the past?

IN A MULTIPOLAR WORLD, everything is up for grabs, and the flash points for potential conflict proliferate. The American order for eight decades provided not only security commitments to allies and partners but also common access to vital resources, military bases, waterways, and airspace—what theorists call “public goods.” In the absence of the United States playing that role, all of these once again become targets of a multisided competition.

That competition won’t be limited to Europe and East Asia. Until now, Germany and Japan have been content to rely on the United States to preserve naval access to Persian Gulf oil, for example. Now they and other rearming powers, including India, Britain, and France, will need to find new ways to take care of themselves. China has shown how this can be done. It had no navy to speak of two decades ago and no bases in the Persian Gulf. Today it has the largest navy in the world, a base in Djibouti, and cooperative arrangements with the United Arab Emirates and Oman to build facilities for China’s use.

In a multipolar world, spheres of interest become important again. For centuries, the ability to maintain and protect a sphere of interest was part of what it meant to be a great power. It was also among the most common sources of war, as the spheres often overlapped. The seemingly endless three-way struggle among Russia, Austria, and the Ottoman empire for control of the Balkans was the source of numerous conflicts, including World War I. The desire to regain or create spheres of interest was a leading motive of the three “have not” powers that helped produce World War II: Germany, Japan, and Italy.

The conclusion of that war led to a global shedding of spheres of interest. Part of what made the liberal world order liberal was the principle of self-determination enshrined in the Atlantic Charter and United Nations Charter. This principle was sometimes violated, including by the United States. But in past multipolar

orders, great powers never even had to consider the rights of small nations, and they didn’t. By contrast, the liberalism of the American order pressured powerful countries to cede sovereignty and independence to smaller ones in their orbits.

The British gradually dismantled their empire, as did the French. Germany was compelled to give up its dreams of *Mittel-europa*, just as Japan accepted the end of its sphere of interest on the Asian mainland, for which it had fought numerous wars from 1895 to 1945. Under the American-led order, these powers never attempted to regain those spheres. China after World War II was so bereft of a sphere of interest that it could not even lay claim to Taiwan, a nearby island filled with people who were once its citizens. The only remaining sphere, other than America’s, was the one the Soviet Union won at Yalta in Eastern and Central Europe. But that, too, was under pressure from the beginning, and the effort required to retain it ultimately exceeded the Soviet Union’s capacities, leading to its collapse.

The mere existence of the United States and the liberal order it supported offered small and medium powers an opportunity denied them by centuries of multipolarity. Moscow’s satellite states in Eastern and Central Europe would not have been so bent on escape had there been nothing to escape to. The American order promised a higher standard of living, national sovereignty, and legal and institutional equality. This gave nations living under the shadow of the Soviet Union an option other than accommodation, and when given the chance to leave Moscow’s control, they took it.

Various self-described realists in recent years have called on the U.S. to accept a return to spheres of interest as an alternative to unipolarity. But they have mostly acknowledged only Russian and Chinese spheres. These are problematic enough. Do we know how far China’s perception of its rightful sphere extends? Does it include Vietnam? All of Southeast Asia? Korea? How about what China calls the First Island Chain, which includes Japan? Russia’s traditional sphere of interest from the time of Peter the Great always included

the Baltic states and at least part of Poland. Vladimir Putin is openly emulating Peter and is frank about his desire to restore the Soviet empire as it existed during the Cold War.

To recognize Russia's and China's spheres of interest would mean accepting their hegemony over a swath of nations that currently enjoy sovereign independence. And in this emerging new world, Russia and China will not be the only ones seeking to expand their spheres. If Germany and Japan need to become great powers again, they will have spheres of interest too, which will inevitably overlap with China's and Russia's, leading to numerous conflicts in the multipolar future just as in the multipolar past.

Which brings us to the much-trumpeted idea of a new accord among the United States, China, and Russia, equivalent to the 19th century's Concert of Europe. A successful arrangement would have to settle on boundaries for their relative spheres of interest. Is such an agreement possible?

The answer is no, because the new multipolar world will not have the same qualities as the one that prevailed two centuries ago. Metternich's Austria was a status quo power, interested only in protecting a conservative order against its liberal challengers. Bismarck regarded his newly unified Germany in the late 19th century as "satiated." They both sought an equilibrium to hold on to what they had, not to get more.

But China and Russia are not at all satiated, status quo powers. They are dissatisfied, have-not powers. Since the end of the Cold War, they have been chronically unhappy with American global

supremacy and sought to restore what they regard as their natural and traditional regional dominance. Even today, China exercises only partial mastery over Southeast Asia, and it doesn't control Taiwan, much less enjoy what it would deem the proper subservience from Japan and South Korea. Russia, too, is only in the early stages of rebuilding its traditional sphere in Eastern and Central Europe. Ukraine is not the end but the beginning of Putin's envisioned order.

What kind of arrangement with the United States could satisfy these ambitions? Not one that simply codifies the status quo, as the Concert of Europe attempted to do. It would have to accommodate the radical geopolitical transformation of Europe and Asia that Russia

and China each view as essential, and for which Russia, at least, has been willing to go to war. Such a transformation will not be a pleasant process for the small and medium powers forced to give up their independence and accept domination by Beijing, Moscow, or Washington—and perhaps eventually by Berlin, Tokyo, or who knows who else. If the first four decades of the 20th century taught us anything, it is that achieving a stable peace with have-not powers is hard. Every nation or territory conceded to them strengthens and emboldens them for the next demand.

In fact, Beijing and Moscow have neither the desire nor the need for any restraining accord with the United States. On the contrary, they have every reason to believe that this is the moment to press on.



Xi Jinping has spoken of “great changes unseen in a century,” which offer China a “period of strategic opportunity.” For Putin, Trump’s destruction of the transatlantic alliance is such a “great change.” Why shouldn’t he seize this opportunity? He can’t know how long the Trump phase will last in the United States, and if the Europeans rearm, the Kremlin’s window of opportunity may close. Until now, Putin has moved slowly, waiting six years between invading Georgia and annexing Crimea, and then another eight years before the full-scale invasion of Ukraine, which was severely hampered by America and its allies. The Americans have now shattered that solidarity, and Putin could well believe that this is the moment to speed up his plans for conquest.

This means that the first years of the new multipolar era will not be marked by adroit, mutually accommodating diplomacy, but by intense competition and confrontation. The world will look more like the brutal multipolar era of the early 20th century than like the more orderly, if still brutal, world of the 19th.

THIS IS THE new world that America is entering, voluntarily shorn of its greatest assets. The influential Chinese strategic thinker Yan Xuetong once observed that the most important gap between the United States and China was not military or economic power, both of which China could amass. It was America’s global system of alliances and partnerships.

When Russia or China went to war, it went alone. When the United States went to war, even in an unpopular conflict like Iraq, it had the support of dozens of allies. American military-power projection has depended on bases all around the world, provided by nations that trusted the United States as a partner and have been willing to overlook the inconveniences of hosting American soldiers. But they may reconsider if the U.S. no longer guarantees those nations’ security and instead wages economic warfare against them and makes political and ideological demands that they find offensive. Trump officials seem to expect European and Asian countries to

join the United States whenever Washington needs or wants them—to put pressure on China, for instance—even as the U.S. offers them nothing in return. But can you ditch your allies and have them, too?

It would be one thing if the United States really was retreating within its hemisphere, reverting to its 19th-century isolation and indifference to global affairs. But among the most remarkable things about this administration’s foreign policy is that, for all the talk of “America First,” Trump evinces seemingly unlimited global ambition. He enjoys wielding American power even as he depletes it. In his first year back in office, he launched strikes against Iran and Syria; threatened to seize Canada and Greenland; decapitated Venezuela’s government and promised to “run” the country; meddled ineffectually in wars in Southeast Asia, Central Africa, and the Middle East; and even proposed construction projects in the Gaza Strip that would have to be defended by American forces.

Is this what “restraint” looks like? Trump’s intellectual cheerleaders extol him for abandoning the “nonsensical utopian goals” of “clueless elites,” but in the next breath praise him for seeking nothing less than to “reshape” the entire world. Reshape it to what end? To line Trump’s pockets and bring him glory?

Trump’s megalomania is transforming the United States from international leader into international pariah, and the American people will suffer the consequences for years to come. Germany’s chancellor in 1916, Theobald von Bethmann Hollweg, worried that his nation’s behavior risked making it “the mad dog among nations” and would provoke “the condemnation of the entire civilized world.” He was right. German leaders were proud of their unflinching “realism,” and believed that the frank and brutal pursuit of self-interest was simply what nations did. But as the historian Paul Kennedy noted, Germany’s constant appeal “to the code of naked *Machtpolitik*” helped unite the world’s great powers in bringing about Germany’s defeat.

The Trump administration revels in the pursuit of self-interest and the exercise of strength for its own sake, with

gleeful disregard for the interests of others. As Trump’s first-term national security adviser H. R. McMaster put it in an essay co-written with the economist Gary Cohn, the world is not a “global community,” but “an arena where nations, nongovernmental actors and businesses engage and compete for advantage,” and in this world of *Machtpolitik*, the United States enjoys “unmatched” power. But for how long? McMaster’s formulation, like Trump’s exaltation of selfishness, rests on profound ignorance of the true sources of American strength. So much of America’s influence in the world has derived from treating others as part of a community of democratic nations or of strategic partners.

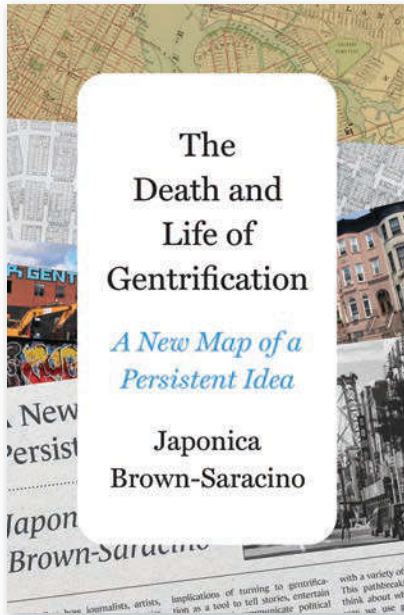
Others see this, even if many Americans don’t. Yan, the Chinese thinker, observed that one of the elements holding the American order together was America’s reputation for morality and respect for international norms. Theodore Roosevelt, often regarded as the quintessential American realist and no slouch in the wielding of power, believed that great nations ultimately had to be guided by an “international social consciousness” that considered not just their own interests but also “the interests of others.” A successful great power, he observed, could not act “without regard to the essentials of genuine morality.”

For decades, much of the world supported a United States that acted on these principles and accepted America’s power, despite its flaws and errors, precisely because it did not act solely out of narrow self-interest—much less in the narrow, selfish interest of a single ruler.

That era is over. Trump has managed in just one year to destroy the American order that was, and he has weakened America’s ability to protect its interests in the world that will be. If Americans thought defending the liberal world order was too expensive, wait until they start paying for what comes next. *A*

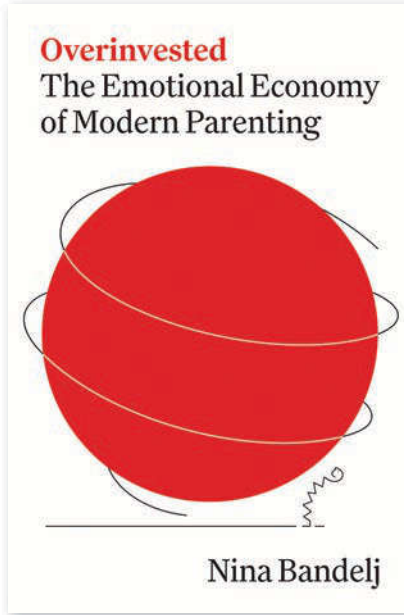
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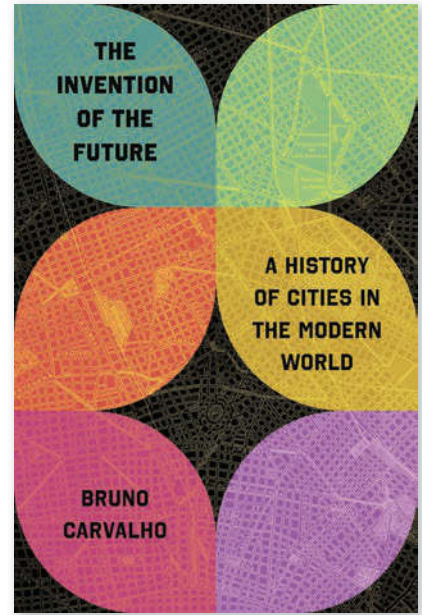


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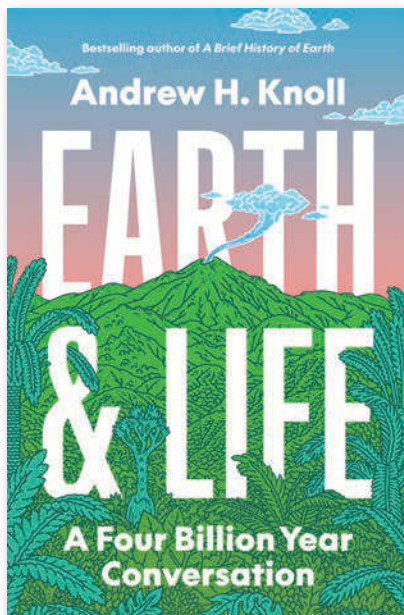


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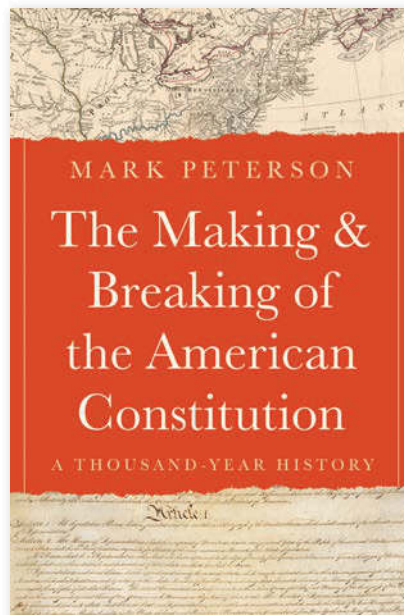
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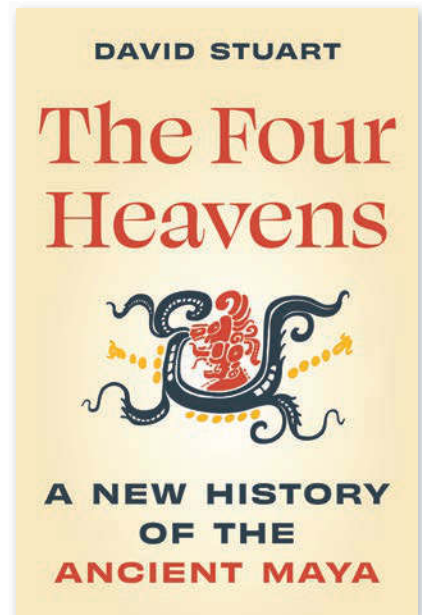
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Illustration by Denise Nestor

Never Say No

*Does Pam Bondi
have any red lines?*

By Stephanie
McCrummen

By the time she faced her first oversight hearing before the Senate Judiciary Committee, Pam Bondi had become a person she never really wanted to be. She had told a reporter once that in college she'd wanted to be a pediatrician, but she ended up becoming a lawyer. She'd said that she wasn't sure she wanted to actually practice law, but she became a prosecutor. She'd told reporters that she "never dreamed" of running for political office, but she did that too, twice winning campaigns for Florida attorney general. She'd said that when Donald Trump eventually asked her to be U.S. attorney general, she "made it really clear" that she did not want the job. During his first term, she had confided to a friend that she wanted to be ambassador to Italy.

But here she was in a Senate hearing room in October, a person who had once seemed so mild, so warm, so kindhearted that she'd earned the nickname "Pambi," opening up a folder full of slap-downs, each tailored to a Democratic committee member, with notes on how to deliver them.

"I wish you loved Chicago as much as you hate President Trump," she told Senator Dick Durbin, who'd asked about the rationale for sending federal troops to his state.

"I cannot *believe* that *you* would accuse *me* of impropriety when you *lied* about your military service," she said to Senator Richard Blumenthal, referring to a matter for which he had apologized 15 years earlier, while dodging his question about why the Justice Department had dropped an antitrust case after lobbying by Bondi's former firm.

"You took money, I believe, did you, from Reid Hoffman, one of Epstein's closest confidants," she said to Senator Sheldon Whitehouse, who'd asked whether the FBI was investigating suspicious

financial activities related to the convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein, and who later said that Bondi had "made up nonsense."

"If you worked for me, you would have been *fired*," Bondi told Senator Adam Schiff.

And on it went for hours, a calculated performance that amounted to a giant middle finger to basic notions of decorum and accountability, leaving all sorts of questions unanswered, including a fundamental one that some of Bondi's old friends and colleagues back home in Florida had been asking. As one of them put it to me: "I keep asking myself, *What the fuck happened to Pam?*"

At this point, there is little mystery about who Pam Bondi has become. She is an attorney general who does not tell Trump no. During the first year of her tenure, Bondi has carried out the most stunning transformation of the Justice Department in modern American history, turning an autonomous agency charged with upholding the U.S. Constitution into one where the rule of law is secondary to the wishes of the president.

What this has meant so far includes firing more than 230 career attorneys and other employees and accepting the resignations of at least 6,000 more, gutting the Civil Rights Division and units that investigate public corruption, and challenging core American principles such as birthright citizenship and due process. It has meant turning the might of the department against Trump's political enemies, a growing list that includes former FBI Director James Comey, former CIA Director John Brennan, New York Attorney General Letitia James, Federal Reserve Chair Jerome Powell, Senator Schiff, a man who threw a sandwich at a federal agent, an Office Depot clerk who refused to print flyers for a Charlie Kirk vigil, and reportedly Minnesota Governor Tim Walz,

Minneapolis Mayor Jacob Frey, and the partner of Renee Nicole Good, who was shot and killed by a federal immigration officer on January 7. It has meant providing a legal justification for the extrajudicial killings of at least 123 people suspected of smuggling drugs, and for the operation to capture the Venezuelan president, an action that opens the door to a world in which the only law is power. And it has meant becoming the face of the Epstein-files scandal, a position that could ultimately be Bondi's undoing.

Trump's previous attorneys general were loyalists who pursued a vision of robust executive-branch authority, but they had red lines: Jeff Sessions recused himself from the Russia investigation, citing ethics concerns; Bill Barr refused to say that the 2020 election had been stolen. Bondi's willingness to do what Trump wants appears to be boundless, and yet that still might not be enough for him. Trump has reportedly been complaining in recent weeks that Bondi has not been moving as fast as he'd like in pursuing cases against his political opponents.

His frustration extends to her handling of the Epstein files, a political disaster for him that could mean legal jeopardy for her. Bondi has so far failed to comply with a federal law that required the release of all the unclassified Epstein files by December 19—millions of investigative documents known to contain not only references to Trump but potentially compromising information about some of the most powerful men in the world. After promising “maximum transparency,” Bondi has released only 12,285 out of more than 2 million documents—a delay she has blamed on the volume of the files—leading even some of Trump's supporters to abandon him and leaving Bondi under enormous pressure. Arguably, nothing less than the future of the MAGA movement and the sanctity of the U.S. Constitution depend on what the attorney general is willing to do next.

All of which raises a question: not so much what happened to Pam Bondi, but why.

A

NY ANSWER WOULD have to come from sources other than Bondi herself. A Justice Department spokesperson rejected my requests to interview Bondi. Even as the attorney general has gone on Fox News and posted selfies with MAGA-friendly media personalities, she has not given any extended interviews with mainstream news outlets since she arrived at the Justice Department, where one of her first acts was to move from the traditional corner

office of the attorney general to a far larger conference room. The space is some 100 feet long, with floor-to-ceiling windows, ornate wood paneling, and murals called *The Triumph of Justice* and *The Defeat of Justice*, the latter depicting Lady Justice as a blond woman collapsed on the ground. At this point, Bondi, who is 60, has sequestered herself within the MAGA-verse.

I went looking for the person who existed before all of that, which meant going to Tampa, where Pamela Jo Bondi grew up in a middle-class suburb between Busch Gardens and I-75, now a landscape of smoke shops, chiropractors, and strip malls moldering in the sun. Temple Terrace, a golf-course development of ranch

houses and mossy oaks, was not the best or the worst neighborhood in Tampa. Bondi came from blank-slate America.

She was the oldest of three children. Her mother, Patsy, was a teacher, and her father, Joe, was also a teacher, as well as an education professor and the mayor of Temple Terrace. His grandfather had emigrated from Sicily and was a cigar maker in Ybor City, home to Tampa's large community of Italians, Cubans, and Spaniards. Joe Bondi was an FDR Democrat, and by all accounts a generous person and the patriarch of the family. In an article in *La Gaceta*, a local trilingual paper, he spoke of himself as “an underdog” who had “lived the American dream,” and said that growing up in Ybor City, he'd developed “a strong sense of togetherness—this is something I'm happy to say I've successfully instilled in my children.” Pam was extremely close with her father and, when he died in 2013, referred to him as “my beautiful Daddy.”

She went to the local public high school down the road, also not the best or the worst. The future attorney general had Farrah Fawcett hair, served as secretary of the student council, and lost her bid for homecoming queen. She went for three years to a college that was also down the road, the University of South Florida, where her father worked, before graduating from the University of Florida, in Gainesville, with a 3.4 GPA and a degree in criminal justice. She often said she loved children, that she wanted to have a big family.

Bondi went to law school at Stetson University, half an hour outside Tampa, later telling Florida's *Business Observer*, “I wasn't certain I wanted to practice law.” Her father urged her to try the state attorney's office in Hillsborough County, where he had connections. She said yes, joining dozens of young prosecutors who worked in the courthouse in downtown Tampa, many of whom were women. The state attorney at the time was known to have a preference for blondes, among other eccentricities; one lawyer described the environment as the “Blond Ambition Tour.” Bondi adapted to a courthouse buzzing in the '90s with local corruption scandals and often surreal cases involving drugged-out teenagers, fallen baseball stars, the murder of a circus performer called Lobster Boy, and flamboyant defense attorneys with names like Boom-Boom Benito.

Although most prosecutors stayed for five or so years before moving into more lucrative private practice, Bondi stayed for nearly 20, rising from misdemeanors to the felony section, where she handled high-profile murder cases, among others. Her evaluations from that time describe an earnest and hardworking prosecutor who sometimes lacked confidence. On a five-point scale, she got fives on diligence and threes, fours, and a few fives on legal acumen. “While Pam is very capable with good potential, she unnecessarily becomes too intimidated by difficult, long, or important cases. She sometimes becomes intimidated by some attorneys as well,” read one evaluation. Others said “team player” and “my right hand” and “Through some demanding times, she has learned the meaning of the word ‘sacrifice.’”

Colleagues and others who knew Bondi then remember her as a competent, at times excellent prosecutor who was good with juries, won many convictions, and was able to convey the moral certitude necessary to seek the death penalty. A former boyfriend, Billy Howard, called her “The Paminator.” At the same time, he told

me, “Pam was very well liked—that is something she worked at. She liked to be liked.” Howard said that during their time together, he was at a high point in his career and also a “big partier.” He said that Pam called his boss, saying she was worried about Howard, a moment he now credits with possibly saving his life. “A part of her was genuine and caring and concerned, and it helped me,” he said.

Many others recalled how kind she could be, how accommodating, how Pambi. One courthouse colleague remembered how a relative of a crime victim mistook Bondi for a secretary and asked her to copy some papers, which Bondi did without hesitating or correcting the woman. “She had humility,” said this person, who, like some others interviewed for this story, requested anonymity because they feared retribution. Patrick Manteiga, the publisher of *La Gaceta*, remembered seeing Bondi at an annual event called the Governor’s Luncheon, part of the kickoff for the state fair. She was standing next to the state attorney at the time, Mark Ober, who became one of Bondi’s most important mentors. Ober was shaking hands, while Bondi supplied him with hand sanitizer.

Besides her willing persona, what began to distinguish Bondi from the courthouse crowd were her appearances on local television. She became the spokesperson for the state attorney’s office, facing cameras during big trials, becoming friendly with reporters. Bondi was good at it, and by 2000, she was making her first appearance on the *Today* show, talking about a high-profile murder case she had prosecuted. She began getting booked as a talking head on CNN, MSNBC, and Fox News.

Florida politics was trending Republican with Jeb Bush’s election as governor. Though no one I spoke with could recall Bondi expressing strong ideological views—if anything, she seemed fairly liberal—it was around this time that she switched her party registration from Democratic to Republican. She became friendly with Sean Hannity. Soon, Fox News was sending black cars to drive her to the studio to talk about sensational cases such as that of Terri Schiavo, the comatose Florida woman who became the center of a national political drama over whether to end life support. Producers would give Bondi a tape of her appearances afterward, or she’d tell friends to record her segments, and they would gather in a living room and rewatch them. “She’d be like, ‘Did I sound stupid the way I said that?’” a close friend from that time told me.

As Bondi’s local fame grew, this side of her personality grew as well, people who knew her said. She could be hyper-defensive and hyper-sensitive to criticism. “The overwhelming thing you have to understand about Pam is her debilitating insecurity—she was always assuming someone was talking about her,” the close friend told me. “Then she’d overcompensate.” At the same time,

Bondi was socially ambitious, excelling at the cocktail-party art of remembering details about people—asking about kids, a sick mother—while looking past them at the more powerful person she wanted to meet. People who experienced this spoke of being “Bondied.” She could be thoughtful and kind, yet she would exile friends at the first hint of disloyalty. She needed constant reassurance, and sometimes this came from dogs.

Pam Bondi loves dogs. Always had them, one after another. She got involved with dog shelters and dog rescue, and once pulled off to the side of a busy road and got out of her car to chase down a stray. Another dog she helped was a Saint Bernard named Master Tank. She adopted him from a shelter after he was lost during Hurricane Katrina in 2005, not long after her own Saint Bernard had died. The story has been told but bears repeating. Master Tank



Bondi with Master Tank in September 2005. She adopted the Saint Bernard after Hurricane Katrina but ultimately had to return him to his original family.

belonged to Steve and Dorreen Couture and their grandson, who was 4, recovering from the murder-suicide of his parents and losing his dog during the storm. Bondi said the dog was a “walking skeleton” and “dying from heartworms” when she adopted him. The Coutures eventually tracked down Master Tank, but instead of giving him back, Bondi hired a lawyer, who accused the Coutures of abusing the dog, which Bondi had renamed Noah. “She lied,” Dorreen told a *Palm Beach Post* columnist years later. “My little grandson begged her to take the dog home, and she refused. She thought she would just wear us down. That we were unstable people and would just quit.” The case was settled out of court, with Bondi securing visitation rights, but she never did visit. She got another dog.

Meanwhile, Bondi was attracting more attention, including, in 2006, that of Donald Trump, who was at the peak of his TV celebrity with *The Apprentice*. Bondi had been defending him on TV during his dispute with the town of Palm Beach over an enormous American flag he was flying at Mar-a-Lago. As Bondi would later tell the story, Trump called her after one such appearance. “He wanted to thank me,” she recalled in an interview with Lara Trump. “All he cared about was America.”

By 2009, Bondi had also befriended a Florida political operative named Adam Goodman. They had met on a film set where Goodman, a Republican whose specialty was television, was directing an ad for Bondi’s boss, Mark Ober. She was behind the scenes, and Goodman remembers that she kept correcting him whenever he used the word *jail*. “*Prison*,” she would say. Goodman had seen Bondi on air, and when the party needed a candidate for Florida attorney general, he thought of her. “I look at things politically, through the lens of performance,” he told me. “Both of us were into the power of performance to compel things to happen.” It helped that Bondi was familiar to voters in the largest media market in the state. If she carried Hillsborough County, she would win.

When Goodman pressed Bondi to run, she told him she had never considered it and needed time to think. He thought she might say no, but then she said yes. Goodman, who remains a Bondi ally, recalled how she “knocked it out of the park” when they filmed one of her first three-minute ads. “She loves the camera, and the camera loves her,” he said, then corrected himself. “She loves the camera because she *knows* the camera loves her.”

As time went on, reporters began noticing another quality Bondi had developed. Manteiga remembered calling her before he printed a critical story during the campaign. “And she gets on the phone with me, and she’s crying—‘Don’t print this article,’” Manteiga told me. “Crying, crying.” He hung up the phone and called a friend who worked for the *St. Petersburg Times*. “I said she was crying, and he said, ‘Yeah, she does that to us too.’ I called another reporter, and he said, ‘Yeah, she’s done that to me.’”

PEOPLE WHO KNEW Bondi during her eight years as Florida’s attorney general tend to make two observations about her. On the one hand, she seemed to have no burning political passions, other than saving dogs. No one I spoke with could point to some dramatic shift in her outlook, or to any newly blossoming conservative values. Privately, she did not express any. She did not seem to hate Barack Obama, subscribe to birtherism, or rail against the Affordable Care Act. She was not worried about the legalization of gay marriage, or gay adoption, or other issues animating the GOP base at the time.

“We talked for an hour about our bunions,” one GOP political operative recalled. “She was not ideological.”

On the other hand, Bondi was willing to make herself useful to the party. She became the public face of a multistate challenge to the ACA. She began wearing a necklace with little elephants. She defended Florida’s bans on gay adoption and gay marriage, arguing in a brief that the latter would cause “significant public harm,” even though she had many gay friends back in Tampa.

This was when some of Bondi’s friends began to wonder what was happening with her. When Bondi was home and ran into people who questioned her position, she would respond with some version of “I had to do it for the party,” or an exhausted “You have no idea how politics works,” or “I was elected to enforce the laws.” When one friend pressed her further, arguing that other attorneys general were refusing to enforce laws denying gay people rights, and telling her how some of her closest friends felt personally betrayed by what she was doing, Bondi said, “You know me. I love gay people. You know my heart.” Sometimes there were tears.

As state attorney general, Bondi was widely praised for her crackdown on opioid pill mills and for her work combatting human trafficking. But more and more, her success hinged on her willingness to be a spokesperson for the party, especially on Fox News. She appeared regularly as a legal commentator on *Hannity*, *Fox & Friends*, *America Reports*, and *The Five*, where she had a three-day stint as a guest host. “She was an accomplished, well-spoken carrier of the message,” the GOP operative, who worked



Bondi, then Florida’s attorney general, campaigns with Mitt and Ann Romney in October 2012.

on Mitt Romney’s 2012 campaign, told me, recalling Bondi’s role as a Romney surrogate. “Pam was somebody you could put out for almost anything,” this person said. “She was somebody you could put on a Sunday show.”

Bondi’s time in office coincided with a dramatic rise in lobbying of state attorneys general. Historically, the office had been a kind of political backwater. But in the years following the 1998 multistate settlement against tobacco companies, corporations aiming to head off similar litigation began donating to attorney-general campaigns and sponsoring lavish conferences for them at resorts in California or Hawaii. Bondi attended many of them. And many of her actions tracked closely with the wishes of corporate lobbyists and campaign donors.

The most well known of these was a decision by her office to drop a formal investigation into fraud and deceptive practices at Trump University, which came after Bondi had solicited a \$25,000 donation from Trump’s foundation. (A state ethics commission later stated that the timing of the decision “may raise suspicions” but found no evidence that Bondi had been “involved with the investigation or decisions regarding Trump University.”)

Soon after taking office, Bondi also pushed out two attorneys who had been among the first in the nation to expose fraudulent practices at so-called foreclosure mills; their investigation found that law firms and lending companies were using false documents to monetize foreclosures at the height of the subprime-mortgage crisis. (A Florida inspector general found “no evidence of wrongdoing” by Bondi or her department.)

Documents obtained by *The New York Times* showed that after being lobbied by the firm Dickstein Shapiro, Bondi declined to prosecute a hospital-bill-collection company accused of abusive practices, an online school accused of “unconscionable sales practices,” and online travel-reservation companies accused by Bondi’s own predecessor of improperly withholding taxes. Bondi has said that she was not unduly influenced, stating at the time that “absolutely no access to me or my staff is going to have any bearing on my efforts to protect Floridians.”



Along with the flood of corporate money to attorneys general came a sharp rise in partisanship, a trend that Bondi helped accelerate. This first became obvious at an annual conference of the National Association of Attorneys General, an event where members would elect a new president. Typically, the elections were a low-stakes formality, the title rotating regionally and, for the most part, alternating between Democrats and Republicans. But one year, Bondi threw herself into contention, mounting a mini-campaign against Jim Hood of Mississippi, a Democrat, calling GOP conferees as they sat around tables. “Are you with me?” she would ask. “It was bizarre,” a Republican attorney general from that time told me. “It was a popularity contest, like in high school. She wanted the recognition.”

Bondi lost, but the move left bitter feelings, and helped diminish the sense of trust at the national association. Bondi was eventually elected to head the Republican Attorneys General Association, where she helped lead an effort to do away with another long-standing norm, that the two parties would not fund campaigns against their incumbent colleagues. The idea was that incumbents often cooperated in a bipartisan way on complex, multistate litigation, and getting rid of them would only hinder those efforts. Bondi was part of a group that seemed to simply want more GOP wins.

“I think she did more to increase partisanship among AGs than any single AG during my tenure,” Chris Toth, an independent who led the national association, told me. “And I just don’t understand why she did that.”

Bondi’s personal life during this time was difficult. Her engagement to a wealthy ophthalmologist ended. Her father died. Some friendships became strained. In an interview during her first term, Bondi described spending 13 hours a day at the office and heading home to a rented condo in Tallahassee. She was becoming a person who said of her life, “It’s been lonely, very lonely,” and who said of her dog Luke, another Saint Bernard, “He’s my company.” Bondi would bring Luke to work. She bought him a therapeutic mattress for car trips back to Tampa.

She began bringing rescue dogs to cabinet meetings, trying to get them adopted, and posting about them on Instagram—a puppy named Baker, a shepherd mix named Zeke. “I was thrilled to introduce Rosie, the gorgeous rescue Boxer mix, at the cabinet meeting yesterday,” she posted. “Rosie is looking for a forever home.”

During this time, Bondi was becoming more entrenched in Republican circles, which for her would come to mean Trump’s circles. When she ran for reelection in 2014, Trump threw her a fundraiser at Mar-a-Lago. When the 2016 presidential primary arrived, Goodman, the operative who had first gotten her into politics, encouraged her to endorse Trump even though establishment Republicans were still keeping their distance. If Trump won, he told her, the endorsement could give her status in his administration.

“She calls me out of the blue, 9 a.m. one morning,” Goodman told me. “She said, ‘I’m going to pick you up in five minutes.’” Trump was holding a rally in Tampa that day in March. “She said, ‘We’re going to the convention center, and I’m going to endorse Trump, and I need your help on talking points.’ I’m

scribbling as we go to the convention center. It was one of those high-intensity moments and, turned out, historic moments.” In her speech, Bondi spoke of her yearslong friendship with Trump; Trump spoke of their “great relationship.”

And that was how Bondi became a person standing on the stage of the Republican National Convention in Ohio. Before a cheering prime-time audience, she declared that she loved “Donald.” She pointed to someone holding a sign calling for Hillary Clinton to go to prison. Clinton had criticized Bondi over her handling of the Trump University complaints.

“Lock her up,” Bondi said. “I love that.”

“O

H, PAM, WHY did you say that?” Chris Toth remembered saying to the television at that very moment. He was certain that she knew better.

It was around this time that Bondi’s old friends began speaking of her as someone they could no longer recognize.

“She was loved around here, just so sweet,” the courthouse colleague said. “People who knew the old Pam, we just can’t resolve it.”

“I thought, *Do I really know this person?*” the close friend remembered thinking after Bondi endorsed Trump.

The person they thought they knew was venturing ever deeper into Trump’s world. Though Bondi did not get a position in his first administration, in a way, she got something better. When she finished her second term as Florida attorney general, she joined a lobbying firm called Ballard Partners, which was co-led at the time by Trump’s 2016 Florida campaign manager, Susie Wiles, who would go on to run his 2024 campaign and is now his chief of staff.

Soon Bondi was making more money than she ever had in her life. She lobbied for Qatar. She lobbied for Amazon. She lobbied for Uber. And eventually she lobbied for Trump, joining his defense team during his first impeachment trial. She helped launch a group called Women for Trump during the 2020 campaign, greeting supporters at a mall in Pennsylvania. When Trump contested the 2020 election results, Bondi was one of the first high-profile figures to amplify the lie that the race had been stolen, rushing to Philadelphia with the Trump-campaign adviser Corey Lewandowski the day after the election, where she declared before a small crowd that Trump had “won Pennsylvania” even as votes were still being counted. Bondi went on Fox News, claiming that there was “evidence of cheating” and “fake ballots,” though she never signed her name to lawsuits with those allegations, which could have gotten her disbarred.

After rioters stormed the U.S. Capitol on January 6, 2021, Bondi remained a willing Trump operative. In testimony before the House select committee investigating the insurrection the next year, Cassidy Hutchinson, who had been an aide to then–White House Chief of Staff Mark Meadows, said that Bondi was among the Trump surrogates who had called her prior to her appearances before the committee to shore up her loyalty to Trump, or, as they often put it, “the family.” Hutchinson said the message was that she would be “taken care of” if she protected Trump,

and that they could “ruin her life” if she did not. Bondi, whom Hutchinson knew from their encounters at the White House, assumed a kind of caretaker role, calling and texting her with job opportunities in Trump world.

“This is Susie Wiles,” Bondi messaged her on Signal at one point, providing Wiles’s email address. “She’s my best friend. She’s super sweet. She’s going to love you.”

“Susie, Matt Schlapp and I had dinner with POTUS at Mar-a-Lago tonight,” read another Signal message, referring to Wiles and a GOP operative, Hutchinson recalled. “Call Matt next week. He has a job for you that we all think you’d be great in. You are the best. Keep up the good work. Love and miss you.” (Through the Justice Department spokesperson, Bondi declined to comment on Hutchinson’s testimony. At the time, she appeared on Fox News, calling the hearings “show trials.”)

Under pressure, Hutchinson wrestled with her conscience and ultimately broke away from Trump. Bondi appeared not to wrestle. She remained inside Trump world, which meant making at least \$1 million at Ballard and nearly \$3 million from shares in the Trump Media & Technology Group for consulting on the merger that created the company, according to financial disclosures covering the two years prior to her nomination as attorney general.

She would make another \$520,000 in consulting fees from the Trump-aligned America First Policy Institute, the disclosures show, where her work in the run-up to the 2024 election forecast the kind of attorney general she was willing to be. Bondi signed on to a brief supporting absolute presidential immunity from criminal prosecution for Trump when he was being investigated for 2020-election interference. In public letters and press releases, she backed a Georgia election-board official who’d claimed authority to unilaterally delay or deny the certification of election results. In April 2024, she warned election officials to do more to ensure that noncitizens could not vote, embracing a long-debunked idea that has been used to make voting more difficult and to contest election results.

Then came the day that Trump won reelection. And the day not long after that when his first nominee for attorney general, Matt Gaetz, withdrew amid concerns that allegations of sexual misconduct and drug use would sink his confirmation. And the day not long after that, the one that Bondi said she never expected would come, when Trump called and asked her to be his attorney general.

At first, she said no. She said she wanted to “go back to my great life in Florida.”

Then, as she often had, Pam Bondi said yes.

As she would later tell Lara Trump, the president, “in his way, talked me into doing this.” Bondi said that she was so devoted to Trump that if he asked her to answer the phones, “I would become the best switchboard operator ever.”

In Tampa, where she had built a wall around her home in one of the city’s best neighborhoods, black SUVs began to let the neighbors know when she was in town. In Washington, D.C., Bondi was easily confirmed, despite concerns among Democrats that she’d declined to acknowledge Trump had lost the 2020 election, and that her first loyalty would be to the president instead of the law. “I need to know that you would tell the president no

if you’re asked to do something that is wrong, illegal, or unconstitutional,” Dick Durbin said during her confirmation hearing. Bondi responded that she would “enforce the law fairly and evenhandedly.” She said that the department “must be independent and must act independently” and that “politics will not play a part.”

After Bondi was sworn in, she moved her office into the large, ornate conference room, where Joseph Tirrell, the director of the department’s ethics office, soon met her and her then-chief of staff for their first ethics briefing. Tirrell had worked in the ethics office since 2018, and had briefed the previous AG in the traditional corner office. “I had been prepared, but it was still a bit shocking,” he told me.

Tirrell said that Bondi was courteous as he went over various regulations. She had no concerns until he began explaining restrictions around accepting gifts, specifically challenge coins, the metal medallions that are given out by the military, police departments, the FBI, and other components within the Justice Department, to signify camaraderie. Trump has displayed his own collection in the Oval Office. According to Tirrell, Bondi and her chief of staff had questions about the restrictions, and a 10-minute conversation ensued. She wanted the coins.

“They were like, ‘We still need to dig deeper on this,’” Tirrell told me. “That was the only real back-and-forth we had.” (Through her spokesperson, Bondi said, “No ethics advice was ever overruled.”)

Tirrell said that in the weeks that followed the meeting, Bondi pressed to keep other gifts even after he told her she couldn’t. A box of cigars. A FIFA World Cup soccer ball. Tirrell was going back and forth with Bondi’s office about the ball when he was fired, a moment he had been half-expecting; he had recently approved pro bono legal services for then-Special Counsel Jack Smith, who investigated Trump’s role in January 6 and now is on Trump’s enemies list. Tirrell is among many employees suing the department over their dismissals, believing that they were motivated by Trump’s need for retribution rather than any wrongdoing. Bondi has said the opposite—that she is “ending the weaponization” of the department. (The Justice Department is attempting to get Tirrell’s case dismissed.)

Standing in the Great Hall when Trump visited the Justice Department in March 2025, she proclaimed that “we are going to fight to keep America safe again,” and called Trump the “greatest president in the history of our country.”

“We are so proud to work at the directive of Donald Trump,” she said.

By the end of her first year, Bondi had taken a litany of actions pleasing to the White House. She said yes to dropping the corruption case against New York City Mayor Eric Adams, allegedly in exchange for his cooperation with Trump’s deportation plans, over objections from senior prosecutors who resigned rather than cooperate; she said yes to the firing of career prosecutors even tangentially involved with investigations concerning Trump; and she said yes to an ongoing raft of pardons, including for at least 1,500 January 6 rioters, as well as dozens of MAGA loyalists, white-collar criminals, drug dealers, and business and political allies of Trump’s. Bondi defended the deployment of National Guard troops to Los

Angeles, Chicago, Memphis, and New Orleans. And she publicly stood by her then-acting deputy, Emil Bove, even after he allegedly said that colleagues might have to tell a federal court, “Fuck you,” a moment described in a whistleblower complaint. (The Justice Department declined to comment on the incident, due to ongoing litigation.) Bove is now a federal judge.

“That would be the *Honorable* Judge Emil J. Bove III to you,” Bondi said to Sheldon Whitehouse during the Senate oversight hearing in October.

Bondi kept saying yes, with one possible exception.

According to reporting by multiple outlets, Bondi had quietly raised concerns about the case against Comey, the former FBI director, after federal prosecutors in Virginia concluded that there was insufficient evidence to bring charges.

For a moment, it seemed that Bondi might say no.

But Trump was relentless. He forced the resignation of the U.S. attorney for the Eastern District of Virginia. He sent a Truth Social message to “Pam,” which he accidentally posted publicly. “What about Comey, Adam ‘Shifty’ Schiff, Leticia???” he wrote, referring to Senator Schiff and New York Attorney General Letitia James, and calling them all “guilty as hell.” “JUSTICE MUST BE SERVED, NOW!!!”

Ultimately, Bondi said yes.

She called reports of her hesitation over Comey a “flat out lie.” Trump appointed a new, inexperienced prosecutor, Lindsey Halligan, who moved forward with the indictment. A judge dismissed the case on the grounds that Halligan had been unlawfully appointed, but the Justice Department appealed the decision.

What the loyalty of Pam Bondi might require her to do next remains an open question, especially after her clumsy handling of the Epstein files. After Trump had suggested during his campaign that he would release the files, Bondi went on Fox News in February 2025 and said that a supposed Epstein client list was “on my desk,” implying that documents were about to be released. Then she invited pro-Trump social-media influencers to the White House and handed out thick binders branded “The Epstein Files: Phase 1,” a moment that immediately backfired because the binders contained no client list and little new information. Many of the influencers criticized the move as a publicity stunt that made a mockery of Epstein’s victims, and some called for Bondi to be fired. Then Bondi backtracked, issuing a joint statement with the FBI saying that in fact there was no client list, which only further enraged a MAGA faction that has been marinating for years in the Epstein scandal and conspiracy theories about global child-trafficking rings. And then came the bipartisan legislation that required Bondi to release the files.

Now she faces an exquisite dilemma: how to comply with the law while also somehow satisfying Trump, who has given conflicting statements about the files. He has called the whole matter a “Democrat hoax,” but eventually supported the legislation requiring the release, saying that “we have nothing to hide.” He has more recently lamented that documents released so far are destroying the reputations of people who “innocently met” Epstein. Trump is exasperated that the issue won’t go away and, according to *The Wall Street Journal*, has blamed Bondi for making



Bondi and Trump at a roundtable discussion at the White House in October 2025

the situation worse. Even Bondi’s friend Susie Wiles, Trump’s chief of staff, has said that the attorney general “whiffed” on the matter. When I asked the White House if I could speak with Wiles, or any allies of Bondi’s, I got no response for weeks. A spokesperson eventually emailed statements praising Bondi from Trump, Wiles, Vice President J. D. Vance, and Secretary of State Marco Rubio, all of which had already appeared in the *Journal*.

Will Bondi continue to delay the full release of the documents, risking contempt charges? Will she resign and take the blame for the fiasco? Is it possible that Bondi’s red line is not the prosecution of the president’s political enemies, or the killing of 123 people who may or may not have been drug smugglers, or the ransacking of the Justice Department, or the undermining of the Constitution, but the prospect of her own ruin? How far is Bondi willing to go for Trump?

With midterms coming, would she say yes to deploying federal monitors to interfere at polling stations? Yes to challenging election results?

Can Pam Bondi say no?

She has new friends now, a support group of women who have also said yes to Trump, including Lara Trump and Tulsi Gabbard. “We text a lot,” Bondi told Katie Miller, a former Trump-administration aide and the wife of White House adviser Stephen Miller, on her podcast last year. “We all support each other, and have each other’s backs.”

In Tampa, Bondi’s old friends are still trying to figure out what happened to the person they remember, but one of them, the close friend, told me that she has finally stopped trying. At this point, she knows. She has been friends with Bondi since their days at the courthouse in Tampa, and on through Bondi’s time as Florida attorney general, her decision to endorse Trump, and several years after that. She said that she loved Pam, that she had tried to understand Pam, to support her, to care about her, and maybe also to excuse her. She said that she is distressed by what she believes Bondi is doing to the rule of law in America, and distressed to have concluded why.

“She went cheap for power,” the friend decided, and now she has only one question left. “Was it worth it?” *A*

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Why Do Democrats Hate Winning?

By Mark Leibovich

K

en Martin has one of those resting dread faces, as if he's bracing for someone to dump a bucket of rocks on his head. His nervous eyes make him look chronically unsettled—which is probably appropriate for someone trying to run the Democratic National Committee these days.

"The political equivalent of being a fire hydrant" is how Martin describes his job, and then helpfully explains the image to anyone not grasping it: "You get pissed on by everyone." This is a favorite line and recurring theme: the put-upon chairman, always being hassled by his easily triggered constituencies.

The first time he said this to me, the week before Thanksgiving, the triggered included Martin's own employees. He had been dealing with a staff revolt following his November 12 announcement that the DNC would be ending its generous work-from-home guidelines. Everyone would be expected to return to headquarters full-time, Martin told his staff, starting in February.

This did not go over well. Thumbs-down emoji filled the Zoom screen. Employees pelted Martin with questions. He told me that he sympathized, but observed that most major public- and private-sector organizations had long since compelled their employees to return to their offices.

"If it's unbearable and it's a quality-of-life thing for you, I'm happy to help you find another job," Martin said he told his staff. The complaints persisted.

"Shocking" and "callous," the DNC's employee union said of the chairman's directive in a statement to *The New York Times*.

The squabble underscored how the Democrats can't help but keep playing to a stubborn stereotype—a soft and pampered bunch, unwilling to make the gritty sacrifices (such as getting dressed) necessary to prevail in their "existential" campaign to save democracy.

"The Democrats treat their fucking people like kindergartners," Sarah Longwell, a former Republican consultant who quit the party over Donald Trump, told me. Longwell can get exasperated by her new allies on the left. When I mentioned the DNC's in-person-work kerfuffle, it set her off.

"Republicans are over here being straight-up mercenaries," Longwell said. "Democrats give everybody Fridays off and talk about work-life balance." She apologized for yelling into the phone. Democrats "are not built for when the fascists come," she concluded.

Martin has invited similar doubts about himself. A former head of the Minnesota Democratic-Farmer-Labor Party, he won an election in February 2025 for the privilege of leading the divided, despondent, and destitute committee. He barely survived the summer after *Politico* received a leaked audiotape of a May 15 meeting in which an anguished Martin can be heard

describing the toll of his job to DNC officers: "The other night I said to myself for the first time, *I don't know if I want to do this anymore.*"

But things were looking up. Martin and I were sipping Diet Cokes at the National Democratic Club, next to the DNC headquarters, on the south side of Capitol Hill. The place was bustling, even festive, for a late Monday afternoon. Assorted House members, Hill staffers, Democratic donors, and lobbyist types clustered around tables of drinks and hors d'oeuvres. Representative Gwen Moore of Wisconsin stopped by to say hello to Martin. Others waved as they passed our table, and a few congratulated him. It had been a while since he'd been congratulated for anything.

Despite Martin's rough start in the job, the party's spirits had brightened considerably after November 4, when Democrats scored double-digit wins in the Virginia and New Jersey governor's races. Although both candidates—former House members Abigail Spanberger in Virginia and Mikie Sherrill in New Jersey—had been favored to win, their impressive margins, along with other overperformances by Democrats across the country, were viewed as hopeful signs for the 2026 midterms.

A veteran party apparatchik, Martin arrived in Washington just as Trump was returning to the White House. Even more than during his first go-round, Trump has enjoyed near-unanimous complicity from supine Republican majorities in Congress, as well as meek resistance from a dazed opposition. Martin, 52, is the harried face of this meek resistance.

I had been checking in with him periodically since the summer as part of my attempt to assess how the Democrats had managed to so thoroughly marginalize themselves. No matter how eager they were to resist Trump, they kept living up to their worst image as an overly sensitive, out-of-touch, and terminally online band of myopic and overindulged factions.

Martin himself has a knack for reinforcing these caricatures. Just as I was starting this project, he presided over the DNC's summer meeting in Minneapolis to begin the urgent work of rebuilding the Democratic coalition and making the party palatable to American voters again. Soon after calling the assembly of more than 400 party officials to order, Martin relinquished his mic to a representative of the Saginaw Ojibwe Nation for the DNC's "land acknowledgment" ritual. Switching between English and her tribal language, the Indigenous woman affirmed that Minneapolis had been stolen from its native Dakota Oyate Tribe ("the original stewards of the lands and waters").

The interlude took only a minute or two but received outsize attention—and ridicule—as an example of how Democrats remain overly concerned with performative pandering to various small identity groups. "It is difficult to imagine more than a handful of people looking out over the current hellscape of U.S. policy and thinking to themselves: *You know what we need to be sure to address today? The Dakota War of 1862,*" Andrew Egger wrote in *The Bulwark*.

"What is Ken Martin doing?" the Democrats' crank emeritus, James Carville, wondered aloud on his *Politics War Room* podcast. It is not the DNC's job to right the well-documented wrongs of

American history, Carville said. “It doesn’t exist to make people feel good. It exists—get this through your head—to win elections.”

I asked Martin if gestures like land acknowledgments were worth the trouble. He bristled. “I’ve always felt that it’s important to be an inclusive party,” he told me. This suggested that the land acknowledgments would continue.

“We’re not going to abandon who we are,” Martin said. “People can call it ‘woke’ as much as they want.” He disputed the notion that he was focused on anything other than winning in 2026.

“It’s all gas, no brakes,” Martin insisted. And imperative that “we do the work between now and November.”

Although it seems that many people at the DNC would prefer to “do the work” from home.

The DNC’s mini-mutiny over the return-to-office mandate ruined the brief elation of the off-year victories. Candidates running for office rely on massive numbers of volunteers, Virginia’s now-Governor Spanberger told me. They work their day jobs and then offer up their spare time because they believe in the cause. So it is not a good look for paid party staff to be talking publicly “about how hard it is to go into an office to get paid to do things that campaign workers do in their volunteer time,” Spanberger said.

But perhaps the deeper issue is that Democrats have historically focused too much on keeping their many constituent groups as happy as possible, sometimes at the expense of their principal goal: triumphing in elections so they can implement their policies. “First and foremost, Democrats need to get much more ruthless about winning,” Senator Elissa Slotkin of Michigan told me. This, she said, is not always compatible with the “weird consensus-based leadership” that their leaders tend toward.

As Trump has rampaged Caligula-like through his second term—draping federal buildings with massive likenesses of himself and renaming them in his honor; razing an entire wing of the White House; deploying masked agents to snatch brown-skinned people from sidewalks; running roughshod over constitutional norms, NATO, Minneapolis, and Venezuela alike—rank-and-file Democrats have shown a clear preference for Team Ruthless. *Unleash the alpha dogs*, they keep saying—*the more rabid, the better*.

“They want to win so fucking bad,” said Longwell, who has convened hundreds of focus groups across the political spectrum. Democratic leaders and political strategists need to understand that anything that does not lead to winning elections is extraneous, she said. “If you watch the DNC, you still see the pronouns on the name tags and the land acknowledgment at the start, and the voters are like, *Get that stuff out of here*.”

MY ASSIGNMENT WAS to pick through the Democrats’ post-2024 debris. I wanted to see if this once-confident multiracial coalition of working-class men and women could somehow get itself together in time for the midterms. Could the Democrats make themselves a viable alternative to the bumbling but dangerous autocrats on the other side? Are they capable of regaining some measure of power, despite themselves?

I traveled around the country and interviewed about four dozen Democratic candidates, elected officials, party leaders, operatives, and voters I met at rallies, town halls, and other gatherings. What I encountered was a political party on a search: for a winning message; for a fresh identity; for new leaders; for the elusive white knight, whatever that might look like. In the past, saviors have occasionally materialized, but rarely how a broken party imagined them. No one saw Barack Obama coming, sweeping in to define a winning coalition of Democrats in 2008. Nor, for that matter, did anyone envisage Donald Trump doing the same for Republicans eight years later. Fortunes can turn fast.

But Democrats have remained stuck in their funk for an unusually long stretch. For much of 2025, their doldrums felt much worse than the typical rough patch that parties endure after bad election defeats. They were staggered, self-pitying, and seemingly traumatized by the denouement of the Joe Biden years. They have wallowed and feuded.

They have also analyzed themselves to death. If sheer tonnage of voter case studies and white papers could rescue a party, Democrats would be set for years. My inbox overflowed with the latest theories on how Democrats had lost their way and what was needed to revive them. Dueling autopsies were produced by various advocacy groups.

“How Democrats Lost the White House,” from RootsAction, blamed party leaders. “The Working Class Project,” from American Bridge 21st Century, determined that the party’s traditional coalition of blue-collar voters has come to “perceive Democrats to be woke, weak, and out-of-touch, too focused on social issues.” “Deciding to Win,” a data-based dissection published by Welcome-PAC, argued that as Democrats have moved left on issues such as



Ken Martin, chair of the Democratic National Committee

crime and immigration, self-identified moderates and conservatives have abandoned the party. For good measure, the centrist group Third Way produced “Was It Something I Said?,” a guide to help Democrats avoid speaking “like the extreme, divisive, elitist, and obfuscatory enforcers of wokeness.” It included a handy compendium of 45 words and phrases (*dialoguing, microaggression, stakeholders, LGBTQIA+*) that the party should not use, because they create “a wall between us and everyday people.”

Of all the autopsy porn I luxuriated in, the most compelling was “How the Democrats Lost America: Making Sense of the 2024 Election and the Future of American Politics,” by Scott Ferson, a longtime Democratic campaign strategist. The exhaustive report—which will be published as a book in April—is based on more than 1,000 interviews that Ferson and his team conducted during the Trump and Biden years.

Ferson argues that in recent decades the Democratic Party has developed an “elitist problem” that has caused it to lose its connection to many Americans. The migration of low-income, non-college-educated voters to the GOP has accelerated: Scores of Black and Latino Americans joined Trump’s coalition in 2024. Recent research suggests a significant shift in how voters perceive the parties; more people now believe that Republicans best represent the interests of the poor and working class, while Democrats are coming to be viewed as the party of rich elites. (Ken Martin has called this reversal “a damning indictment” of the Democrats “that’s got to change.”) Recent presidential-election trends illustrate this turnabout. In 2012, Mitt Romney carried voters earning more than \$100,000 a year by 10 percentage points; in 2024, Kamala Harris won them by four points. In 2012, Obama won voters making less than \$50,000 a year by 22 points; in 2024, Trump won those voters by two points.

In his report, Ferson describes conversations he had with people in the districts in and around Canton, Ohio, which have been decimated by plant closures and job losses. “I think the Democrats’ message to people in Canton, Ohio, is *You should move*,” Ferson told me, adding that many Canton residents think Democrats feel superior to them and their hometown. His research also confirmed how effective conservative media have been in reducing Democrats to caricatures. “By the time we knock on their door in Pennsylvania,” Ferson said, quoting a line from the Democratic media consultant Joe Trippi, “we’re a pedophile space alien who created AI to take their job away.”

Shortly after Martin became chair, he announced that the DNC would be producing its own report on the lessons of 2024. He purposely called it an “after-action review” and not an autopsy, to emphasize that the party is “not dead.” That was reassuring.

Whatever they’re called, the various post-2024 analyses all posed the same unavoidable questions: How had the party lost the working-class voters who were once the backbone of its coalition? Would Democrats be better served by running more moderate candidates to court persuadable swing voters? Or by running more firebrand, populist types, who are better at creating excitement?

The off-year results of 2025 offered something for everyone. “Your task is going to be not to impose litmus tests,” Obama told a room of giddy Democrats during a live *Pod Save America* podcast

a couple of days after the victories. “We had Abigail Spanberger win, and we had Zohran Mamdani win, and they are all part of a vision for the future.” But Spanberger and Mamdani, who won the New York City mayor’s race, were well situated culturally and ideologically for the very different electorates they were running in. It is hard to imagine the Democratic Socialist Mamdani winning a statewide race in Virginia.

In October, Democrats nominated Aftyn Behn, a Tennessee state representative and former progressive activist, in a special election for a U.S. House seat in a heavily Republican district in the Nashville area. Behn, who once described herself as a “radical” and campaigned with the very progressive Representative Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez of New York, was portrayed by her opponent as extreme. She wound up losing by nearly nine points to the Republican Matt Van Epps. Though Democrats celebrated this as another overperformance (Trump had carried the district by 22 points in 2024), a more moderate candidate, one not nicknamed “AOC of Tennessee,” likely would have done better. “The problem is that the left just is unalterably dedicated to this proposition that if you are more radical, you will turn out more voters,” Matt Bennett, of Third Way, told *Politico*. “And it keeps being disproven over and over and over.”

But parties are stuck with whomever their voters decide to nominate. “We have to stop acting like we’re casting parts in a play,” Spanberger told me. “Like, *Oh, this person should run in Virginia, or this person feels like a good Texas Democrat*.” Candidates are going to run regardless of whether some political operative or professional opinion-haver thinks they’re sabotaging the party’s chances. And primary voters tend to vote for the candidate they personally prefer, regardless of whether that candidate has the best chance of winning a general election.

Consider the scenario playing out in Texas, where Representative Jasmine Crockett, an unrestrained liberal media magnet, is running for the Senate seat held by the Republican John Cornyn. Crockett’s gift for profane insult comedy aimed at Republicans has made her a celebrated sound-bite warrior on the left. But it is not clear that she would have a better chance of winning in red Texas than State Representative James Talarico, a 36-year-old former seminarian and aspiring minister, whose viral speeches have raised his profile, as well as a stunning amount of cash. Talarico’s faith and his relative political moderation could make him more palatable to Texans than Crockett in a general election. In January, an Emerson College poll had Talarico performing slightly better against Cornyn than Crockett in a general-election matchup.

BUT WHAT IF the main divide among Democrats today is not, as so many assume, progressive versus moderate? Slotkin told me that “*Is it Mamdani or is it Spanberger?*” is “kind of an outdated approach.” The more consequential split, she said, is between leaders willing “to fight and go on offense” and those content to wait Trump out.

Since Trump’s reelection, Democratic voters have shown a strong preference for the former. They’ve also made it clear that they think their current leaders have been soft and timid.

Seventy-one percent of Democrats and 78 percent of all Americans believe that the party has been ineffective in standing up to Trump, according to a June CBS News/YouGov survey. And 62 percent of Democrats say the party needs new leadership, a Reuters/Ipsos poll found, also in June.

If Democratic voters perceive a candidate to be principled and unrelenting, they have been more than willing to look beyond acres of red flags. Graham Platner, a gravelly voiced oyster farmer who is running for Senate in Maine to supplant the Republican forever-incumbent, Susan Collins, offers a case in point: Platner, a political neophyte at 41, spent much of his adult life in the combat thickets of Iraq and Afghanistan before pivoting to mollusks. His campaign started off like gangbusters in August, attracting huge crowds and millions in donations. Reporters flowed to Sullivan, Maine, for an audience with the burly oysterman (just as soon as they were done with the Jesus-loving Democrat in Texas).

"My plan is to just bribe reporters with oysters," Platner told me as he shucked a few fleshy ones from a cage he'd pulled in. It was a windy morning in early September, and we were out on the white-capped waters of Sullivan Harbor, near Acadia National Park. "Working-class populist" is how Platner described himself. "I'm a small-business owner. And I also own an immense amount of firearms."

If this was a casting call, Platner nailed it: flannel shirts, weathered caps, a pro wrestler's voice. "I'm a fucking oyster farmer from Sullivan, for God's sake," he told me at one point, which might as well go on a bumper sticker.



Representative Jasmine Crockett,
*of Texas's Thirtieth Congressional
District, is running for the Republican
John Cornyn's Senate seat.*

Platner seemed a far more compelling character than Maine's 78-year-old governor, Janet Mills, the candidate preferred by the party establishment. To his excited supporters, Platner might just be the Democrats' perfect populist insurgent for Maine.

Well, maybe not perfect. Okay, not at all perfect.

Like shellfish, political newcomers only stay fresh for so long before they start to smell. Old Reddit posts can surface. Such as the one where the candidate remarked that some white rural Americans were stupid and racist. Or the ones that were homophobic or misogynistic. Or the anti-police one. Platner, who called his Reddit comments "indefensible," attributed the "dark feelings" reflected in them to his time in the infantry. Chairman Martin called the old posts "hurtful" but not "disqualifying."

Next came a swell of questions about the large tattoo that Platner had on his chest, a skull and crossbones widely recognized to be a Nazi death's-head. He claimed that he had been ignorant of the insignia's Third Reich associations, and that he had gotten the ink done in Croatia following a drunken night out with his Marine pals in 2007. When the tattoo became a campaign issue, he hastily got it covered over.

It would be nice if Democrats could find a working-class-hero candidate who was not sullied by, say, a Nazi tattoo. But Platner's early support has proved durable. His supporters blame the surfacing of his old comments on a smear campaign engineered by the establishment and the party's rich patrons, who are scared of an unfiltered populist outsider who owes them nothing.

"I think he's running a really good campaign," Senator Bernie Sanders told me. "It saddens me very much that instead of engaging in a real debate about the future of America, we have some people in the Democratic leadership trying to destroy him." Sanders said he believes that Platner "stands an excellent chance to be the next senator from Maine."

As he navigated the choppy waters in his boat, Platner splashed from topic to topic. He talked about the finer points of oyster farming, his love of soccer and of Maine's native osprey, how therapy had saved him after his return from combat, and various other things.

"I do love gays," he said at one point. (Good to know!) "Somebody asked me where do I stand on LGBTQIA+," Platner added.

"What does IA+ stand for?" I asked him.

"That's actually a good question."

Platner said that in an earlier speech, he'd just said "LGBTQ." After thinking for a moment, he posited that the Q, I, and A stand for "queer, intersex, and androgynous."

"But what's the plus?" I asked.

"Everything else," he said.

Platner's broader argument is that although his campaign is focused on the "material conditions that people are living in"—hospital closures, housing shortages, affordability—he is not willing to compromise on social issues at the expense of vulnerable populations. "I don't think there is any value, both morally but also politically, in selling people out," Platner said.

His aide interjected with a correction: In fact, the A in LGBTQIA+ stands for "asexual," not "androgynous." The candidate regretted the error.

"It's *asexual*, sorry," Platner said. "It's *asexual*."

THOUGH THE DEMOCRATS may have been buoyed by November's elections, it is hard to overstate how far the party had fallen.

At the start of August, the DNC had \$13.9 million cash on hand, compared with \$84.3 million for the Republican National Committee. A *New York Times* analysis found that from 2020 to 2024, Democrats lagged Republicans in new-voter registrations in all 30 states that track registrations by party. Polls kept drawing a bleak picture of the party's popularity. Over the summer, Gallup measured the party's approval rating at 34 percent, its lowest point since Gallup began tracking partisan approval ratings, in 1992; a *Wall Street Journal* poll had the Democrats at 33 percent approval; a CNN poll put their approval rating at a wretched 28 percent.

Representative Jason Crow of Colorado, who co-leads the Democrats' candidate-recruiting efforts for the House, told me Democrats need to project confidence in their policy positions: "People respond to confidence, and they respond to strength." But because Trump and the Republicans have been so effective in slapping extreme liberal caricatures on their opponents, Democrats are gun-shy. "We can't be apologetic for our own positions, and second-guessing ourselves, and being weak and timid about it," Crow said.

"I've never seen the party so unsure of itself, and so kind of lacking its own footing," Colin Allred, the former NFL player and representative from Texas who lost the 2024 Senate race to Ted Cruz, told me. Allred, who is running for a Dallas-area House seat, described the state of the Democratic Party's brand as "terrible."

"We are living through hell right now, let's be honest," Mallory McMorrow, a Democratic candidate for U.S. Senate in Michigan, told me. But McMorrow, a 39-year-old state senator and former bartender, sounded oddly buoyant, perhaps because she sees the 2026 midterm campaigns as a chance to clear out the old bones of the party establishment. The party "has not been prepared for this moment," McMorrow said. "It is inexcusable to go on national television and say things like 'Well, Democrats aren't in charge right now, so we can't do anything.' Why would anybody vote for you?"

And yet, despite the Democrats' abysmal approval ratings—and their repeated, self-parodying demonstrations of why they might deserve them—voters have shown a consistent preference for them in recent months. Since Trump took office, Democrats have flipped 25 state legislative seats that had been held by Republicans, while Republicans have flipped zero seats held by Democrats. For all their dysfunction and malaise, Democrats have this key dynamic going for them: The party in power tends to overreach, mess up, and then take most of the blame when voters get cranky. This is a far more reliable blueprint for a party's resurrection than anything drawn up at a think tank.

True to form, voters have overwhelmingly blamed Republicans for what they see as a gloomy state of national affairs. Americans broadly disapprove of how Trump has handled the economy, immigration, and the cost of living—the three issues most responsible for putting him back in the White House. The Republican policy agenda has proved disastrously unpopular: A November



Graham Platner, a Maine oysterman and controversial political newcomer beloved of the populist left, is running in the Democratic primary in hopes of taking on long-serving Republican Senator Susan Collins.

Gallup poll put Trump's approval rating at 36 percent, a low for his second term, and at just 25 percent among independents.

But none of this should be confused with a national wave of love for the opposition party. On the contrary, Democrats in Congress scored a particularly dismal 18 percent approval rating in a Quinnipiac University poll released in mid-December, a record low.

Yet the DNC apparently prefers to tune this out. The day after the Quinnipiac poll was published, Martin announced that the committee's deep-dive review of the 2024 debacle would not be released after all. In other words, while the Democratic brand continued to flatline, the autopsy itself was declared dead in the cradle—this despite DNC officials having conducted more than 300 interviews and Martin having previously called the autopsy a crucial exercise.

I'd spoken with several Democratic politicians and operatives who hoped that the memorandum, which would benefit from the DNC's resources and access to party officials, could be an important addition to the canon of wonkery. It could help determine, for instance, which candidate profiles would work best in certain districts and states, how much blame Joe Biden deserved for 2024, and what, if anything, Kamala Harris could have done differently. But what the DNC essentially declared at the end of 2025 was *Never mind*. Releasing the DNC report,

Martin suggests, would distract from the party's work. Martin also seemed intent on cramming as many buzz phrases (and banned words) as possible into his official statement about the decision to scuttle the project: "In our conversations with stakeholders from across the Democratic ecosystem, we are aligned on what's important, and that's learning from the past and winning the future." He continued, "Here's our North Star: does this help us win? If the answer is no, it's a distraction from the core mission."

Here is Martin's north star, based on his first year at the DNC: proceed with extreme caution and commit no microaggressions.

Martin's decision to bury the DNC's findings invited suspicion and derision. Simon Bazelon, the lead author on the "Deciding to Win" project, told *The New York Times* that the aborted autopsy is sadly consistent with the Democratic leadership's general penchant for complacency, risk aversion, and avoidance.

"It's reflective of a broader problem within the party," Bazelon said. "We are scared of ever making anybody in our coalition upset."

"DEMOCRATS ARE PUSSIES."

Senator Ruben Gallego of Arizona was on the phone, and I was telling him what I kept hearing about his party. Gallego, a former Marine and an Iraq War veteran, did not disagree. This was no surprise, because he has cultivated a reputation for bluntness, and the media have held him up as the Democrats' ambassador to the regular-bro types who supported Trump by large margins.

During his winning Senate campaign in 2024, Gallego held events in boxing gyms and touted the appeal of a "big-ass truck" (apparently his attempt to buck the perception that Democrats drive only puny-ass Priuses and Jettas). Gallego is confident that none of the pejoratives affixed to Democrats—*weak*, *feckless*, *timid*—applies to him.

"I just called the president an idiot on national TV, so I'm not exactly the person to talk about it," he told me.

Gallego, who is 46, prevailed in his Senate race despite a rough performance by Democrats nationally. Latino men supported him by 30 points, despite Trump carrying about half that group across the country. Everyone was asking who the Trump-Gallego voters in Arizona were, Gallego said. "A lot of them were just men who said, 'Ruben Gallego is a fighter.'"

Or, not a pussy.

I intentionally used that word because I'd heard so many others use it to describe Democrats, typically while conveying how impotent their elected leaders have been in standing up to Trump's serial abuses. "Yes, exactly, I totally agree," Gallego said. But he was hesitant to be quoted using that word specifically, and he asked to go off the record.

Back on the record, Gallego told me he'd won in Arizona because those Trump-Gallego voters said, "Ruben is not a *wussy* like these other Democrats." One could see why a politician would not want to utter *pussy* on the record, given its crass anatomical connotation (Gallego wussed out). These are sensitive times, after all, even for big-ass-truck-loving fight-fans.

Being a Democrat can be exhausting sometimes. So many considerations, so many shifting sensitivities and cancelable offenses.

TRUMP'S STEAMROLLING of anything, including the Constitution, that might impede his authoritarian project has made the limpness of the Democratic opposition more conspicuous.

"What we've allowed to become normalized is completely deviant," California Governor Gavin Newsom told me in the fall. "This is code red." Newsom said that although he longs for the "*When they go low, we go high* shit," this is no time for the usual political bromides and tactics. Democrats need to go beyond writing a concerned "op-ed that lands in *The New York Times*," he added, which "we can retweet—to the 12 of us—and say how proud we are about our prose."

Newsom said the Democrats need to get out of their own heads and enclaves and start acting with a desperation commensurate with the moment. If the Democratic Party remains weak, "we will get rolled," Newsom said. "Weakness is the toxicity of our brand."

Among nationally known Democrats, it is Newsom's political standing that may have risen the most amid the dark Trumpian doings of 2025. The governor's willingness to mock the president through aggressive social-media parody elevated him to de facto resistance leader. Given voter impatience with wimpy party leaders, a righteous showdown with Trump is not a bad situation for an ambitious Democrat to be in. Newsom was also willing, at great risk to himself politically, to counter GOP efforts to gerrymander red-state House districts. He blew up California's nonpartisan redistricting laws and led a successful ballot initiative to redraw the state congressional map to favor the Democrats.

As I spoke with Newsom, I realized that pretty much everything he said was some variation of "Desperate times call for desperate measures." Conversations with him on this topic tend to be a bacchanal of profanity and exasperation. "Wake the fuck up; wake the fuck up," he kept saying. "This thing is being torn down."

Newsom's aggressive trolling of Trump has helped combat the long-standing view of him as a slick opportunist and has won him new admirers. "When people see someone fighting, they get really, really excited, and when they see someone folding, they get really, really demoralized," Beto O'Rourke, the former representative from Texas and onetime presidential candidate, told me. "Gavin Newsom, who frankly I just wasn't necessarily a big fan of before, I'm a big fan of right now. That guy's a fighter."

There's a need for fighters, O'Rourke said, because Trump is now a "cornered animal"—one that happens to be "the most powerful animal in the country, who controls the House, the Senate, the White House, the Supreme Court, the National Guard, and has a secretary of defense who is in concert with him on using American cities as the training grounds for the military. So this is some dark stuff."

I couldn't help noticing that O'Rourke's voice acquired a kind of dreamy cadence as he described the darkness. Nothing like a potential Armageddon for American democracy to get a graying former golden boy—he is now 53—excited. "It's also this extraordinary moment," O'Rourke continued, "where all of us who are alive today get this chance to save the country. We're going to be tested in a way I don't think you and I can even imagine."

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ONE RECURRING RESENTMENT among Democratic voters is the disconnect between the party's red-alert anti-Trump rhetoric and the musty vehicles—Biden and Harris, as well as Hakeem Jeffries, Chuck Schumer, and the various other dust-gatherers—it keeps deploying to resist him. “People continue to say, ‘Oh my God, Trump is an authoritarian; the world’s going to end,’ all this stuff,” David Hogg, the 25-year-old gun-control activist and advocate for recruiting young progressive leaders, told me over the summer. Hogg, who had a brief and tumultuous stint as a DNC co-vice chair in early 2025, is contemptuous of the party’s lingering cohort of elder leaders.

“It’s like, ‘Okay, look who your members of Congress are: Some of them literally cannot stand for a press conference,’” he said. “You cannot credibly tell the American people that democracy

is in danger and the world is ending, and the people that you are putting up on the front lines of fighting back against that genuinely belong in a nursing home.”

On that note, I headed to a Bernie Sanders rally.

“We are living in a moment that is unprecedented in the modern history of this country,” Sanders roared. The socialist senator from Vermont was speaking to a packed theater of about 3,000 people in Wheeling, West Virginia. “We have got to act in an unprecedented way in response.”

Sanders, who turned 84 in September, seems to have earned immunity from the party’s anti-gerontocratic agitators. When I saw him this past summer, he was making a stop on the Fighting Oligarchy tour, which has consistently drawn fiery hordes across the country. At times, he’s been joined by Democratic Socialists of America luminaries such as Mamdani and Ocasio-Cortez. The three of them filled a stadium in Queens for a raucous rally in October, which featured chants of “Tax the rich.” Two of the Senate candidates drawing the most enthusiasm from the left—Platner in Maine and Abdul El-Sayed in Michigan—are Sanders acolytes.

These days, the far left is attracting a lot of the party’s money, media attention, and crowds. But whether this energy on the left represents the Democrats’ path to restoration or to electoral doom depends on whom you ask (or which white paper you read). A remarkable 66 percent of Democrats say they have a positive view of socialism, compared with only 42 percent for capitalism, according to an August Gallup poll.

Sanders strolled onstage in Wheeling to protracted applause and chants of “Bernie!” “I was told that West Virginia was a conservative state,” Sanders said as he hunched over a small podium. It was certainly a Trump state: The president won 70 percent of the vote there in 2024, his second-biggest margin in the country, behind Wyoming.

But West Virginia is a proletarian locale that until not long ago was a Democratic stronghold. Bill Clinton carried it twice in the ’90s; in 1988, it was one of the 10 states that Massachusetts Governor Michael Dukakis won in his otherwise thumping defeat at the hands of the patrician George H. W. Bush.

“We are losing working-class voters—the core of our coalition since the New Deal—to a corrupt billionaire with a gold toilet,” Dan Pfeiffer, a former top Obama adviser, wrote in his Message Box newsletter. A critical mass of working-class voters has deemed said gold-toilet user to be their kind of tough; they like that he professes to fight for them, and they don’t care that he fights dirty.

A lot of working-class voters prefer Trump, Graham Platner told me, because they believe he intuitively understands that they feel screwed by the world, just as Trump—the billionaire president—himself does. But running against a “rigged deal” was once the main Democratic message. Sanders had been delivering it for decades before Trump came along; the Fighting Oligarchy speeches are essentially the same ones Sanders has been giving for five decades. What’s happening in America today, Sanders declared, with several million working-class people at risk of losing their health care, is an acceleration of what has gone on for half a century: Life gets better and better for the wealthiest Americans—and worse for everyone else.

"You know what happens when people can't go to a doctor when they need to?" Sanders asked the crowd.

"They die!" the crowd responded.

Keep hope alive this is not. But the audience was on its feet and in full frenzy as Sanders revved up his rhetorical bus and set his sights on ... Kamala Harris. Why had she lost?

"One of the reasons," Sanders said, "is she had too many billionaires telling her not to speak up for the working class of this country."

The line drew the loudest cheer of the evening.

A BIG THING for Democratic politicians these days is to swear a lot, as if by appearing pissed off and profane, they will show how raw and real they are. Since February 2025, they have sworn more often than their Republican counterparts, according to a *Washington Post* analysis of social-media posts and public remarks. (The big wins, they just keep piling up for the Democrats.)

One detects in this penchant for profanity a whiff of overcompensation—an effort by Democrats to prove that they can talk working-class. Ken Martin says that the party needs to stop being so cautious. "The problem we have as Democrats is we throw a punch, and then we pull it back," he told me. "We don't want to get canceled by someone in our party." I was eager to test this proposition, given that Martin is steeped in the cautious language of the Democratic big tent; God forbid he ever utter something hurtful or make someone feel (*double God forbid*) unsafe or triggered.

So I asked Martin: What about Biden? Specifically, his fiasco of a presidential campaign. Didn't he wait too long to bow out, and wasn't it dumb for him to have run in the first place?

"It's an academic exercise," Martin said, ducking the question. "Do you have a time machine?"

I do not.

"The point is," Martin continued, "we don't know for sure whether he should've or shouldn't have, and we can't change it."

"He was too old," I said.

"What I'm interested in are things that will inform the next election."

A few minutes later, Martin was back to talking tough about the importance of speaking freely and not caring about whom he antagonizes.

"I don't give a fuck who I offend," Martin declared.

Except Biden, I noted.

"Listen, that has nothing to do with offending him or not," Martin said. He reiterated that he is not in his job for glory. "All you do is get pissed on all the time," he reminded me.

I WAS STRUCK by how often Biden came up in my conversations with Democrats around the country. Specifically, people mentioned that his refusal to step away despite his obvious decline—and the refusal of Democratic leaders to acknowledge this decline until it was too obvious to ignore—was a betrayal that the party has yet to reckon with or recover from. "If their line was *As long as the president's not senile*—I just have a higher bar than that," James Talarico said.



James Talarico, a state representative and former seminarian running for Senate in Texas, believes that the Democrats' struggles give them a chance to redefine themselves to be more broadly appealing.



Senator Ruben Gallego of Arizona won by running as a "big-ass truck" Democrat in 2024.



Abigail Spanberger won the Virginia governor's race in November by an impressive margin, giving hope to the beleaguered Democrats.

"When you tell people that the thing that they are seeing isn't true," Graham Platner said, "they're going to stop fucking believing you. Because you're obviously lying."

The lie has become a proxy for distrust of Democratic leaders on issues across the board. It's a big reason Democrats have lost significant ground with a constituency that was once solidly theirs—the youth vote. "When we told them the president is too old, they told us, 'No, he's not; look how strong he is,'" David Hogg told me.

To his supporters, Trump approximates what "strong" looks like and what a "man" looks like (and even what a "strongman" looks like). Despite his constant whining and incessant lies, Trump embodies for his base blunt honesty and brutish masculinity.

Let's pause for a second to appreciate the richness of the irony here: Nearly every elected Republican in Washington who is not named Trump has allowed himself or herself to be effectively neutered by him. Republican "leaders" might fashion themselves as a pack of alpha dogs, but in fact they have proved themselves to be a pack of panting poodles. "They love to call us cucks," Ken Casey, the lead singer and bassist for the punk band the Dropkick Murphys, told *The Atlantic* this past summer. "Which I find ironic because there's a good portion of MAGA that would probably step aside and let Donald Trump have their way with their significant other if he asked."

Ruben Gallego said that "if I was bullied as much as these Republicans are by President Trump and his followers, I would be so ashamed to see my family."

The gap between how Trump is perceived by some Republicans (strong and confident) and his actual persona (overwrought and histrionic) is large. "He has built this sort of whole infrastructure around assuaging an insecurity that he has," Abdul

El-Sayed, the Senate candidate from Michigan, told me. "He is so fragile that he builds this simulacrum of strength."

I asked El-Sayed what he meant by that. "It looks strong, and it's enforced by other people thinking it's strong," he explained. "But if you actually got in a physical fight with Donald Trump, you'd kick his ass."

For the record, El-Sayed, who is 41, looks like he could kick most people's asses, certainly mine. A former high-school wrestler and football player, he attended the University of Michigan, and then Oxford on a Rhodes Scholarship; he was later appointed executive director of Detroit's health department. He ran for governor in 2018, losing in the Democratic primary to the eventual winner, Gretchen Whitmer.

We were sitting in a café not far from El-Sayed's home in Ann Arbor. Fresh from his Saturday-morning workout, beads of sweat on his forehead and massive arms bulging through a tight black T-shirt, he was sipping a weird energy concoction containing espresso and wheat germ or something. El-Sayed speaks bluntly about the need for a more muscular Democratic Party that fights harder, shows less mercy, and refuses to cede "masculinity" to the cartoonish version modeled by a president who plans to host an Ultimate Fighting Championship bout next summer at the White House. "If they go low, we don't go high," El-Sayed told the crowd at a rally with Sanders that day in Kalamazoo. "We take 'em to the mud and choke 'em out."

El-Sayed is one of the many Democratic candidates and officials I spoke with who readily acknowledged that their party has been actively, albeit inadvertently, repelling men. "Every time you heard the word *masculinity* in Democratic spaces, it was always preceded by a particular adjective—*toxic*," he said. "And if you condemn a whole group of people as toxic, don't expect them to be like, *Yeah, I want to be part of that*."

“When we say ‘The future is female,’ I get where that’s coming from,” Talarico told me. “But to a young guy, that kind of sounds like the future is not for them.”

It was the middle of October, and Talarico and I were talking in the lobby bar of a hotel in Arlington, Texas. Part of his political momentum has been grounded in novelty—*Look, Democrats have found a guy they think can talk to Christians in Texas*—but Talarico is legitimately talented. Even though he is in many ways more moderate than his primary opponent, Jasmine Crockett, if Talarico wins the nomination, Republicans will inevitably do what they’ve become so adept at: turn him into a one-dimensional embodiment of a radical Democrat and make the race a referendum on “woke” pronouns, DEI, and transgender issues.

Talarico might be especially vulnerable to this because of a remark he made in 2021, during a legislative debate. “God is nonbinary,” Talarico said, in a video clip that resurfaced this past fall. (Josh Barro, a political commentator who left the Republican Party in 2016 and is now a centrist Democrat, promptly weighed in with a Substack essay titled “The First Step to Winning Back the Senate: Don’t Nominate Anyone Who Said ‘God Is Non-Binary.’”)

When I mentioned to Talarico that statements such as “God is nonbinary” could present a problem for him, he said he thinks Republicans would have a much harder time turning his race into a referendum on divisive cultural issues in the way they did in 2024, because the dominant issues of 2026 will be the economy and the cost of living. “We’re always focused on what happened in the last election,” Talarico said. Especially, he noted, the stream of out-of-town reporters in their shiny new cowboy boots. Talarico said he can predict what the national press is going to ask: “It’s trans athletes, the ‘God is nonbinary’ thing,” (I felt seen. Or exposed.)

Focusing on cultural issues would be akin to “fighting the last war,” Talarico concluded, perhaps wishfully. But Spanberger’s campaign in Virginia last year provided validation for this. More than half of Republican ad money in her race was spent on anti-trans themes. “The attack ads were trying to do some sort of othering, right?” Spanberger told me. “It worked with Harris, and so then they presumed it could work with me.”

It didn’t. Spanberger figured—correctly—that every ad Republicans ran “talking about a bathroom, or trying to vilify kids, was a moment that they weren’t talking about the economy.” A poll conducted in the final weeks of the campaign found that transgender issues in schools were the top concern for only 4 percent of voters.

Talarico argued that Democrats should not curse the uncertainty they have endured, or treat this period as pointless. “There’s an opportunity here to redefine the Democratic Party,” he told me. “And you can’t do that if the brand is super set, or if there’s a strong leader at the top of the party.” This, he said, should excite anyone who wants to see the party grow and evolve. “The wilderness is where new ideas and new leaders and new movements come forth.”

As Talarico and I talked, a woman from the hotel front desk approached our table to warn us that a coyote had been spotted on the patio earlier. She showed us a picture of the creature on her phone, and we assured her that we would be careful.

Talarico remarked that the nasty interloper would provide good color for my story, and then recalled the time that former Governor Rick Perry had encountered a coyote while running outside Austin—and shot it dead.

“He jogs with a gun” was Talarico’s takeaway.

You never know what you’ll come across in the wilderness.

ALTHOUGH QUANTIFYING MORALE and momentum is hard, by the end of 2025, the Democrats were enjoying an upturn in both. Their message felt more focused, and their resolve stronger, than it had in a long time. Those off-year election wins helped, and so did Trump’s ongoing obfuscation of the Jeffrey Epstein files, which gave Democrats a righteous fight to engage in.

The president helped by continually serving up gold-plated symbolism: He demolished the East Wing of the White House so he could build a \$400 million ballroom, and threw a *Great Gatsby*-themed party at Mar-a-Lago in the midst of a protracted government-shutdown fight that jeopardized health-care subsidies and SNAP benefits for tens of millions of Americans.

At the same time, Trump’s National Guard deployments and immigration-enforcement offensives in Democratic-run cities became more aggressive—and more unpopular. Social media served up a daily video deluge of heavily armed agents randomly manhandling dark-skinned people. Opposition to these incursions catalyzed a more determined resistance than Democrats had shown before. Trump’s approval ratings on immigration, which had been his strongest issue, have tanked.

In early November, I traveled to Chicago, the first midwestern blue city Trump had targeted for his immigration crackdowns. J. B. Pritzker, the Illinois governor and a potential Democratic presidential candidate in 2028, found himself in an ongoing Chicago beef with federal authorities, trying to serve as resistance leader against Trump while keeping a volatile situation from exploding in America’s third-largest city.

The president had recently called for Pritzker to be jailed—a status symbol among high-profile Democratic governors who might run for president. (Pritzker and Gavin Newsom could wind up sharing both a jail cell and a debate stage.) I visited him on a sparkling fall day in Chicago. Or, as Trump called it, a “war zone” and “the most dangerous city in the world.”

At the time we spoke, Pritzker had been urging citizens to blow whistles when they saw federal agents in the area so potential targets could flee. (*Really?* I thought. *Has it come to this?*) He was spending his days fielding insults from the president (the sturdy governor endured a lot of fat jokes) while suggesting that Trump himself was “suffering dementia.”

A former venture capitalist and an heir to the Hyatt-hotels fortune, Pritzker kept spitting out dire admonitions. He predicted that the presence of Trump-controlled security forces in Chicago and other cities might foreshadow federal tampering with the 2026 elections. “I think that all the pieces of something nefarious seem to be occurring, and I’m just putting the pieces together,” Pritzker said. “I’m hopeful I’m wrong, but I don’t think we can assume that I’m wrong.”

He was disappointed that it had taken so long for a robust resistance to Trump to coalesce. “My complaint is not about regular folks,” Pritzker said. “What I’ve been frustrated by is people who hold leadership positions. And I’m not talking about elected Democrats only. I’m talking about CEOs of companies. I’m talking about boards of universities. I’m talking about people who have influence, who have the ability to stand up, but are afraid.”

Pritzker talks a lot about Nazis. He does not hesitate to compare Trump’s authoritarian gambits to the rise of the Third Reich. A descendant of Jewish refugees whose family fled Ukrainian pogroms, Pritzker was talking like this even before the Chicago raids. In February 2025, he gave a speech about how “it took 53 days for the Nazis to tear down a constitutional republic,” he told me. “Authoritarianism happens fast.”

Pritzker is a billionaire—not exactly a beloved species among Democrats these days. Other than Trump and his court-flatterers, billionaires are probably the most agreed-upon class of boogeyman that Democrats have. In his 2018 run for governor, Pritzker said, one challenge was “overcoming” that.

“Overcoming being a billionaire?” I asked.

This seemed to irritate him. “In a Democratic primary,” he said, yes. He asked me to consider the challenges he’d surmounted in running for governor two years after Bernie Sanders had gotten half the vote in the Illinois Democratic primary with a “Billionaires are evil” message. Pritzker had weathered his billionaire status to defeat Republican Governor Bruce Rauner. If he ran for president in 2028, Pritzker said, he would have to face that “obstacle.”

Pritzker said he’s proud of the fact that many of Sanders’s 2016 supporters in Illinois have become strong supporters of his, despite his wealth. Like Newsom, Pritzker exemplifies how using competence and combativeness against Trump plays well with constituents—and can wipe out all kinds of political deficiencies.

While in town, I stayed at the Hilton Chicago, a 1,544-room landmark, built in 1927, on South Michigan Avenue. The hotel overlooks Grant Park. The last time I’d been there was 2008, when I covered Obama’s Election Night rally, one of the most unforgettable experiences of my career. The wholesome pride in Chicago was palpable that night: hometown pride and American pride, as well as a strong sense—or illusion, it turned out—of national unity. The Ethiopian cabdriver who drove me to O’Hare the next morning kept bursting into tears because, he said, he never expected that the people of his adopted country would elect a Black president.

Obama’s ascendancy that night also represented a 21st-century high point for the Democratic Party. Hope, change, all of those things. (As well as the racial backlash, prominently abetted by Trump.) That was a long time ago, and feels longer. The arc of the moral universe is complicated.

MY LAST STOP on the tour was a café in Toledo, Ohio, about two weeks before Christmas. Former Democratic Senator Sherrod Brown was hosting a roundtable featuring seven Ohioans sharing stories about the financial pain that bloated health-care costs had inflicted on their families, compelling them to scale back their medical care.

One after another, the participants described, at times tearfully, how their struggles had been exacerbated by the Trump administration’s policies, especially the so-called big, beautiful bill that Republicans passed over the summer.

This was a classic Democratic campaign event, centered on the party’s most solid policy terrain—health care. It was also classic Sherrod Brown, a now-rare breed of working-class progressive who had managed to get himself elected three times to the Senate and seven times to the House, in a state that veered to the right during the Trump years. Brown, 73, finally saw his luck run out in 2024, when he lost his campaign for a fourth term to Bernie Moreno, a MAGA disciple.

When he lost, he assumed that his political career was over. “I really was not going to do this again. My wife didn’t want me to do it again, and my kids didn’t want me to do it again,” he told me. But when Trump returned to office and started wreaking even more havoc than he had in his first term, Brown saw an opening. He is now running for a seat held by a Republican incumbent, Jon Husted. “I’m going to win this race because the state is so different,” he said.

“Different from what?” I asked.

“Different from what it was last year,” Brown said, when Trump 2.0 was more popular, the Democrats were a mess, and it looked like Brown’s brand of nuts-and-bolts liberal politics was cooked. Now Trump is so much less popular that the abiding Democratic disarray might not matter.

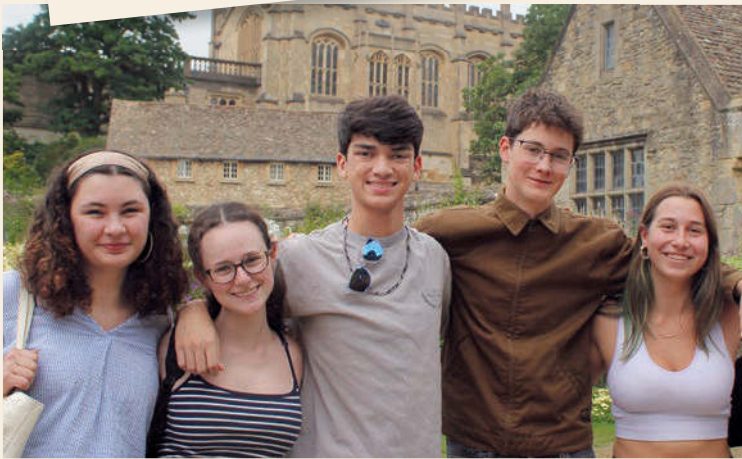
I wanted to end this journey with Brown because he is not flashy or a media magnet or a handwringer or (bless the man) someone who gets hung up on white papers about why Democrats are adrift. He is simply seizing an opportunity the Republicans have handed him: Large majorities of voters are losing patience with Trump.

Last year, James Carville was criticized in some circles for his argument that Democrats would be best served by staying out of the way, suppressing their penchant for self-harm, and simply waiting for Trump and the Republicans to self-immolate. Which is essentially what they’ve done. Carville’s theory was and remains controversial—his critics point to the lasting damage Trump has inflicted everywhere since his rapacious return to office while the Democrats have looked on haplessly. But as the 2026 midterms approach, Carville’s advice seems likely to be vindicated.

Essentially: Do no harm, strive to remain at least in the ballpark of “normal,” and bank on one huge built-in advantage—opposition parties typically do well in midterms. Also, the past 10 years have shown repeatedly that Republicans vote far less reliably when Trump is not on the ballot. Finally, for all the blundering, there remain just two viable political parties in the United States, and the Democrats are still one of them, despite themselves. No party wants to “lose America,” as the white papers put it. But when the other side is destroying it, there are worse things to be than the alternative. *A*

Mark Leibovich is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

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Culture & Critics

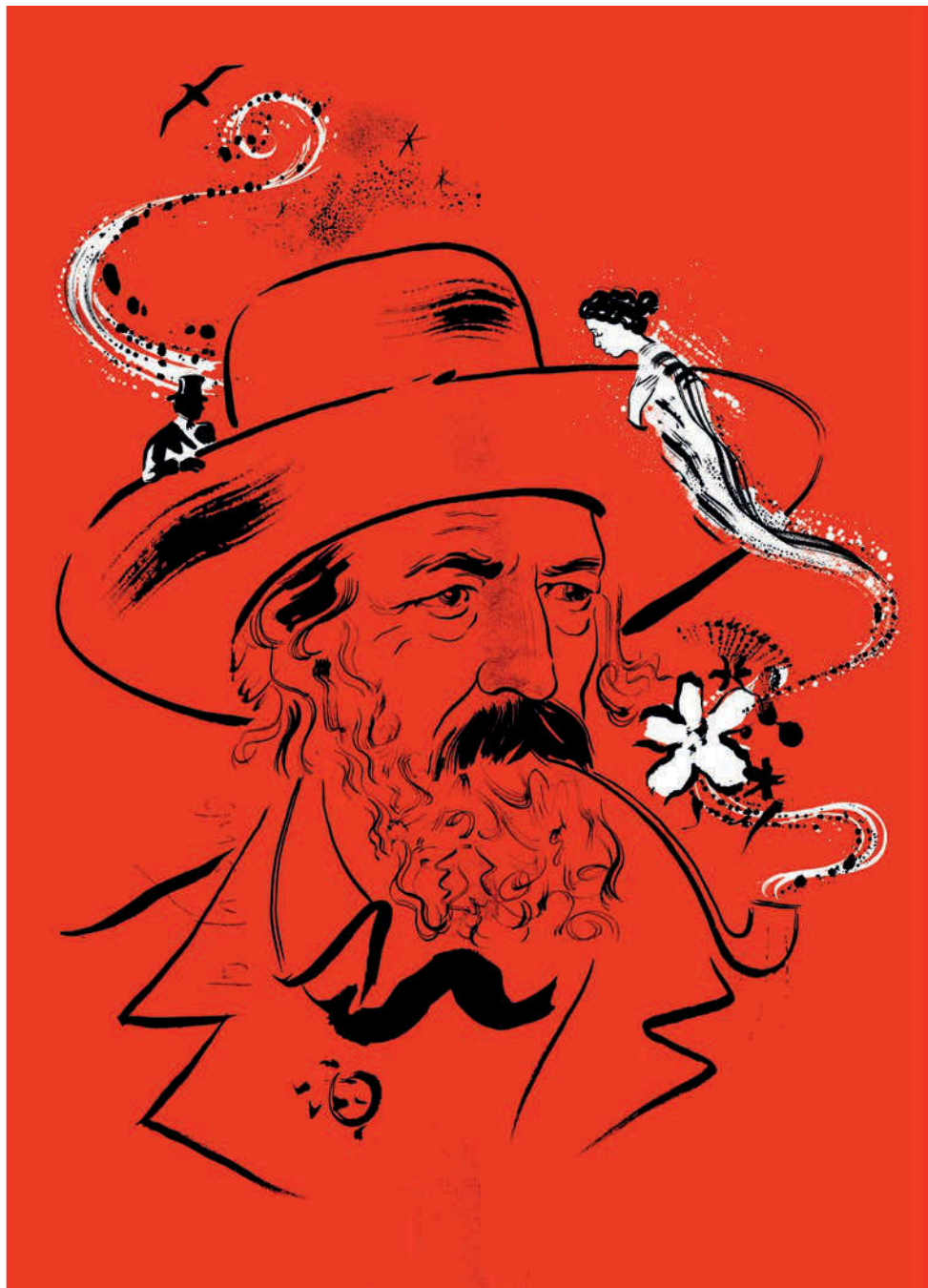
OMNIVORE

The Madness of Lord Tennyson

The Victorian poet was startlingly modern.

By James Parker

The appointment of a new medicine man is a dicey moment in the life of a tribe. Get it wrong, pick the wrong guy, and your deepest spiritual diseases will go not only untreated but undetected. Get it right, and there's at least a chance of an accurate diagnosis. The Victorians, rather surprisingly, got it right. In fact, for all their pomposity and stolidity and leadenness of soul, and for all their windbag religiosity, they nailed it. They chose as their national poet a vagrant and depressed semi-atheist from a family of lunatics. They chose Alfred, Lord Tennyson.



PICTURELAKE / GETTY

Tennyson was already famous, largely on the strength of his blockbuster elegy, *In Memoriam*, when Queen Victoria made him her poet laureate in 1850. But it is with the haunted and chaotic pre-fame poet—the shaggy, craggy, germinal genius wandering in his cloud of tobacco smoke and melancholy, poring over his books about physics and chemistry—that Richard Holmes's *The Boundless Deep* is chiefly concerned. Subtitled *Young Tennyson, Science, and the Crisis of Belief*, it tracks this character's metabolic absorption of the most disturbing, displacing ideas that contemporary science had to offer; their effect on his personality; and their manifestation in his poetry.

Holmes, the master scholar-biographer of Coleridge and Shelley, is ideally qualified for such a gig. In prose so lucid that you barely notice when it has slipped into a stream of profound interiority, into the hidden life-current of his subject, Holmes gives us what feels like the whole man. His Tennyson is cosmically miserable, while also being—when among friends—very good company: that is, highly appealing to us moderns. He devours works of popular science, the information they contain as intoxicating to him as the poetry of his idols Keats and Shelley. Nervously puffing away on “infinite tobacco” (as his friend Thomas Carlyle described it), he rides the fault line between epochs. Astronomy is deepening space, geology is deepening time, and as the news comes in—one revelation after another—he can feel the answering tremor in human consciousness, and the fearful new understanding it foretells. An empty heaven. A disenchanted world. “I stretch lame hands of faith,” he writes in *In Memoriam*, “and grope, / And gather dust and chaff.” The new science of psychology, too, absorbs him. Not at all a degraded Romantic (for which he is sometimes mistaken), this Tennyson, in his gleamy-gloomy way, is a looming giant of modernity. Behind him is Keats and “The Eve of St. Agnes”; before him is *The Waste Land*.

Tennyson was prolific, prodigious. He rumbled with poetry; he recited it endlessly; it poured off him on long walks. Language teemed inside him, especially when he was a young man, producing verse so musical, it sometimes seems on the verge of becoming pure fluid sound, a kind of glittering higher gibberish:

A bow-shot from her bower-eaves,
He rode between the barley-sheaves,
The sun came dazzling thro' the leaves,
And flam'd upon the brazen greaves
Of bold Sir Lancelot.

The darker strands of the young Tennyson's existence—madness, spurned love, ruinous genes, insolvency—would become the themes of a later poem that Holmes regards as pivotal. It appeared

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THE BOUNDLESS
DEEP: YOUNG
TENNYSON,
SCIENCE, AND
THE CRISIS
OF BELIEF

Richard Holmes

PANTHEON

in Tennyson's first book as poet laureate, *Maud, and Other Poems*, published in 1855. The reviews were not good. In fact, they were violently hostile. Despite containing such patriotic bangers as “Ode on the Death of the Duke of Wellington” and “The Charge of the Light Brigade,” both previously published (and the latter instantly memorized by half the British empire), the new collection was discredited, in the eyes of its critics, by its long centerpiece, “Maud: A Monodrama,” a poem narrated by a madman.

“Ill considered, crude, tawdry and objectionable” was one reviewer's judgment of *Maud*. To the reviewer in the *Press*, it might have been the output of “a love-sick youth in the measles.” One small constituency, however, rated *Maud* quite highly: Victorian shrink-types. Clinical accuracy is not something with which poets have traditionally tended to preoccupy themselves, but Tennyson's account of mental extremity impressed the experts. *Maud* got a glowing write-up in the October 1855 edition of *The Asylum Journal of Mental Science*, and a doctor named Robert Mann published an entire pro-*Maud* pamphlet, *Tennyson's Maud Vindicated: An Explanatory Essay*. “Where can this unprofessional psychologist have acquired his accurate insight into the phenomena of insanity?” he asked. (“I seem to have the doctors on my side if no one else,” the laureate growled in a grateful letter to Mann.)

“Maud” was personal. Tennyson called it “my little *Hamlet*” and then—after the critical kicking it sustained—“poor little Maud,” and it is indeed a strange, stormy, fragmented, wildly lyrical, futuristically subjective freak-out of a poem, part melodrama, part psychotic break. The narrator's father, destroyed by the failure of “a vast speculation,” commits suicide; the narrator becomes obsessed with Maud, the daughter of the man who bankrupted his father, now living in grandeur on a neighboring estate and flashing her profile at him—“Faultily faultless, icily regular, splendidly null, / Dead perfection, no more”—as she rides past in her carriage. Obsessed, obsessed, truly obsessed: obsession like a dead flame licking the walls of life, or a wind singing through the deepest flaw in the universe. Maud and the narrator meet and fall in love—or do they? At one point, he seems to be lying outside her house in the dark—in a trance? stalking her?—hallucinating the sound of her footsteps in the movement of the leaves. Above him are the stars, bleep-bleeping away from the depths of untenanted space. He talks to them, lamenting

the boundless plan

That makes you tyrants in your iron skies,
Innumerable, pitiless, passionless eyes,
Cold fires, yet with power to burn and brand
His nothingness into man.

The cold fires, the nothingness—as Holmes shows us, all of this Tennyson had seen through the high-powered telescope in his garden, and read about in the books that were filling his library. To combine this kind of depth perception with the galactic ache of an unreal love, of an undead infatuation, that was new. That was scary. No wonder reviewers recoiled.

The vision was not just telescopic, but microscopic. In the second—and maddest—section of the poem, the narrator, having fled in panic to France, roams the Breton shoreline. He fixates upon a seashell:

The tiny cell is forlorn,
Void of the little living will
That made it stir on the shore.
Did he stand at the diamond door
Of his house in a rainbow frill?

Buffeted by hallucinations as he is, he zooms in on the long-gone shell-dweller like one of the underwater cameras in David Attenborough's *Blue Planet*.

Part of Tennyson lived, was encamped, at the outer reaches of the psyche. Alcoholism, seizures, mood swings, incontinent rage—all ran in his family's "black blood." His father was regularly deranged; his brother Edward was a helpless depressive; and his brother Septimus introduced himself to Dante Gabriel Rossetti with the words "I am Septimus, the most morbid of the Tennysons." Septimus was under the care of Matthew Allen, a psychiatric pioneer who called his establishment at High Beech, Essex, not an asylum but "a place of seclusion for exhausted minds." Tennyson befriended Allen and began to spend a lot of time at High Beech: Holmes connects the poet's observation of the patients there directly to "Maud," noting, "The gardens at High Beech, the paths and the shrubberies, the wandering figures of the insane, muttering to themselves, recur like a remembered tune fifteen years later."

A remembered tune, but also a staticky signal from the incoming 20th century, the noise of a voice splintered into different voices, fading in and out of clarity. Modern critics adore "Maud" for precisely the qualities that repelled its original audience—for its weirdness and its brokenness, and its pre-Freudian blast of erotic attachment. Tennyson would never be this exposed again: fame, the laureateship, and a steady marriage all solidified him. But for a long moment, he was beautifully out of sync with his public and ahead of his time, as any healer must be—because where can healing come from if not the future? *A*

James Parker is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

Literary Theory

By Ada Limón

Somehow the word
allow is in the word
swallow and in *swallow*
two wholly different meanings:
one to take in through
the mouth and another
what we call the common
winged gnat hunter who
is, in all probability,
somewhere near us now.
Once, I thought
if I knew all the words
I would say the right thing
in the right way,
instead language becomes
more brutish: blink twice
for the bird, blink once
for tender annihilation. Who
knows what we are doing as
we go about our days lazily
choosing our languages. Some
days my life is held together
by definitions, some days
I read the word *swallow*
and all my feathers show.

Ada Limón is the author of seven books of poetry. Her most recent book is Startlement: New and Selected Poems. She served as the 24th poet laureate of the United States.

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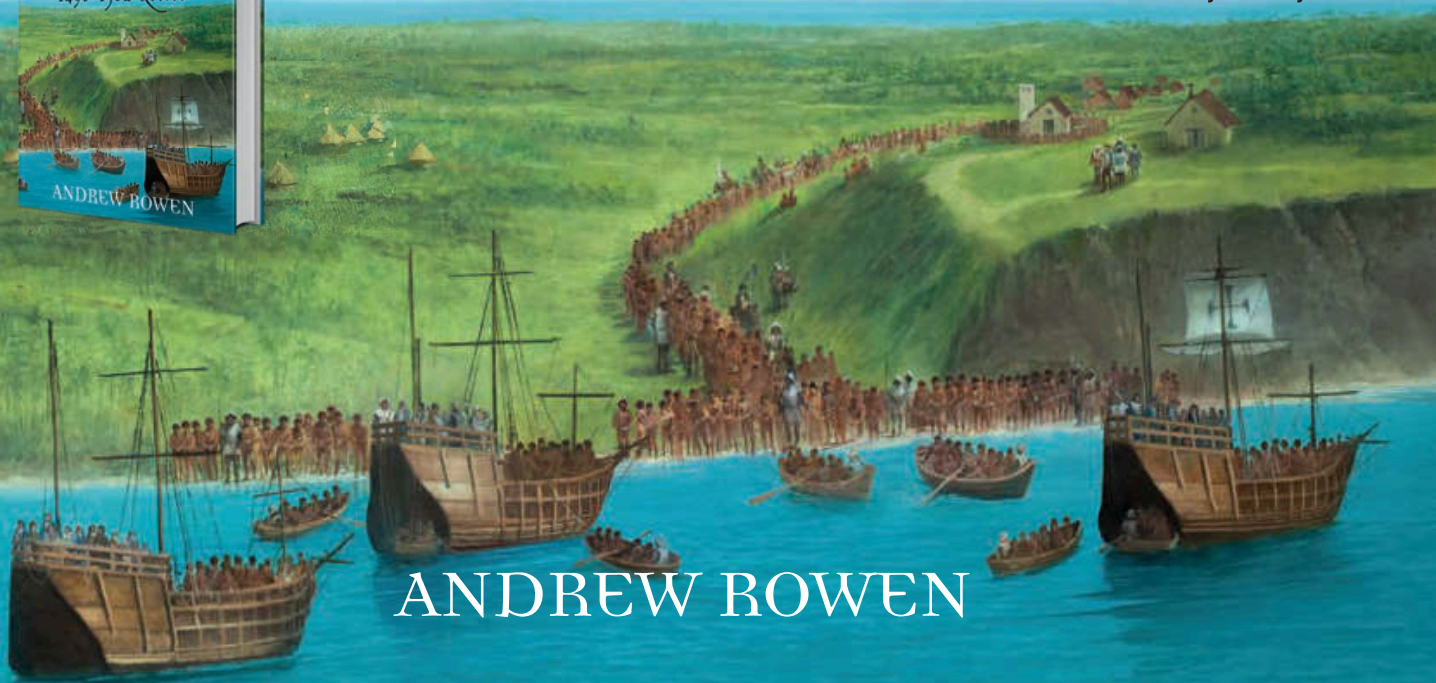
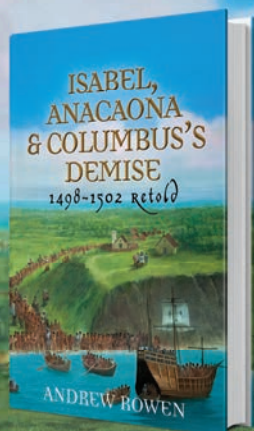
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BOOKS

How Toni Morrison Saw History

*In her novels, she located the
missing story of Black America.*

By Judith Shulevitz

“I don’t like erasures,” the novelist Toni Morrison told a Princeton audience in 2017. She had been asked what she thought about Confederate statues, then being torn down throughout the South. Leave them up, she said: “Talk about the offense. You know, put another statue next to it and say the opposite.” Hang a noose around its neck, she added. The audience laughed nervously, but she wasn’t kidding.

The moderator quickly moved on to another question, so Morrison kept the rest of her views to herself. After 11 novels, many of them prizewinning, and a wealth of essays and literary criticism, she was a monument in her own right—a canonical American writer awarded the Nobel Prize in Literature in 1993—and monuments aren’t supposed to stir up trouble. In any case, she had laid out her theory of cultural preservation in the 1970s, a more experimental era than ours.

In a brilliant essay called “Rediscovering Black History,” she tells a story about racist statuary and the NAACP. The civil-rights organization had booked a hotel for a convention on the condition that two statuettes of Black jockeys be removed from the lobby. “The hotel management reluctantly agreed,” Morrison reports, “but before the statuettes could be temporarily removed, they were draped with sheets.” Morrison’s reaction to the incident was, and still is, remarkable. She did not criticize the management; she chided the NAACP for forgoing the opportunity to honor a little-known instance of Black accomplishment. Never mind that the statuettes were meant to be demeaning. Better to mine an artifact for history than conceal it for fear of white contempt:

Instead of being delighted that the profession of being a jockey virtually belonged to black men before 1900; that 14 of the first 27 Kentucky Derby races were won by black jockeys; that Isaac Murphy, a black jockey, was the first to win three Derbys; that Jimmy Lee won all six races at Churchill Downs in 1907—we draped the figures and hid their glory not only from white eyes but from our own eyes.

The provocation was sheer Morrison. Part of her genius lay in the ability to discover meaning where no one else imagined it could be found. She set out to write her first novel, *The Bluest Eye*, in the early 1960s because “it was a book I wanted to read, and I couldn’t find it anywhere,” she told an interviewer in 1988. That book, published in 1970, was about a young Black girl dealing with severe family dysfunction and incest. “Vulnerable young black girls were profoundly absent” from American literature, she recollected in an essay about working on *Beloved* (1987), her most celebrated novel. “When they did appear, they were jokes or instances of pity—pity without understanding.”

Morrison wanted traces of Black history to be safeguarded regardless of their source, because she was “keenly aware of erasures and absences and silences,” she writes in that essay. She once said in an interview that she felt a responsibility toward the millions who died during the Middle Passage: “Nobody knows their names, and nobody thinks about them.” Their stories were not even preserved in the usual repositories of collective memory, such as folktale, song, and dance, Morrison speculated, because those who crossed the Atlantic with them would have been loath to share their memories. To the degree that these legions of the dead are remembered, it is as pure absence.

When the history was available, Morrison was struck that much of it was unspeakable. In a 1987 essay about 18th- and 19th-century slave narratives, Morrison notes that the authors often cut their stories

short “with a phrase such as, ‘But let us drop a veil over these proceedings too terrible to relate.’” They didn’t want to scare off the audiences they hoped to convert to abolitionism. As a 20th-century Black novelist, Morrison’s job was to “rip that veil.” The task daunted her. How could she know what it was like to have an iron bit shoved into one’s mouth? She also worried that she wouldn’t be able to resist the urge to idealize the victims, scrubbing them of flaws. Nothing could be more fatal to a work of fiction.

Above all, Morrison worried about turning characters, especially slaves, into objects of voyeurism. How could she write about obscene violence and abjection without arousing a prurient response? She didn’t want to produce what some people now call “trauma porn.” The difficulty redoubled when she tried to write about Black self-perception. In her foreword to *The Bluest Eye*, a novel about self-loathing, Morrison recalls struggling to sabotage the “despising glance”—white disparagement refracted through Black self-loathing—even as she re-created it.

Nonetheless, in novels about slavery, segregation, and racism—both the kind that comes from the outside and the kind that is internalized—Morrison channeled the Black experience to extraordinary effect. An awareness of absent ancestors prickles through her writing, but at the same time, her fictional worlds feel solid and present. Her characters do not lack agency; they are not made heroic; she did not write trauma porn. How did she avoid those traps? How do you represent the unrepresentable without betraying it?

*How do you
represent the
unrepresentable
without
betraying it?*

MORRISON NEVER stopped thinking about the trick of evoking erasure and undoing it at the same time. In *On Morrison*, an incisive study of Morrison’s main works, Namwali Serpell calls this theme the “paradox of representation.” An English professor at Harvard and the author of two acclaimed novels, *The Old Drift* (2019) and *The Furrows* (2022), Serpell combines a professorial breadth of reference and a novelist’s fascination with the mechanics of literature. Her erudite digressions and granular readings add up to a kind of literary procedural. Plus, every so often, she fangirls: The novelist did not suffer fools; she could be high-handed. “Morrison’s imperiousness never failed to electrify me,” Serpell confesses.

To be clear, *On Morrison* is a work of criticism, not a biography. Morrison hoped that nobody would write one, and Serpell was happy not to. She has an argument to make. Morrison envied African novelists their freedom not to explain Black life to white people, Serpell writes, and to avoid “that omnipresent fog, the white gaze,” Morrison invented a uniquely Black aesthetic. Its sources lay in Black cultural practices—Black music and humor; masking; “signifying,” or

competitive insulting; and so on. Serpell identifies a different cultural mode influencing the form of each work she considers.

Jazz (1992), for instance, reproduces the music's swing and improvisational flow. Serpell highlights what Morrison does with sound and rhythm, such as when her sentences glide and trill in dreamlike riffs, then chop themselves up: "A colored man floats down out of the sky blowing a saxophone, and below him, in the space between two buildings, a girl talks earnestly to a man in a straw hat. He touches her lip to remove a bit of something there. Suddenly she is quiet. He tilts her chin up. They stand there." The dominant device in *Sula* (1973) is an "ironic bluesy tone"—irony understood in its most basic sense, as saying the opposite of what one means. Serpell shows the novel proceeding from one seeming contradiction to the next: laughter that comes from both amusement and pain, the surname Peace for a family that has none, a mother's mercy killing of her son.

Even as the forms of Morrison's novels change, though, she is always trying to give voice to silence. Serpell introduces that theme in the chapter on *The Bluest Eye*, asking, "What would it look like to crack the quiet open, to break absence into pieces, to subject a void to rupture?" The void takes the shape of Pecola Breedlove, an 11-year-old girl raised without affection or care, who, over the course of a year in the early 1940s, is hollowed out even further by loneliness, racism, and abuse. The title derives from her deepest wish, born of the conviction that her dark skin makes her ugly: She yearns to have blue eyes. Her story is told by Claudia, looking back as an adult on that year, when she was 9 and her family took Pecola in. Claudia's family is intact, barely scraping by but rich in love, and she has a constant companion, her sister, Frieda. The novel brightens when they come into view, and they make us painfully conscious of everything Pecola is deprived of.

Watch how Morrison evokes presence and absence at the same time in her description of the Breedloves' bleak storefront apartment. Its furnishings

were anything but describable, having been conceived, manufactured, shipped, and sold in various states of thoughtlessness, greed, and indifference. The furniture had aged without ever having become familiar. People had owned it, but never known it. No one had lost a penny or a brooch under the cushions of either sofa and remembered the place and time of the loss or the finding.

From the loss of a penny or brooch, Morrison proceeds to a deficit of life itself: "No one had given birth in one of the beds—or remembered with fondness the peeled

paint places, because that's what the baby, when he learned to pull himself up, used to pick loose."

Pecola responds to her misery by trying to undo herself. When her parents fight loudly, she shuts her eyes and imagines herself disappearing, body part by body part. The parents themselves have long since come undone. Benumbed by extreme poverty and the wounds of Black childhood in Jim Crow America, they live in a state of complete isolation. In other words, the Breedloves have experienced social death.

The Bluest Eye could have been an "identitarian sob story," Serpell writes, but "this emphasis on absence—the void, the vacuum, the vanished; the failed, the silenced, the missing" holds the bathos at bay, and elevates the novel to a work of art. Morrison, though, did not think it succeeded. In her foreword, she writes that she had been concerned that the fragile Pecola would be shattered by her circumstances, which would "lead readers into the comfort of pitying her rather than into an interrogation of themselves for the smashing." And indeed, after Pecola is raped and impregnated by her father, her situation becomes so extreme that she seems beyond the reach of empathy. "It didn't work," Morrison writes. "Many readers remain touched but not moved."

ON MORRISON

Namwali Serpell

HOGARTH

IN *THE BLUEST EYE*, Morrison struggled to unite the there and not-there in the same figure: Claudia had occupied the positive pole, as it were, and Pecola, the negative. Four novels later, in *Beloved*, Morrison came up with a conceit that fused the two: a ghost.

Beloved opens in Ohio in 1873, a decade after Emancipation, though half of the novel is a flashback to life on a plantation in Kentucky in the 1850s. The work confronts the bodily and psychic horrors of slavery and its aftermath. Morrison based her main character, Sethe, on an escaped enslaved woman whom she had read about in a newspaper clipping from 1856, shortly after the passage of the Fugitive Slave Act. The woman had fled Kentucky with her four children. When she was captured in the free state of Ohio, she tried to kill them and herself rather than let them all be taken back. She managed to kill only one child, a little girl, before she was stopped. That is Sethe's backstory too. Now, 18 years later, Sethe and a surviving daughter live on the property where the murder took place, and they are haunted by an angry spirit.

The ghost in *Beloved* was not Morrison's first spectral being. Pecola's parents are in essence zombies—the walking dead. *Song of Solomon* (1977) has at least one ghost, a father who has been murdered in front of his young children, who wind up alone and homeless in the woods. But he is just a fleeting apparition who leads them to shelter. *Beloved's* ghost occupies the foreground. It hurls furniture with the strength of a

poltergeist and has substance enough to press hand-prints into cakes. Passersby hear its shrieks and moans from the road. All of this happens even before it takes human form.

Ghost stories defamiliarize worlds we think we know; Morrison uses the uncanny to make slavery feel real, rather than abstract. Possession is an apt metaphor for enslavement. “To be possessed can mean either to be taken over by a ghost or a spirit, or to be owned like an object,” Serpell writes, just as chattel slaves were. Morrison disorients readers from the very first line: “124 was spiteful.” What does that mean, a spiteful number? The author throws one startling image after another at us—“baby’s venom,” a shattered mirror, a kettleful of chickpeas steaming on the floor—before we begin to understand what the phrase refers to. “I wanted the reader to be kidnapped, thrown ruthlessly into an alien environment as the first step into a shared experience with the book’s population,” Morrison writes in the foreword to *Beloved*.

Ghosts blur the lines between past and present, life and death, destabilizing the order of things. *Beloved*’s revenant defies the dictates of realism according to which a character is a bounded individual. The wraith materializes in the body of a young woman, but she is ambiguous as to number. She may be one; she may be many. She might be the ghost of Sethe’s murdered child, now grown up. Or she may not even be dead, but rather a living wreck of a girl who has been chained up in a white man’s house since childhood, presumably as a sex slave. She may be both. Or more than both.

She may even be one of those lost ancestors; she has memories of what seems to be the hold of a slave ship—Morrison’s reimagining of the underworld. The girl crouches because there is no room to stand. Along with everyone around her, she is being mummified by hunger and dehydration: “If we had more to drink we could make tears.” While “men without skin” (white people) push corpses overboard, the living strain to become ghosts themselves: “We are all trying to leave our bodies behind.” *Beloved* is sometimes identified as a work of magical realism, but it feels more like a religious novel—the religion being Afrodiasporic and syncretic. “If my work is to confront a reality unlike that received reality of the West,” Morrison writes in an essay, “it must centralize and animate information discredited by the West”—the kind of information, she adds, that is “dismissed as ‘lore’ or ‘gossip’ or ‘magic’ or ‘sentiment.’”

AMONG THE many ironies characterizing the work of this writer so attentive to irony is that she adds even as she subtracts. *Beloved*’s ghost is being and nonbeing, the chimerical in the flesh. And yet for all Morrison’s pains to make us feel the reality of unreality, her prose

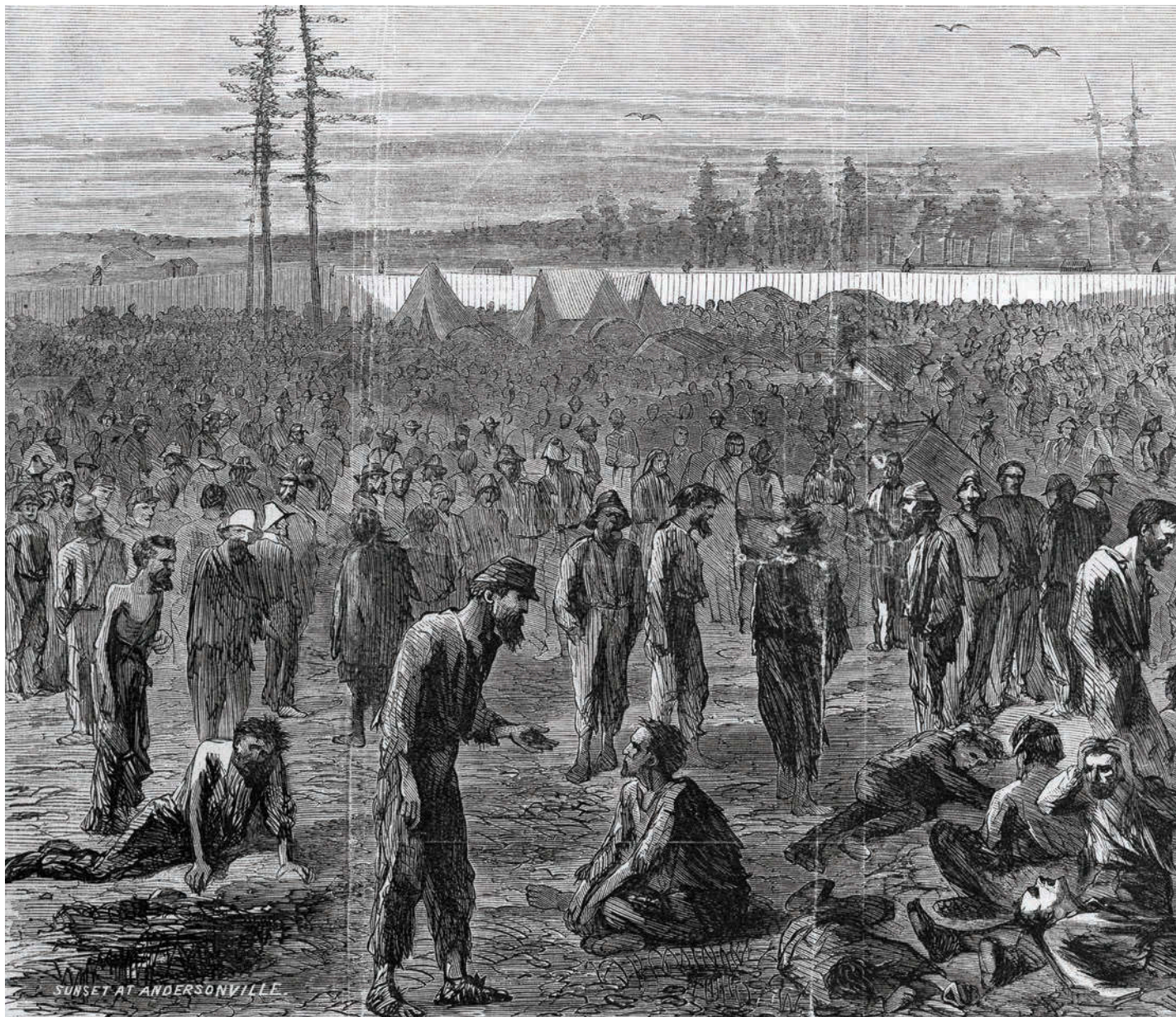
For all Morrison’s pains to make us feel the reality of unreality, her prose is rich in concrete pleasures.

is rich in concrete pleasures. Serpell observes that even Pecola thrills to eruptions of beauty on a familiar run-down street that otherwise go unseen. “She owned the crack that made her stumble,” Morrison writes; “she owned the clumps of dandelions whose white heads, last fall, she had blown away; whose yellow heads, this fall, she peered into.” A passage in *Sula* in which two girls becoming friends lie together in the grass is a gorgeously corporeal yet delicate picture of teenage-girl intimacy. Their foreheads are “almost touching, their bodies stretched away from each other at a 180-degree angle. Sula’s head rested on her arm, an undone braid coiled around her wrist. Nel leaned on her elbows and worried long blades of grass with her fingers.”

Serpell doesn’t deliver a big takeaway. That isn’t her style. Her gift is reading closely. Notwithstanding her expert use of modern critical terminology, she belongs to the old-fashioned school of appreciation. She wants us to understand how difficult Morrison is. “She is difficult to read. She is difficult to teach,” Serpell writes on the first page of the book. I applaud her nerve. It’s a rare critic writing for nonspecialists who would deliberately discourage them like that. Serpell gives us Morrison the Black particularist, who is much less accessible than we may have thought. The point needs making. Morrison despised the notion that her writing achieved “universalism”—“a code word that had come to mean ‘nonblack,’” she once wrote. But I think Serpell overstates the difficulty. Morrison’s writing functions on many levels; her surfaces can be as rewarding as her depths.

My favorite story about how artists make something out of nothing appears in her foreword to *Beloved*. Morrison has just quit her job and is allowing herself to feel “free in a way I had never been, ever,” which leads her to thoughts of slavery. She sits on her porch with a view of the Hudson River, rocking in a swing and looking at the giant stones that serve as a breakwater. Enter the ghost: “She walked out of the water, climbed the rocks, and leaned against the gazebo. Nice hat.” In the essay recalling the writing of *Beloved*, Morrison tells the same story, this time in the academic mode. Having just remarked on how, as a student, she felt stymied by the gaps in Black history—“silences that I took for censure”—she notes that when she became a novelist, “the interstices of recorded history” became a place of liberation. That is where she finds “the ‘nothing’ or the ‘not enough’ or the ‘indistinct’ or ‘incomplete’ or ‘discredited’ or ‘buried’ information” that sets her imagination in motion. I can’t think of any writer in our time as rich as Morrison in negative capability. *A*

Judith Shulevitz is a staff writer at The Atlantic.



BOOKS

Deadlier Than Gettysburg

How the cruelty of the Confederacy's prison camps gave rise to the rules of war

By Drew Gilpin Faust

The Civil War isn't what it used to be. Instead of the romantic version, a "good war" of courage and glory, that emerged in the conflict's immediate aftermath, or the post-civil-rights-era emphasis on the war as the vector of liberation for 4 million enslaved African Americans, a more recent direction has been labeled the "dark turn." Grim rather than celebratory, it has chronicled the war's cost and cruelty, exploring subjects such as death, ruins, starvation, disease, atrocities, torture, amputations, and postwar trauma, as well as a freedom that was rapidly undermined.

W. Fitzhugh Brundage's gripping new book, aptly titled *A Fate Worse Than Hell: American Prisoners of the Civil War*, represents an essential contribution to this rethinking in its account of what was perhaps the most horrifying realization of the suffering and inhumanity the war produced. But Brundage, who teaches at the

BETTMANN / GETTY



An illustration of the Confederate prison camp in Andersonville, Georgia, published in *Harper's Weekly* in 1865

University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill, does more than expand our understanding of a neglected aspect of Civil War history. His study offers a window into larger questions—about the evolution of laws of war and the definition of war crimes, about the ethical responsibility of combatants, about the growth of the nation-state and its attendant bureaucracy, and about the defining presence of race in the morality play of American history. As one Vermont infantryman wrote from a Confederate prison camp, “Here is where I can see human nature in its true light.”

At the beginning of the fighting, in 1861, no one anticipated that more than 400,000 men would become prisoners of war and that at least half of these would spend extended time in sites of what we would now call mass incarceration. The odds of being captured by the enemy in World War II were 1 in

100. In the Civil War, they were 1 in 5. As Brundage observes, three times as many Union soldiers died at the Confederate camp in Andersonville, Georgia, as at Gettysburg. Overall, approximately 10 percent of the war’s deaths occurred in prisons.

But prison camps attained this scale and significance only gradually. Both sides were initially uncertain about how to handle enemy captives. “What should be done with the prisoners?” the *Richmond Whig* asked. Treatment was largely ad hoc and depended to a considerable degree on individual commanders, but customarily prisoners would be exchanged or placed on parole—granted their freedom but required by oath not to return to military action. Rooted in assumptions about gentlemen’s honor and the integrity of pledges, the notion of parole now seems quaint, and it disappeared as the brutality of the war escalated. Some members of Abraham Lincoln’s Cabinet even argued for executing Confederate prisoners as traitors, but Congress and the public exerted pressure on the president to establish procedures to facilitate the return of captured Yankees. Formal provisions for the exchange of prisoners was not agreed upon until the summer of 1862, delayed by the Union’s reluctance to take any action that implied recognition of Confederate nationhood. Under the terms of the Dix-Hill agreement, some 30,000 prisoners were returned from captivity by the fall, but the formal exchange arrangement was soon upended.

The Emancipation Proclamation, issued in preliminary form in September 1862, provided for the recruitment of Black troops into the Union Army. Viewing this new policy as equivalent to fomenting slave rebellion, the South rejected any exchange of Black soldiers and did not extend them the protections of prisoners of war. They might be killed on the battlefield even after they surrendered, or remanded into slavery, or consigned to camps where they endured disproportionately harsh treatment.

Lincoln was resolute in his resistance to these measures. If Black soldiers could not be exchanged, no soldiers would be exchanged. The Dix-Hill agreement was suspended, and the number of prisoners of war grew exponentially; the result was camps the size of cities and untold misery for thousands of men in both the North and the South. Only during the last months of the war, with slavery disintegrating and northern victory all but assured, did exchanges resume.

BRUNDAGE CHARACTERIZES the creation of the camps as an “innovation,” describing them as “experiments in custodial imprisonment” that exceeded anyone’s prewar imagination. These were modern inventions made possible by the introduction of railroads to transport prisoners long distances from battlefields, and by the growth of administrative and

“Here is where I can see human nature in its true light.”

organizational structures required to manage not just mass armies but hundreds of thousands of prisoners. Although they emerged out of war-born imperatives, the camps were, he insists, a choice made by northern and southern policy makers alike, motivated by assumptions and purposes for which Brundage argues they must bear responsibility.

Both sides believed that any sympathetic act toward the enemy would represent an insult to their own soldiers. The Union commissary general in charge of prison administration proclaimed that “it is not expected that anything more will be done to provide for the welfare of the rebel prisoners than is absolutely necessary,” and that work on a prison camp under renovation should “fall far short of perfection.” During spring and summer months, he mandated that any clothing distributions include neither underwear nor socks.

But whatever the moral and logistical shortcomings evident on both sides, Brundage draws a clear distinction between North and South. “By any reasonable measure,” he judges, “Confederate prisoners were better kept than their Union counterparts.” Southern officials, he concludes, “never fully accepted the obligation to provide for prisoners of war.” Union prisoners were regarded not as human beings but as “a security liability that imposed no ethical imperative.” The South housed its captives in ill-adapted existing spaces. Richmond’s Libby Prison was a converted tobacco factory; the Salisbury, North Carolina, prison had been a textile mill; camps in Montgomery and Tuscaloosa, Alabama, and Macon, Georgia, were former slave jails. At the notorious Andersonville camp, no structures were provided at all. Men were not even issued tents but scrounged to procure shirts, blankets, or other bits of cloth to drape over sticks of wood to create what they called “shebangs.” Those unable to find cloth or wood dug holes in the ground.

The Union, in contrast, erected barracks and designed purpose-built enclosures for this new experiment in large-scale imprisonment. Those overseeing Union prison camps acknowledged that providing food and shelter for captives was indeed a moral obligation, even if on numerous occasions they failed to deliver adequately on that commitment. Yet the 25 percent death rate at the North’s worst prison, in Elmira, New York, came close to that at Andersonville (29 percent); overall, the mortality rate was 16 percent for Union prisoners and 12 percent for Confederates. Cruelty and corruption recognized no regional boundaries, and officials on both sides seem to have come closer to despising than sympathizing with their suffering captives.

THERE IS a long tradition—born in the midst of the war itself—of accusation and debate about which side behaved worse. Defending the South’s treatment

of its prisoners became a central theme for the neo-Confederates of the Lost Cause as the movement to rehabilitate the South emerged in the late 19th century. The blame for the surge in incarceration in 1863 and beyond should rest with the Union, they contended, for it was the North that halted the prisoner exchange. Pressing the advantage of their superior numbers, the North mercilessly kept captured Confederates in prison camps to prevent them from returning to the field to replenish the South’s diminishing ranks. The North’s decisions about prisoner exchanges were based on military calculations, not benevolent concern for Black captives. The South, they argued, did its best with its prisoners, given the scarcities of resources available to Confederate soldiers and citizens alike, scarcities they blamed on the Union effort to destroy the southern economy by blockading ports.

Professional historians in the early 20th century were not as explicitly partisan as the United Daughters of the Confederacy and their supporters. Yet, influenced by William B. Hesseltine’s field-defining *Civil War Prisons*, published in 1930, they adopted a kind of everybody-inevitably-made-mistakes approach that exonerated Confederates of any intentional moral failings. At the same time, they attributed to the North a vindictiveness arising from “abolitionist propaganda” that exaggerated Confederate prison atrocities.

The first comprehensive—one might say encyclopedic—study of prison camps since Hesseltine, Brundage’s book challenges these arguments head-on and assigns responsibility to the South’s unwavering commitment to slavery and Black subordination. Post-civil-rights-era attitudes about the equality of African Americans have prompted a different assessment of who caused the breakdown in prisoner exchanges, and thus bore the onus for the suffering and death that ensued: It was the South’s refusal to recognize Black soldiers as free men and thus treat them as prisoners of war, not Lincoln’s principled reaction to this Confederate policy, that produced such large numbers of Civil War captives. And Brundage ensures that his readers will not dismiss the record of prison atrocities. Although he offers examples of miseries from both northern and southern camps, his portrait of Andersonville leaves the most vivid impression of what the war’s moral compromises came to mean.

Andersonville was not created until February 1864, but in the months that followed, as many as 90 trainloads, containing 75 men to a boxcar, soon established its unprecedented scale. The camp consisted of a stockade erected around a 16-acre field by 200 enslaved workers commandeered from nearby plantations. Andersonville was designed to hold 10,000 prisoners, but its population reached as high as 33,000. The camp had no sanitation system, no barracks, no

A FATE WORSE
THAN HELL:
AMERICAN
PRISONERS OF
THE CIVIL WAR

W. Fitzhugh
Brundage

W. W. NORTON

clothing allocations, and scant rations distributed uncooked to men without pans or utensils or firewood. Disease—scurvy, typhoid, dysentery—was rampant among prisoners, but medical treatment was worse than inadequate. In the prison hospital, made up of dilapidated tents, 70 percent of the patients died. When Confederate officials arrived to inspect the camp in May 1864 and again that August, they were shocked by what they saw. Nearly 13,000 men lie buried in the Andersonville National Cemetery, which the nurse and future founder of the American Red Cross Clara Barton helped establish on the site at the end of the war.

A GREAT STRENGTH of Brundage's study is the breadth and depth of his research; he makes deft use of a wide variety of evidence beyond the official records on which much earlier historical work on Civil War prisons has rested. He opens the book with a consideration of a series of photographs of Andersonville that in themselves make minimizing the horror and suffering impossible. A photographer from Macon, 60 miles away, seemingly compelled by pure curiosity, spent an August day in 1864 taking panoramic pictures of life within the camp stockade—the ground obscured under a sea of shabby improvised shelters; the swarm of prisoners gathered to receive rations; the men seated bare-bottomed over an open trench that would carry their waste into the same stream that provided their drinking water. Illustrations throughout the book support Brundage's insights and arguments.

Yet perhaps even more striking than the pictures are the words taken from prisoners' letters, diaries, and memoirs. Brundage accompanies his narrative of evolving prison policies with voices and stories of individual men. "Are we to be exchanged, or are we to be left here to perish?" asked Orin H. Brown, William H. Johnson, and William Wilson, three Black Union sailors, in the summer of 1863, still packed into a crowded Charleston prison half a year after their ship had surrendered and their captured comrades, all of them white, had been exchanged. Somehow their petition—miraculously evading Confederate interception and traveling, via the Bahamas, to Washington—arrived on the Navy secretary's desk, though they likely weren't released until the end of the war. For Frederic Augustus James, a prisoner at Salisbury, unreliable mail was one of many sources of agony; he learned of his 8-year-old daughter's death five months after the fact, a succession of his wife's letters having never reached him. Four months after his transfer to Andersonville, he died of dysentery.

William Hesseltine and his followers had dismissed such sources as at best partial and at worst partisan in their exposition of the cruelties inflicted by their war-time enemies. Brundage approaches these materials

with an appropriately critical eye, demonstrating their consistency with other records and their value in providing deeper human insight into prisoners' experiences. What Hesseltine claimed as objective history, Brundage both tells and shows us, was in actuality far from objective; it placed the story in the hands of the official record keepers while silencing those who were the victims of their decisions and policies. Incorporating their accounts, Brundage provides his readers with a far richer and more complete version of the past.

At the same time, he casts his book as being about the present and the future as well. Mass internment, as he portrays it, is a product of modernity, made possible by technology and growing organizational and logistical capacities. But it was also a deliberate choice, a callous and conscious decision. "What combination of institutional authority and procedures," he asks, "eroded the moral inhibitions of officials, commanders, and camp staff, thereby making it easier for them to abandon the responsibility they might otherwise have felt to ease the suffering of the fellow humans" at Andersonville? It is hard to look at the most terrible pictures of captives ultimately returned to the North without seeing in one's mind the photographs of those liberated from Nazi concentration camps eight decades later.

Yet the demands of modernity produced some humane outcomes that also presaged the future. The dilemma of how to deal with Civil War prisoners served as a catalyst for General Orders No. 100, issued by the War Department in 1863. It was the first systematic codification of the rules of war and became the foundation for modern international humanitarian law. It led to the trial and subsequent execution at the war's end of Henry Wirz, the commander at Andersonville, for conspiring "to impair the lives of Union prisoners." Northern prosecutors had hoped to charge top Confederate leadership, including President Jefferson Davis, in a series of postwar trials. In the end, Wirz was their only major conviction, because southern outrage and northern demands to forgive and forget brought an end to the legal effort. But Wirz's trial represented the origin of modern prosecution of war crimes.

"Military necessity," General Orders No. 100 directs, "does not admit of cruelty." In the Civil War's prison camps, it did just that. Yet the statement encodes an aspiration and an expectation, if not always an enforceable law. Born of Civil War suffering, international humanitarian law demands, as does Brundage's important book, that we recognize cruelty as a choice. *A*

*Both sides
believed
that any
sympathetic
act toward
the enemy
would
represent
an insult to
their own
soldiers.*

Drew Gilpin Faust is a contributing writer at The Atlantic and the Arthur Kingsley Porter University Research Professor and president emerita at Harvard. She is the author of This Republic of Suffering: Death and the American Civil War.



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HISTORICAL / GETTY

The Novel as Extended Op-Ed

If anyone could write good fiction about immigration, it would probably be Lionel Shriver. Instead, her latest book goes off the rails.

By Adelle Waldman

Few novelists today can match Lionel Shriver for topical range. The author of 18 books, she is best known for her 2003 novel, *We Need to Talk About Kevin*, about a teenager who murders several of his classmates. The nine novels that followed include a clever critique of the American health-care system (*So Much for That*, 2010), a family drama about the obesity epidemic (*Big Brother*, 2013), an economic dystopia (*The Mandibles*, 2016), a satiric look at the growing popularity of extreme endurance sports (*The Motion of the Body Through Space*, 2020), and an exploration of the social costs imposed by increased longevity (*Should We Stay or Should We Go*, 2021).

In her latest, *A Better Life*, Shriver tackles immigration and goes off the rails, which makes this an ideal moment to take stock of her novelistic gifts and ambitions. As her subjects suggest, she is not the kind of writer whose fiction features precious lyricism or pseudo-intellectual or solipsistic musings. She has a wry observational intelligence that propels her well beyond her personal orbit. She is also adept at unpacking psychological states and analyzing relationships with almost clinical incisiveness. Her writing is witty, and startlingly precise. *We Need to Talk About Kevin* describes a man as a “stringy cerebral type whose skittering metabolism burns chickpea concoctions at a ferocious rate.”

Shriver’s novels teem with well-chosen observations about ordinary life, the sort that some literary novels skip: whether characters watch what they eat; what exercise routine they favor (a disconcertingly large proportion of them do calisthenics daily); how long they stay when they visit; whether they dominate conversation or ask questions of others. She devises interesting plots too. Her protagonists *do* things, which is not to say they do outlandish or unbelievable things to facilitate crude plot twists.

Shriver tends to see the world as being divided between those who work hard and support others—both in their personal life and through the taxes they are forced to pay—and those who take advantage of such people. The characters who have her sympathy practice what the protagonist of her 2007 novel, *The Post-Birthday World*, calls “mental kindness.” That is, they try to be charitable in their assessments of others, even in the privacy of their thoughts. As a novelist, Shriver holds herself to the same standard. Her tone tends toward the caustic, and she doesn’t give central characters a pass when they behave badly, but she is fair to them. She shows us their reasons, even when they behave in ways that she clearly finds irritating, such as going all in on extreme endurance sports in their mid-60s.

Her more comic novels do, however, too often include one-dimensionally terrible minor characters (a pretentious filmmaker who mooches off her brother in *So Much for That*, a born-again woman who uses Christianity to feel superior to others in *The Motion of the Body Through Space*); they seem to exist only so Shriver can skewer them. But these take-downs of generally easy targets are atypical. Shriver focuses most of her fictional energies on characters who are more generously, and more plausibly, drawn and thus more deserving of her—and our—interest.

In her non-novelist capacity as, among other things, a columnist for the British magazine *The Spectator*, Shriver enjoys a reputation as a provocateur and a contrarian: economically conservative (“unenthusiastic about widespread dependency on the state,” as she once put it) while progressive in her social views, though anti-“woke” and critical of the #MeToo movement. Her decision to briefly wear a sombrero at a writers’ festival in 2016, to signal her disapproval of the then-faddish concept of “cultural appropriation,” caused a stir in literary circles.

But however controversial Shriver is as a commentator, her novels have never been mere vehicles for her politics. Take *The Mandibles*, a book that revolves around the national debt, long a bugbear of hers. This might seem a particularly wonkish fixation, unlikely to inspire even passable fiction, but Shriver—whether or not you agree with her views on the underlying macroeconomics (I don't)—delivers a clever pillorying of Americans' belief that our place at the top of the international hierarchy is both deserved and permanent. In the novel's near-future setting, the rest of the world abruptly decides that it will no longer underwrite the United States' debt. By the end of the book, the U.S. is just like any other developing country, and Mexicans speak derisively of white Ameritrash. The granularity of Shriver's vision reflects a mind as skilled at analyzing the reverberations of monetary policy in daily life as at depicting interiority. It also makes for a very entertaining read.

Which is to say that if any contemporary American novelist could write compelling fiction about immigration policy—perhaps the single most important issue in national politics—it would probably be Shriver. It's certainly very much like her to try. And it is unlike her to fall short on just about every count I've described. *A Better Life*, her new novel, fails not because its politics are out of step with progressive opinion. If that were sufficient to doom a novel, *The Mandibles* wouldn't have met with the praise it did a decade ago. Nor is the main problem that *A Better Life* reads like an op-ed column thinly disguised as a novel, although that's part of the trouble.

A BETTER LIFE tackles what Shriver portrays as the ruinous immigration policies of the Biden years. Nico, the book's 26-year-old protagonist, lives with his divorced mother, Gloria, rent-free in the well-appointed basement of his childhood home in Brooklyn (now worth \$2.5 million). He hasn't had a job since he graduated from college and spends his days scrolling through the right-coded precincts of the manosphere. An inheritance from his grandfather enables beer and takeout when the mood strikes. As the novel opens, he's bitterly relocating to his old, cramped bedroom upstairs: Gloria has decided to house a female asylum seeker in his former lair, through a city-sponsored program that Shriver apparently modeled on a plan floated but never enacted under former New York Mayor Eric Adams.

Having an immigrant boarder suits both Gloria's progressive politics and her pocketbook: The city will pay her more than \$3,000 a month. An artist who spends most of her time volunteering at a nearby makeshift shelter for immigrants, she can use the money. Nico's two sisters share their mother's heartfelt

pro-immigration views and support her decision. Nico does neither. But the step Gloria takes at least gives him a sense of purpose; already leaning toward a keep-them-out position, he becomes fixated on it.

He rails about progressive-run cities, such as New York, that promise new arrivals "free digs, free grub, and free Wi-Fi," perks guaranteed to ensure that yet more people keep coming. Sounding like a cranky 60-something, he complains about the state of bike lanes: "Their overwhelmingly Hispanic riders didn't glance over their shoulders before overtaking or signal when they were making a turn." Many of these bikers are out making deliveries, of course. (It's unclear why Nico thinks so many immigrants work these jobs when they are, according to him, given so many freebies by the city.)

In outline, the premise seems primed for satire: A young man who lives off his mother is obsessed with immigrants who he thinks are living off hardworking American taxpayers. Indeed, *A Better Life* is full of passages that read as if they are meant to be send-ups of blinkered ideologues: "Over tequila shots, Vernon launched into a set piece about how, while populations in the West were heading into gradual decline, Africa was the exception, certain to rise from 1.4 billion this year to 2.5 billion by midcentury."

But Vernon, a documentarian and a longtime friend of Nico's parents, is not drawn as a satirical figure; rather, we are intended to see him as bombastic but appealing—warm, gregarious, freethinking, and probably correct in his concern about Western decline. This tone deafness is characteristic of the novel, which seems to want to operate as a work of realist fiction dealing with people whose fates we're supposed to care about, no matter how thinly portrayed or unattractive they are.

Nico is the primary example, despite the twist Shriver offers on the stereotypical angry young male reactionary: He's not a jobless flyover-country type; he's a white man reared in the upper-middle-class meritocracy. A member of the coastal elite, he's been at once coddled and academically driven, only to then fail (thanks to DEI policies) to get into even an Ivy-adjacent school. But this is sociology, not psychology—as characterization, it's merely a starting point, as a novelist of Shriver's skill certainly knows.

The book never goes deeper. Nico's inner life is almost entirely devoted to thinking about immigration as a public crisis and about Martine, the Honduran asylum seeker who has moved into his mother's basement. Nor do his daily interactions prompt any sort of lively reflection. The bulk of the book's dialogue consists of long discussions of the issue initiated by Nico with whomever he encounters. Whatever merit the material might have as opinion-page filler, as conversation, it's leaden.

A BETTER LIFE

Lionel Shriver

HARPER

The book's plot is more compelling than its dialogue—but only because it's melodramatic. Martine turns out to have some troubling associates, who first make themselves at home in the household and then commandeer it. As Martine taunts Nico: “Other people take your nice country, they take your nice soft life. Because you no fight.” The situation comes to a head when Nico does try to fight back.

Picture him in concert with a bunch of late-middle-age white men (including his father and Vernon) in ski masks, toting guns; a dead body; an unreliable witness to the crime—I'll stop here, though there's more. The climactic conclusion is action-packed, yes, but getting invested is hard when the characters are little more than mouthpieces in service to a pat homeland-in-danger metaphor—prolix zealots like Nico and Vernon, naive progressives like Gloria, and opportunistic new arrivals ready to seize their moment when she throws her doors wide open.

Perhaps Shriver envisioned the book's exploration of Nico's frustration as a warning to liberals—a novelization of one of those “this is how we got Trump” articles. But prescient it is not: In the current moment, *A Better Life* reads like a dour morality tale from a bygone civilization, one in which Americans never imagined they'd be reeling at images of masked ICE agents pulling day laborers off the streets. If you fed ChatGPT a Fox News segment about criminal immigrants and the progressive politicians who enable them and instructed it to come up with a Lionel Shriver novel, I'm not sure the result would be much worse. The book's only mystery, really, is that a writer of Shriver's talent bothered to churn it out, however up in arms she may have been about the nation's immigration policies.

THOUGH PUNCTURING liberal pieties on a subject like this one is certainly on-brand for Shriver, the newsy subjects that have served as catalysts for her fiction have generally operated as springboards, not destinations—a way into stories that are fundamentally character-driven and focused on relationships. *A Better Life* doesn't just call attention to the inadequacy of topicality on its own to propel a novel; its failure serves as a reminder of Shriver's true strength.

She has excelled at more than the deft depiction of inner life, a staple of successful domestic fiction. She is one of the most astute portraitists of marriage working today. The long-term potential as well as the perils of intimacy were central themes even in her debut novel, *The Female of the Species* (1987). When Shriver wrote of *The Post-Birthday World*'s protagonist that “having a man who loved her and whom she loved in return was the most important thing in Irina's life,” she described a disposition shared by many of her

main characters, most notably Eva Khatchadourian, the narrator of her signature work, *We Need to Talk About Kevin*. On its face a compassionate exploration of post-Columbine sociopathic darkness, it is also a brutally poignant story of a marriage.

Eva's romance with her husband, Franklin Plaskett, delights and amazes her. Very mixed feelings about motherhood kick in when she gets pregnant—and it doesn't help that Kevin is a difficult baby and then boy. For a good portion of the novel, readers are apt to tack back and forth on the questions that explicitly animate it: Is Eva's ambivalence the reason Kevin turned out as he did? Was she not loving enough? Or was Kevin just born that way—and the social tendency to blame mothers prompts us to find fault in Eva?

What makes the novel so unusual, however, is that its most emotionally compelling drama is submerged, and is one that Eva herself never fully recognizes: Her attachment to the marriage is doing profound damage, forcing her to choose between Franklin's affection and her ability to speak truthfully about what she sees, what she fears. If she isn't a good mother, it's not because she doesn't love Kevin enough—it's because she loves her husband too much, and he can't or won't acknowledge that there is anything worrisome about their son.

Subtle, painful, with central characters who are both slippery and beautifully drawn, the book manages one of fiction's most elusive feats. It seduces us into viewing the world as Eva does, only to then show us that we, too, have fallen prey to a willful ignorance of the rot in a marriage she values so much.

Shriver has written other original novels about marriage and family. But *We Need to Talk About Kevin* stands out for its elegant construction; the cool austerity of its prose, which is intimate without being cloying or chatty; and its sheer narrative power. Its artful evocation of self-deception recalls 20th-century classics about marriage such as Richard Yates's *Revolutionary Road* and Edward Albee's *Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf?*

To pull off something close to pure ventriloquism, leaving Eva's perspective and mood to dictate the tone, as Shriver does, is the sort of imaginative triumph that is a rarity for any author, as she knows. In *The Mandibles*, a young man sees that his 90-something great-aunt, a formerly famous writer, is unhappy, and he speculates as to why. “You want to write with the same fire that lit you up when you were writing *Better Late Than*,” he says, naming her unmatched novel. And then he finishes the thought: “the kind of fire that hardly anyone gets to keep.” *A*

Adelle Waldman is the author, most recently, of the novel Help Wanted.

Puncturing liberal pieties is on-brand for Shriver, but newsy subjects have generally operated as springboards, not destinations, for her fiction.

ESSAY

The Secrets of Indigenous Art

*Major exhibits are upending the way people understand
Native American and Aboriginal artists.*

By Susan Tallman



Every student of modern art knows how European and American avant-gardists of the early 20th century had their world rocked by Indigenous art—how they swooned over and strove to imitate the dynamic concision they saw in ethnographic exhibitions. How Picasso launched Cubism by sticking African masks on French prostitutes in *Les Femmes d'Alger*. How Marsden Hartley



paved his way to abstraction with tepees and Native American symbols. How Jackson Pollock started painting on the floor after seeing a demonstration of Navajo sand painters at the Museum of Modern Art in 1941.

Generally overlooked in Art History 101 was the inverse: how European materials and images were repurposed by Indigenous artists. That 1941 MoMA show was full of ancient Native objects, along with recent work that adhered closely to historic examples. (The catalog advised readers that “Good Indian work, done without the interference of whites, includes restrained colors as well as bright ones, and usually leans to economy rather than complexity of design.”) As with MoMA’s earlier shows of African and folk art, American Indian art merited inclusion in a museum of modernism not because it *was* modern, but because it offered inspiration to a Euro-American avant-garde. Somehow, modernist aping of Indigenous models got told as a story of increasing originality, while Indigenous adaptation of Western models was seen in terms of decreasing authenticity. The logic was clear enough: The proper job of Western art was forever to point to the future; that of Indigenous art was forever to repeat the past.

It has taken a century for the art world to realize its mistake, but contemporary Indigenous art is now having a moment. Major museums are mounting exhibitions of recent Aboriginal art from Australia and Native art from the Americas. In the imposing nine-pound book *Tōi Te Mana: An Indigenous History of Māori Art*, the art historian Ngarino Ellis writes enthusiastically of a new “global Indigenous art world.” Its advent was clear at the 2024 Venice Biennale, which featured Māori artists from New Zealand, Kaqchikel artists from Guatemala, and Nonuya artists from Colombia. The Australian pavilion’s award-winning installation interwove personal genealogy with 65,000 years of Aboriginal history. The Brazilian pavilion was renamed the Hãhãwpuá pavilion by Tupinambá artists, and the Danish pavilion was relabeled Kalaallit Nunaat (the Greenlandic name for Greenland) by the photographer Inuuteq Storch. The U.S. pavilion

kept its name, but its mini-Monticello exterior was swathed from pavement to cornice in the eye-popping geometries of the Choctaw/Cherokee artist Jeffrey Gibson, the first Native American to fill the building with a solo exhibition.

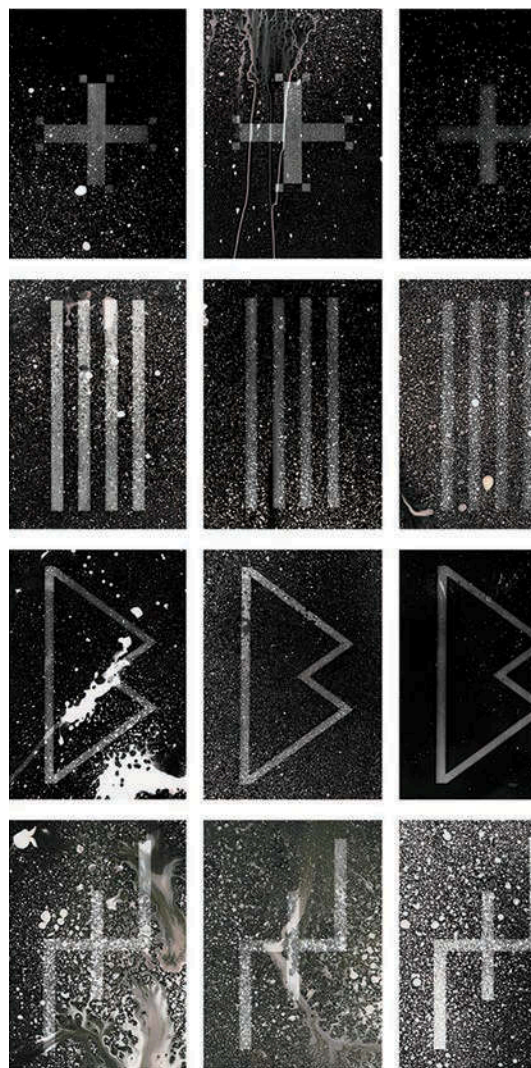
Gibson, whose statues of anthropomorphized animals in Native regalia are currently holding court on the facade of the Metropolitan Museum of Art in New York City, is one of the world’s most visible artists. A MacArthur fellow, admired by critics and popular with the art-going public, he has used his platform to normalize the idea of “an Indigenous present.” The phrase, designed to disrupt the equation of *Indigenous* with *cultural stasis*, forms the title for both his compendium of contemporary Native art, published in 2023, and a new traveling exhibition of Native abstraction that opened at the Institute of Contemporary Art in Boston last fall, before heading to the Frist Museum in Nashville and the Frye Museum in Seattle.

Rambunctious and enticing, the book consists of 450 pages packed with images of works by 60 artists—running the gamut from sassy conceptualism to enigmatic video stills, and from the lyrical painting of Jaune Quick-to-See Smith to Wendy Red Star’s photographic self-portrait as a diorama Indian with an inflatable elk. There is no obvious chronological or typological order to the presentation, nor any of the usual scholarly overviews. The title page doesn’t arrive until page 35.

The “Indigenous Present” exhibition, by contrast, feels almost stately—six dozen works by 15 artists, gracefully laid out in spacious galleries. Given the rubric of abstraction, the Indigenous references don’t jump out the way they do in Red Star’s photograph, but they make themselves felt through what the Cree artist Kimowan Metchewais called “live relics”—attributes of a culture that run beneath the surface, animating everything.

Previous pages: *Kam*, 1991,
Emily Kam Ngwarray. This page: *So’ II*
(*Stars II*), 2022, Dakota Mace.

THE OLDEST and oddest works in the show are the “personality prints” (actually triptych drawings) by Mary Sully, who was born in 1896 and died in 1963. Made in the decades before World War II, they depict their subjects in riddle-like sequences that progress from streamlined emblems to decorative patterns. The one dedicated to the aviator Beryl Markham, for example, begins with a cusp of blue water bookended by a pair of coastlines and matching female silhouettes—a tidy graphic summa of Markham’s record-breaking 1936 Atlantic crossing. Below it, a second drawing adapts those elements into a moiré pattern, suggesting both pistons and waves; the third drawing crystallizes the theme with interlocking polygons. Precisely delineated with colored pencil, Sully’s pictures look simultaneously naive and urbanely sophisticated. They echo



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flapper-era print ads and Art Deco posters and fabric design, as well as the kind of modernist abstract painting she would have encountered while living in New York City, along with the Dakota quillwork she would have learned as a child on the Standing Rock Reservation in South Dakota.

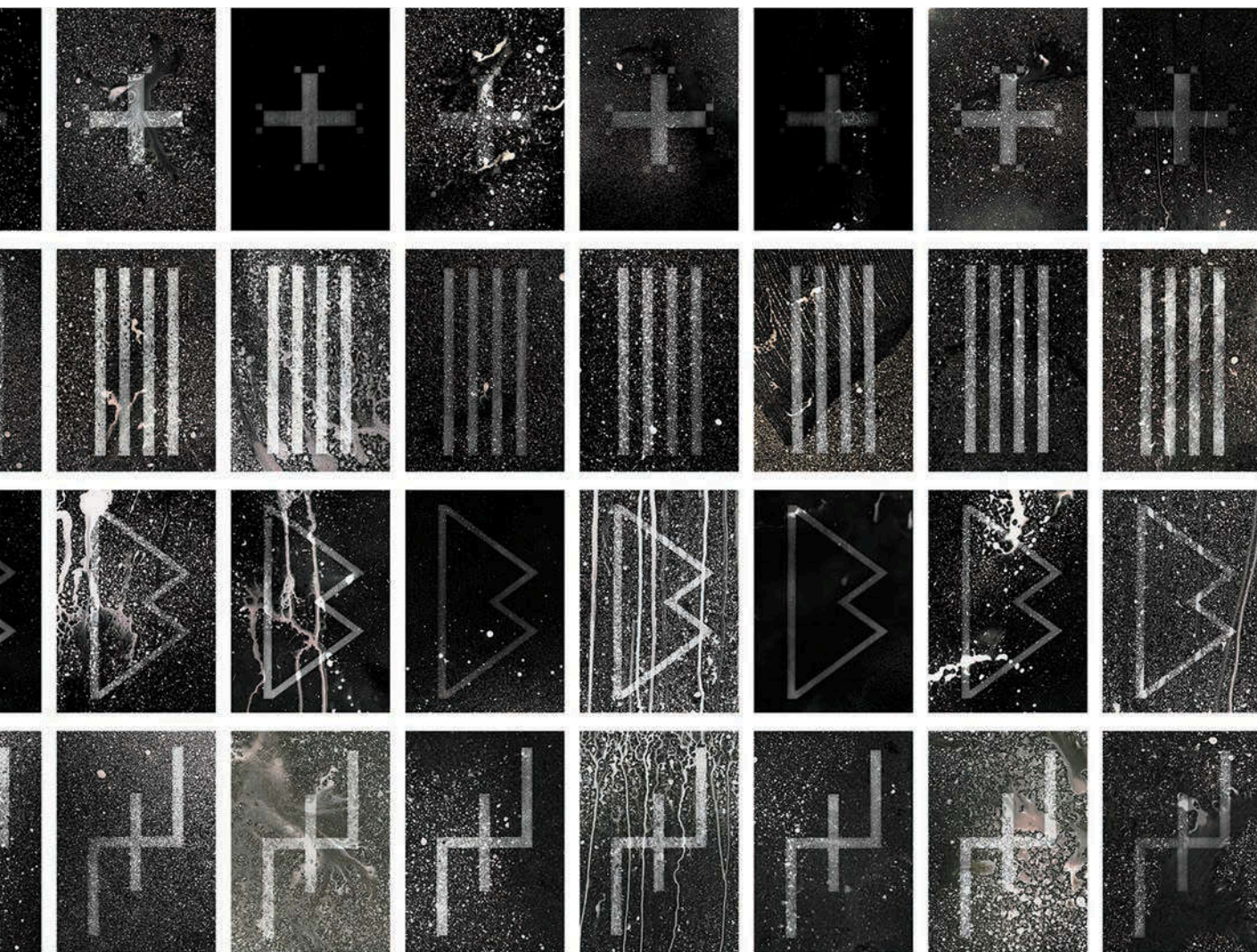
Sully, whose real name was Susan Deloria, was both the great-granddaughter of the English-born painter Thomas Sully (it's his portrait of Andrew Jackson that glowers at us from \$20 bills) and the great-aunt of the Harvard historian Philip Deloria, whose 2019 book, *Becoming Mary Sully*, first brought her to public attention. A reserved and seemingly fragile person—Deloria calls her “an Indian soulmate to Emily Dickinson”—she never exhibited her work, and we have no idea what her aims were. Her subjects were an eclectic bunch: Bob Ripley (he of “Believe It or

Not”), Gertrude Stein (who got rows of roses), the polar explorer Admiral Byrd. It's hard to cast them all in the same play, maybe because they interested her less as people than as prompts. What seems to have motivated, even delighted, her was not representation but transformation—the transition from real life to geometry, from the anecdotal to the eternal.

Unseen for most of a century, Sully's drawings can hardly be called influential, but in their multipart format, physical modesty, and casual interlacing of pop culture and Native references, they anticipate much of the show's later work. The hefty paper sheets of Metchewais's *Luther (Striped Man)* (2003) climb the wall with the erratic logic of a Post-it brainstorming session. Creased here and there from previous folding, they are stained rust red and nicotine yellow, and several carry the

photographic image of a standing figure shrouded in black-and-white-striped fabric. It has the playfulness of a sheet ghost, Op Art style, while recalling old photographs of Native leaders wrapped in chiefs' blankets. Taped together on the front rather than the back, Metchewais's constructions—he called them “paper walls”—wear their contingency on the surface, keeping open the possibility of other potential arrangements, other ways of connecting.

Almost everybody here has been to art school. Walking through the galleries, you can draw connections to Pop Art or Conceptualism or Bay Area Funk and not be wrong. One room features the familiar minimalist format of near-identical objects arranged in grids, where the viewer's task is to recognize the conceptual rule underlying their slight differences.



Each of the 27 paintings from Kay WalkingStick's *Chief Joseph Series* (1974–76) carries four sliced-arc shapes in various arrangements, but the title directs attention not to abstract concepts but to a real person: the Nez Percé leader who guided his followers on a 1,000-mile trek in pursuit of self-determination. Suddenly those sliced arcs begin to look like strung bows, and her muted palette begins to feel like an elegy. Similarly, the angular shapes that repeat across Dakota Mace's 80 chemigrams (created by painting photo developer and other materials onto light-sensitive paper) are Diné symbols, linking land and lore.

For an exhibition of serious contemporary art, "An Indigenous Present" feels uncommonly light on its feet. These grid-ded installations lay claim to a lot of real estate, but the objects they are built from could fit in a backpack. Sully's oeuvre spent decades in a suitcase. Untaped and folded, Metchewais's "walls" could be carried under an arm. Such rejections of monumentality are not rare in contemporary art, but they usually appear as a reaction against what came before—a swerve away from the bombast of Expressionism, the

hard shells of Minimalism, the slickness of Pop. What you see in "An Indigenous Present," however, feels less like refutation than a willing handshake with the past—but it's a different past.

INDIGENEITY IS by definition site-specific—a statement of cultural continuity between a particular place and its people for time out of mind. Discussions of a "global Indigenous art world" thus raise the question of what a Choctaw/Cherokee MacArthur fellow working in the Hudson Valley and an illiterate Anmatyerr woman working in Australia's Central Desert might have in common. The obvious answer is a shared legacy of colonial dispossession, racism, and cultural condescension, and plenty of Indigenous art calls out injustice in explicit terms.

But that's not the central focus of "An Indigenous Present," nor of the expansive survey "The Stars We Do Not See: Australian Indigenous Art," organized by the National Gallery of Victoria, which opened its North American tour at the National Gallery in Washington, D.C., in November. And it was nowhere to be seen in the retrospective that Tate Modern in London

recently devoted to the groundbreaking Aboriginal painter Emily Kam Kngwarray.

Kngwarray was a phenomenon. Born sometime between 1910 and 1914, she grew up foraging, hunting, and sleeping in grass shelters. She remembered her first sight of a "whitefeller." (She ran away.) She spoke little English and learned to write her signature only when it was time to endorse her pension checks. For most of her life, her artistic gifts were exercised in body painting and drawing in the sand—crucial elements of the ceremonies through which Aboriginal culture has been maintained down the millennia. But in 1977, Utopia Station, the tiny settlement where she had learned to write her name, began classes in batik, the Indonesian process of using hot wax on fabric as a dye-resist, with the goal of helping Aboriginal women earn money through handicrafts. (Funding agencies doubted the capacity of Aboriginal women for such fine work. They needn't have worried, as the luminous silks teeming with squiggles, dots, and flattened lizards at Tate Modern showed.) Kngwarray was in her late 70s when she began working with acrylic, and in her final eight years, she produced



COURTESY OF THE MARTINELLI ARTISTS, NEUMAN. PHOTO: PREDEAG CANCAR / NGV.
NATIONAL GALLERY OF VICTORIA, MELBOURNE, FELTON BEQUEST, 2011. © THE ARTISTS.

thousands of paintings, some the size of a school bus. Video footage shows her dabbing paint insistently on canvases laid out on the ground. As the global audience for Aboriginal art grew, she emerged as a star. A year after her death, Kngwarray's work was in the 1997 Venice Biennale. Today it can be seen cladding a Qantas 787 Dreamliner in giant red webs and white spots.

For non-Australian viewers, the Tate show was a revelation. Juddering across her 1991 painting *Kam*, spots of color—yellow, white, ochre—cluster and disperse amid darkness. The canvas is nearly 10 feet long and 4.5 feet tall but feels bigger, as if it stretched not just side to side and up and down but also back in space and even time. It is a knock-your-socks-off painting, engrossing and peculiar. The only visual analogues that spring to mind for its inchoate choreography are Hubble Space Telescope images of cosmic clouds and nascent nebulae, unimaginably distant and impossibly large. Read the label, though, and you find the picture rooted to the ground: In Kngwarray's native Anmatyerr language, *kam* is the name for the tiny seeds and seedpods of the pencil yam for which she was named, a vital resource for Aboriginal people in Australia's Central Desert. Limitless space collapses into something small, local, and edible.

"The Stars We Do Not See" includes photography, video, and conceptual art, but what makes it astonishing is the breadth of painting produced by Aboriginal artists over the past 50 years. After centuries of images that were either ephemeral (body painting; drawing in loose earth) or immovable (rock art), numerous Aboriginal groups in the 1970s and '80s began making things that white audiences could recognize as art. In Arnhem Land in the Northern Territory, artists expanded the

practice of bark painting, using hand-ground ochre to portray loose-jointed human figures. In the Western Desert settlement of Papunya, they worked with industrially made boards and paints to create pictures in which arrays of dots nestle and collide. In Utopia Station, they started with batik. Most compositions run edge-to-edge with interwoven lines, wavering zigzags, or fields of dots dancing over and under other shapes. There are no horizons, no evidence for up or down. Why would there be in imagery that arose from the practice of drawing on the ground?

In the context of Tate Modern or the National Gallery's East Building, it is tempting to see echoes of Western post-war abstraction—early Philip Guston, late Larry Poons, Brice Marden in his tangled-line phase—but those references would have been as alien to Kngwarray or Papunya artists as the experience of foraging for yams is to most of us. Whatever we may think we are seeing, they were not painting "abstractions"; they were painting "Country."

That word, capitalized, appears 212 times in the Kngwarray catalog and 189 times in "The Stars We Do Not See" catalog, but its meaning remains elusive. It can refer to the native territory of a people, or more broadly to "the lands, salt and fresh waters, the subterranean and the cosmos to which they are connected," the curator Kimberley Moulton writes. Inseparable from the ancestral stories called Dreamings, it also encompasses "law, place, custom, languages, spiritual belief, cultural practice, family and identity." With such an extensive crib sheet, all kinds of things can be read into these images—cracked earth, reflected light on water, night skies, ecological awareness, metaphysics.

The enormous painting that greets visitors to the National Gallery show, *Ngayartu Kujarra* (2009), is mostly occupied by a single white shape, wobbly at the edges, some 13 feet long and seven feet high. Around the white, patches of variegated color swell and thin in the way littoral landscapes do—a scrubby green bit here, a sandy pink bit there, a shoal-like shape pushing up into the whiteness. The intimation of topography is confirmed by the label: *Ngayartu Kujarra* is the Punmu

name for a seasonal salt lake also known as Lake Dora. The large blue dots that appear at the edge of the composition are sacred watering holes in the surrounding desert.

The canvas—a collaborative project by 12 Punmu women—was painted over the course of a week on-site, outdoors, in 118-degree heat. Led by a "senior custodian" of Punmu culture, the women sang, then walked onto the canvas to paint. When they finished, they laid the canvas on the lake's crusted-salt surface, where it was celebrated with further song and dance. Finally, the National Gallery of Victoria reports, it was taken inside, and a last white coat was added "because it was too dirty from all of the dogs and cups of tea and little kids touching it."

The curators are keen to educate visitors about Aboriginal life and worldviews. Wall panels offer primers on the central role of Country and Dreamings. Photographs show landscapes whose patchy growth patterns reverberate through the paintings. Videos let us hear the languages being spoken. But there are limits to what is being shared, we are informed. In Aboriginal societies, access to certain knowledge, designs, and even pigments may be restricted by age, gender, genealogy, or status within the community. Some of this is negotiable (initially the painters were all men), but much is not.

Maintaining these constraints in a world of oral transmission is one thing, but paintings can be carried anywhere and seen by anyone. While many artists saw painting as a way of keeping their culture alive for younger generations who may or may not live in their historic Country, traditionalists worried about how geographic or spiritual information appeared and what outside audiences were told.

All of this required invention. One reason for all of those dots, scholars have suggested, might be that they act a bit like pebble glass in a bathroom, diffusing without denying that which should not be shared. In addition to finding pictorial solutions to the problems of protected knowledge, Aboriginal artists needed to create a new language to translate the social, performative, and transient experience of ceremonies into the step-back, stand-still experience of a picture hung on

Ngayartu Kujarra, 2009, a collaborative painting by 12 Punmu women: Jakayu Biljabu, Yikartu Bumba, Doreen Chapman, May Chapman, Nyanjilpayi Nancy Chapman, Linda James, Donna Loxton, Mulyatingki Marney, Reena Rogers, Beatrice Simpson, Ronelle Simpson, and Muntararr Rosie Williams

a wall. Like artists everywhere, they were navigating between inherited cultures and present-day opportunities. The Yolngu artist Nonggirnga Marawili painted on tubes made of rolled bark, a form that imitates the hollow logs once used by the Yolngu as ossuaries. Her grid designs refer both to a network of water holes and to the fish traps of ancestral hunters, but their magenta hues come from recycled toner cartridges. The 12 Punmu women were inspired to make their painting of Lake Dora after seeing it from a plane.

IT WOULD be foolish to make broad statements about Indigenous art on the basis of three exhibitions. But one thing that seemed distinctive—a contrast to the general tenor of contemporary art on other floors in the same buildings—was the solicitousness with which the artists approached their cultural inheritance. Western art likes to move forward by rebelling against its parents. Never mind that it does so through old-fashioned means, such as oil on canvas and cast metal: The rhetoric is one of rupture. In these shows, the rhetoric is different—neither rejection nor blind adherence to tradition, but simply respect, and an affirmation of a vital and lasting universe.

One of the mesmerizing works in “An Indigenous Present” is Audie Murray’s video installation *Bear Smudge* (2022). For most of its 30-minute run time, all you see is a field of flickering pastels, like a glitchy, pixelated Monet landscape. You can hear wind, shuffling footsteps, and what sounds like the striking of a match. Sometimes a distinctive motion within the static hints at the presence of a person. The wall text explains that you’re watching the artist perform a ceremony after smearing bear grease on the camera lens. What exactly she is doing on the other side of that bear grease is not explained, though anyone who has binge-watched *Reservation Dogs* or *Resident Alien* may recognize the practice of wafting cleansing

smoke, and it’s easy enough to look up Native American smudging rituals on your phone. Objects spread out on the gallery floor offer clues, but the game of deduction is far less engaging than the scintillating field on the wall.

The visual effect is oddly reminiscent of Kngwarrray’s *Kam*. Both convey a sense of particles in motion and of events taking place below the surface—some organizing engine hovering just out of view. The video and the painting were made in different centuries on opposite ends of the Earth, but they walk the same delicate line

*Nonggirnga
Marawili’s grid designs
refer to water
holes and the fish traps
of ancestral hunters,
but their magenta
hues come from recycled
toner cartridges.*

between making something visible and making it clear. Both artists were creating work that they knew would be seen by viewers unversed in their traditions and perhaps unmoored from the very idea of reverence.

Talking about his “Indigenous Present” exhibition, Jeffrey Gibson posed a set of questions rare in the usual run of contemporary art: “What is meant to be seen? How do you protect something? How do you transform something so you can share it, but not reveal it?” Most spiritual

traditions—Indigenous and otherwise—restrict access to the sacred. But even beyond religious mystery, it can be salutary to be reminded of the existence of things beyond your ken. The title of “The Stars We Do Not See” was inspired by the Yolngu concept of “the stars behind the stars”—everything that exists yet escapes perception.

“It turns out,” Metchewais wrote in a 2009 Facebook post, “the thing in the modern world that most matches the Indian psyche is the web.” This might seem a reach, but as the technology historian James Gleick pointed out in a recent essay, Tim Berners-Lee’s crucial insight in creating the web was that “what matters is not objects but relationships.” The observation made me think of the 12 women working together on the huge salt-lake painting, and of Sully’s drawings, where what happens between each section feels more meaningful than what happens within any given one. In the “Indigenous Present” book, the curator Candice Hopkins argues that modernists missed the point by adopting the look of Indigenous objects while doing “away with any social role of that cultural belonging.” It occurred to me that if you relocate Gibson’s question about how to share and yet protect something, you have the essential conundrum of the internet age.

The art world is a fickle place. Inevitably the buzz around Indigenous art will fade away. The art itself, however, is likely to remain—not because of any high-minded notion of equal representation in institutional settings, or even for the window it opens onto worlds we may not know, but because of the light it shines on the one we’re all in. *A*

Susan Tallman, a contributing writer at The Atlantic, is an art historian and the author, most recently, of Kerry James Marshall: The Complete Prints: 1976–2022.

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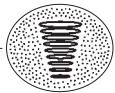


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By Caleb
Madison

Warning: This crossword puzzle starts easy, but gets devilishly hard as you descend into its depths. See which circle you can reach before you abandon all hope.

ACROSS

- 1 Words repeated at the altar
- 4 Scottish "no"
- 7 The Big Apple
- 9 Certain unit on a nutrition label
- 10 Puts to work
- 11 Unsuccessful attempts
- 14 *The Odyssey* or *Doctor Zhivago*
- 15 2024's highest-paid athlete
- 19 Throw off track
- 20 Arboreal soldiers at the Battle of Isengard
- 21 Matchmaking site available in Hebrew
- 22 Schadenfreude, for one
- 24 Dashboard dial: abbr.
- 25 Legendarily rich king
- 29 Concentrate in a hookah, maybe
- 30 Minute
- 31 Back muscle, for short
- 32 Broke
- 35 Double-____
- 36 They might back up an argument
- 37 Presb., e.g.
- 38 Squash, for one
- 41 It might accompany draft picks?
- 43 In
- 44 Toast
- 45 *El número más solitario*
- 46 ID first issued in 1936

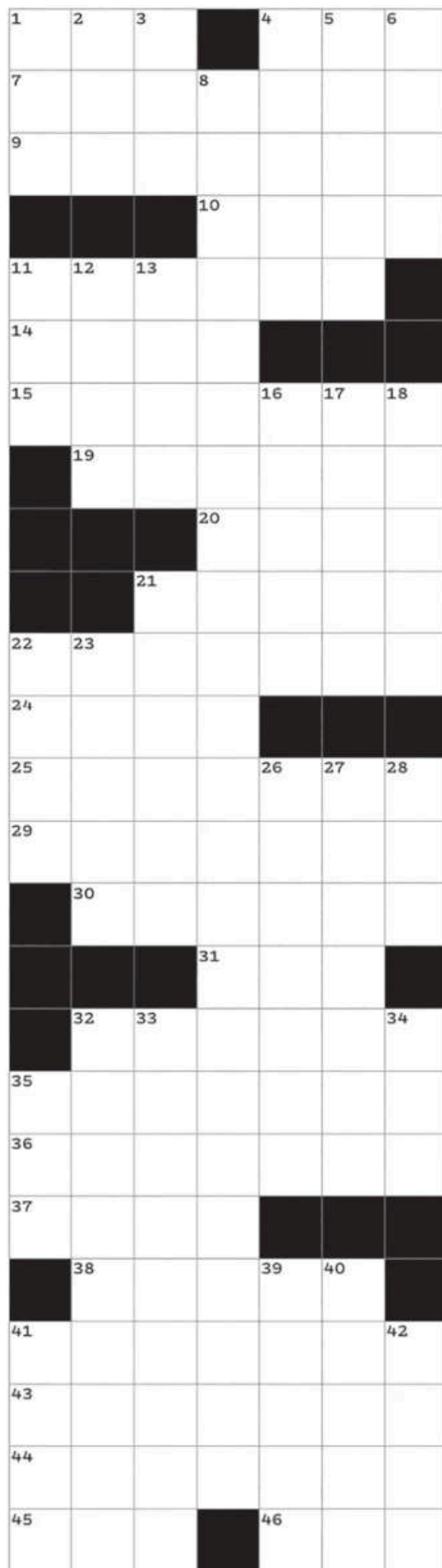
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DOWN

- 1 Abbreviation after many company names
- 2 Anti-narcotics org.
- 3 Bird associated with wisdom
- 4 Like Odin and Thor
- 5 Zodiac sign symbolized by a ram
- 6 ____ out (scrapes up)
- 8 "Do NOT sneak up on me like that!"
- 11 Prefix for *maid* or *man*
- 12 Device that featured a click wheel
- 13 The opposite divided by the hypotenuse, in trigonometry
- 16 Hawaiian island that neighbors Maui
- 17 "Same!"
- 18 Either star of *New York Minute*
- 21 Full of merriment
- 22 Set in stone?
- 23 *The Death of* ____ (Jacques-Louis David painting)
- 26 Singer with a famous song about 7-Across
- 27 Its NYSE symbol is *X*
- 28 Lacking
- 32 Do business?
- 33 2000s-TV son known for his existential crisis
- 34 License to drill?
- 35 Biggest player?
- 39 They might get pitched
- 40 Foofaraws
- 41 *Baduizm* singer
- 42 Actor Bruce or Laura



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